

JPC reviews key constitutional bills during Delhi visit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) on Wednesday met Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the Delhi Secretariat and briefed the Chief Minister on the objectives, key provisions, and proposed changes contained in the three Bills. The visit forms part of the committee's ongoing consultations and study process before finalising its recommendations on the three Bills currently under examination. The proposed legislation is expected to play a significant role in shaping future governance frameworks, accountability mechanisms, and constitutional processes in the country. The committee, chaired by Member of Parliament Aparajita Sarangi, is examining the Constitution (130th



Amendment) Bill, 2025, the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation (Amendment) Bill, 2025, and the Union Territories Government (Amendment) Bill, 2025. The JPC also handed over copies of the proposed legislation and related documents to the Chief Minister. According to the committee, the proposed amendments are aimed at strengthening accountability and

transparency in public life, reinforcing constitutional values, and enhancing public confidence in democratic institutions. The meeting brought together several Members of Parliament from across party lines. Apart from Chairperson Aparajita Sarangi, those present included Dr K Laxman, Ujjwal Nikam, DK Aruna, Parshottam Rupala,

Asaduddin Owaisi, Dr Indra Hang Subba, Anurag Thakur, Brij Lal, Brijmohan Agrawal, and Manan Kumar Mishra. Senior officials from the Lok Sabha Secretariat also attended the discussions. Welcoming the committee, the Chief Minister highlighted the importance of public trust, accountability, and ethical conduct in a democratic system. She said the strength of Indian democracy depends not only on constitutional provisions but also on maintaining transparency and credibility in governance. During the interaction, the Chief Minister briefed the committee on Delhi's administrative structure, its unique constitutional position, and the measures being undertaken by the Delhi Government to improve governance standards. She said the Government is working

to build a transparent, accountable, and citizen-focused administrative framework. The Chief Minister noted that strengthening democratic institutions and public confidence in governance is a shared responsibility. She said efforts to improve accountability and transparency in public life are essential for ensuring effective governance and maintaining trust between citizens and institutions. Speaking about the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, the Chief Minister said the proposal seeks to further strengthen public confidence in individuals holding public office. She described the proposed amendments under consideration as an important step towards reinforcing constitutional morality, accountability, and trans-

parency in public affairs. She also said that the suggestions and input received by the committee during its consultations would help strengthen democratic institutions and improve governance systems. According to her, continuous dialogue, consultation, and reforms are necessary for the healthy growth of democracy. After the meeting, Sarangi interacted with media and said the committee has held 11 meetings so far and visited nine states and Union Territories, including Rajasthan, Haryana, Delhi, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Punjab. Sarangi said that the stakeholders extended support to the bill and also submitted some written comments and suggestions. The joint committee was constituted in November 2025 to examine the Bills.

CM issues Flood Control Order 2026, makes Nodal officers accountable for waterlogging

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday issued the Flood Control Order-2026 at a high-level apex committee meeting at the Delhi Secretariat. High-level sector committees have been constituted under Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Ashish Sood, and Manjinder Singh Sirsa, each including three to four District Magistrates responsible for flood management and coordination in their areas.

nisms, operational plans, machinery deployment, and control room contact details. She directed all departments to keep teams on alert and prepared for emergencies, with relief and rescue equipment inspected according to prescribed checklists, and adequate arrangements made for safe evacuation in the event of flooding. PWD and other departments were directed to inspect all permanent pump houses and deploy mobile pumps in waterlogging-prone areas. Officials informed the



Bishnoi Gang associates held for firing outside gym linked to Guru Randhawa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Crime Branch arrested two alleged associates of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang for allegedly opening fire outside a gym linked to Punjabi singer Guru Randhawa in Delhi's Paschim Vihar earlier this month. One of the accused had returned from Russia less than two weeks before the incident, police said on Wednesday. The accused, identified as Arman (19) and Tushar alias Tashu alias Pinku (21), both residents of Haryana's Sonapat district, were arrested from Bahadurgarh following a manhunt. Investigators alleged that the duo worked as shooters for gangster Anil Pandit, a member of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang who is believed to be operating from the United States. According to police, two motorcycle-borne assailants opened fire outside a gym located on Outer Ring Road in Paschim Vihar at around 4 am on June 11 before fleeing the spot. No injuries were reported in the inci-



dent, though seven empty cartridges were recovered from the scene. A case was registered at the Paschim Vihar East police station. The firing attracted widespread attention after a social media post allegedly made by Anil Pandit went viral, claiming responsibility for the attack on behalf of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang. Police said the post suggested the gym was targeted because of its alleged association with Randhawa and referred to the singer's purported proximity to Bollywood actor Salman Khan, who the Bishnoi gang has repeatedly threatened in the past. Given the suspected organised crime angle, the investigation was trans-

ferred to the Crime Branch. Officers reconstructed the escape route of the shooters, analysed technical evidence and tracked their movements across nearly 100 kilometres. The probe led investigators to four suspects, Sahil, Sagar, Arman and Tushar. Acting on specific inputs, police conducted raids in Bahadurgarh on June 15 and arrested Arman and Tushar. During interrogation, both allegedly confessed to their role in the firing, police said. Investigators said Arman is a cousin of the two absconding suspects, Sahil and Sagar. Tushar had recently returned from Russia, where he had been working after travelling on a study visa. Police alleged that shortly after his return, he came in contact with Sahil and Sagar and became part of the conspiracy. Both accused have been remanded to police custody. Police said efforts are underway to apprehend the remaining suspects, identify other members of the network and recover the firearm used in the attack.

Delhi BJP holds cleanliness drives across all 256 mandals, ministers lead campaigns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's BJP Government and party leadership on Wednesday rolled out a city-wide cleanliness campaign covering all 256 organisational mandals of the capital. The campaign was started to mark 12 years of the Modi Government. Led by Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra, party MPs, Delhi ministers, MLAs, state office bearers and Delhi Government ministers participated in the campaign held in 256 blocks across the capital. Malhotra, accompanied by local BJP MLA Abhay Verma, launched the campaign near Laxmi Nagar metro station and said that everyone should take a pledge to avoid littering. Malhotra said that when Prime Minister Modi took the oath for the first time in 2014, he emphasised cleanliness, which has now become a people's movement. Cabinet Ministers Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Kapil Mishra, and Pankaj Kumar



Singh leading drives in Model Town, Kalkaji, and Najafgarh, respectively. Meanwhile, Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra said 3,500 cleanliness points have been identified across the city under the campaign called "Seva Hi Sangathan." Sirsa joined a cleanliness drive in the Model Town Assembly constituency alongside local MLA Ashok Goel, councillors, and residents, cleaning parks and public spaces. Kapil Mishra, participating in a cleanliness and plantation drive in Kalkaji along-

side South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, used the occasion to address the ongoing opposition signature campaign on the O-Zone issue. Health and Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh, who participated in a drive at Sai Baba Mandir in Najafgarh with MP Kamaljeet Sehrawat, linked cleanliness directly to public health. Delhi Jal Board Vice Chairman Satish Upadhyay and MLA Kartar Singh Tanwar swept the floor and railings at the Katyayani Devi temple and dharamshala in Chhatarpur.

CROSS COUNTRY HOTELS LIMITED

Regd. Off.: Cross Country Heritage Hotel, Mukand Garh Fort, Mukundgarh, Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, India-333 705 CIN: L55101RJ1990PLC013744 Email Id: sales@crosscountry.co.in Website: www.crosscountry.co.in

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that 35th Annual General Meeting of Members of the company for Financial Year 2022-23 has been fixed for Monday, the 13th day of July, 2026 at 2.00 P.M. to 3.00 P.M. at Shri Ashwiniyayak Dham, Dundlod road Railway Station Mukundgarh Dist. Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan to transact the business detailed in the Notice of the Meeting, which was dispatched to the members individually.

Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made there under and Clause 16 of the Listing Agreement with Stock Exchange, Notice is also given that the Register of Members and Share Transfer Register shall remain closed from Monday, 6th July, 2026 to Monday 13th July, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of the Annual General Meeting.

Place: New Delhi Date: 18.06.2026

By the order of the Board For Cross Country Hotels Limited

(Ishan Rai Juneja) (Director) DIN: 06410313

CROSS COUNTRY HOTELS LIMITED

Regd. Off.: Cross Country Heritage Hotel, Mukand Garh Fort, Mukundgarh, Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, India-333 705 CIN: L55101RJ1990PLC013744 Email Id: sales@crosscountry.co.in Website: www.crosscountry.co.in

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that 33rd Annual General Meeting of Members of the company for Financial Year 2022-23 has been fixed for Monday, the 13th day of July, 2026 at 11.00 A.M. to 12.00 P.M. at Shri Ashwiniyayak Dham, Dundlod road Railway Station Mukundgarh Dist. Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan to transact the business detailed in the Notice of the Meeting, which was dispatched to the members individually.

Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made there under and Clause 16 of the Listing Agreement with Stock Exchange, Notice is also given that the Register of Members and Share Transfer Register shall remain closed from Monday, 6th July, 2026 to Monday 13th July, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of the Annual General Meeting.

Place: New Delhi Date: 18.06.2026

By the order of the Board For Cross Country Hotels Limited

(Ishan Rai Juneja) (Director) DIN: 06410313

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
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E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE
(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISIO TO RULE 8(6) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of **Central Bank of India**, secured creditors, will be sold on **24.07.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis** for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: **www.centralbank.bank.in** or (**https://BAANKNET.com**)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 24.07.2026 (30 DAYS NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Delhi Cantonment New Delhi	Mr. Suraj Kumar MOB: 8957330934	GOPAL SEWING MACHINE	Part Basement, Ground Floor, 1st, 2nd, 3rd Floor Premises / Property Bearing No.L-117 Khasra No.518 & 519, Situated in Area of Village Chowkri Mubarkabad Abadi known as Shastri Nagar, Delhi-110052. Area : Basement Built up area - 300 Sq.Ft. (27.87 Sq.M.) Approx. 1/3rd of 100 Sq.Yds. (83.61 Sq.M.) Ground Floor Shop builtup Area : 256.5 Sq.Ft. (23.83 Sq.M.) Approx. F. F., S. F., & T. F. Total Builtup Area : 837 Sq.Ft. (77.76 Sq.M.) Approx (2795 Sq.Ft. x 3 Floors) Owned By- Mrs. Sunita Sharma W/o Sh. Gopal Sharma	Rs.46,99,692.92 as on 15.06.2026 + Interest + Other Charges	25.05.2026 (Physical)	₹ 1,12,50,000.00 ₹ 11,25,000.00
2.	Shahbad Mohammedpur	Ms. Nisha Rani Mobile: 9560073475	Mr. Vinod Kumar S/o Mr. Kishan Ram	Residential Property Bearing No.RZ-236-A, Second Floor without Roof Rights, Land Measuring Area of 50 Sq.Yds. i.e. (41.805 Sq.Meters), Out of Khasra No.692/92, 93 & 94 Situated at Block-D, Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.. Owned By- Mr. Vinod Kumar S/o Mr. Kishan Ram	Rs.17,45,058.00 as on 29.04.2026 + Interest + Other Charges	18.02.2026 (Physical)	₹ 18,00,000.00 ₹ 1,80,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 24.07.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 P.M WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 24.07.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (**https://BAANKNET.com**) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (**https://BAANKNET.com**)).

The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "**https://BAANKNET.com**" E-auction will be held on **"As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis**. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).

For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in **www.centralbank.bank.in**. Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (**https://BAANKNET.com**) **BAANKNET** Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 17.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

The Pioneer

Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, Prateek Tomar, R/o OMQ 119, Air Force Station Hindan, Ghaziabad-201004 (UP), lost my RIMC class X Certificate and Marksheet Roll No. SSE/1188 and XII certificate and marksheet Roll No. SSCE/7032 while getting them laminated in Malviya Nagar, New Delhi. Finder kindly contact +916364002138.
PD(1393)C

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Shraavan Kumar S/o Ram Swaroop R/o F-236, Gali No.20, Mittal Colony, Pul Pehlad Pur, New Delhi-110044, have changed my minor son's name from Arpan to Arpan Samrat, aged 13 years, for all future purposes.
PD(1394)C

I, Hitherto known as Tapasya R/o L-1/106-A, DDA Flats, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019, have changed the name of my Minor Son Shaurya aged 14 years and shall hereafter be known as Sukrit Kumar.
PD(1395)C

I, No.15572398L Nk Borge Yuvaraj Shripati, R/o At/Post- Umbraj (Shripati Niwas, Shivneri Colony) Tel-Karad, Dist- Satara, Maharashtra- 415109, have changed my name from Aditya Yuvraj Borge to Borge Aditya Yuvaraj, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1397)C

I, No.15572398L Nk Borge Yuvaraj Shripati, R/o At/Post- Umbraj (Shripati Niwas, Shivneri Colony) Tel-Karad, Dist- Satara, Maharashtra- 415109, have changed my name from Lata to Borge Lata Yuvaraj, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1398)C

I, Amina Khatun, Mother of No.16019317M Hav Abdul Tariq Khan, R/o- North Side, Near Pani Tanki, Usia, Ghazipur, U.P- 232330, have changed my name from Amina Khatun to Aamina Khatoon, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1399)C

I, Noor Eatma, Mother of JC-472414W Sub Salim Naqvi, R/o- Vill & PO- Sirsi, Teh & Dist- Sambhal, U.P- 244301, have changed my name from Noor Eatma to Noor Fatma, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1400)C

I, Runa Devi, Mother of- No.18014758L Nk Pintu Ram, R/o- Vill- Aankushpur, PO- Kusumhi Kalan, Dist/Teh- Ghazipur, U.P- 233302, have changed my name from Runa Devi to Runiya, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1401)C

I, Dhami Mother of No.10136741P Nk Vijender, R/o- Vill- Indiwali, PO- Devrala, Teh- Tosham, Dist- Bhiwani, Haryana- 127029, have changed my name from Dhami to Dharam Wati, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1402)C

I, Lata, W/o No.15572398L Nk Borge Yuvaraj Shripati, R/o At/Post- Umbraj (Shripati Niwas, Shivneri Colony) Tel-Karad, Dist- Satara, Maharashtra- 415109, have changed my name from Lata to Borge Lata Yuvaraj, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1403)C

I, JC-473185H Sub Sher Singh, R/o- VPO- Tabiji, Teh & Dist- Ajmer, Rajasthan- 305206 declare that in my service record my deceased Father's name is wrongly recorded as Lakhshman Singh whereas his correct name is Laxman Singh which may be amended accordingly.
PD(1404)C

I, Shubi Jan, W/o No.14678096N Nk/Auto Tech B Voh Mukhtar Ahmad Kulley, R/o- Vill- Kothair, PO- Nowgam, Teh- Shangus, Dist- Anantnag, J & K- 192201, have changed my name from Shubi Jan to Shubby Jan, vide affidavit dated 17/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(1405)C

I, Mahender kumar S/o Sh. Sukh Dev Raj R/o Flat No 277, Platinum Heights DDA Multistorey HIG flats Sec 18B Dwarka Delhi have changed my name as Mahender kumar Bhaskar for all purposes.
PD(1406)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Ramu Natarajan, Mrs. Jallakshmi Ramu, Ms. Ashwini Ramu Iyer have approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Ghaziabad, U.P. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Unit No. 1404, 14th Floor, (1082 sq. fts.), Tower-CB-3, Capetown, Plot No. GH-01/A, Sector-74, Noida, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. from Ms. Shweta Kureel, who has represented that she is the owner of the said property by virtue of Sub-Lease Deed dated 03.05.2016 (Doc. No. 7786) and Mutation Letter dated 20.11.2018 issued by Noida issued after the death of co-owner Mr. Ashok Kureel. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate Narang & Associates D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Summons For Settlement Of Issues (O.V. RULE 20 (1-A) OF (C.P.C.) IN THE COURT OF THE CIVIL JUDGE SENIOR DIVISION A COURT, MAPUSA. Special Civil Suit No. 130/2025/A Mrs. Ana Vanisa D'Souza and anr V/sPlaintiffs Haardik Ishani Fabrications Private Ltd and 2 orsDefendants To, The Defendant 1. Haardik Ishani Fabrications Private Limited, A Private Limited Company having its office at RZ C-1, Jeewan Park, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, Delhi, India 110059. WHEREAS the above named plaintiffs have instituted a suit for Declaration, Permanent, Mandatory Injunction and other Consequential Reliefs under section 34 & 38 of Specific Relief Act, 1963. AND WHEREAS earlier summons to you at your last available address have returned to this Court unserved. AND WHEREAS the Plaintiffs has prayed for substituted service by way of Publication in a local daily newspaper circulated in New Delhi and this Court has passed an order on the said application: Publication to be carried out in two newspapers widely circulated in that area. NOW THEREFORE, notice is hereby given to you Under Order V Rule 20(1A) of C.P.C. to appear before this Court on 22.07.2026 at 2.30 p.m. either in person or by a pleader duly instructed if any and able to answer all material questions and you are directed to produce on the day all the documents upon which you intend to rely in support of your defence and to file your written statement and reply. TAKE NOTICE THAT, in default of your appearance on the day before mentioned, the suit will be heard and determined in your absence. GIVEN under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 14th day of the month of May, 2026. (Ms. Puja U. S. Sardesai) Senior Civil Judge 'A' Court, Mapusa-Goa

Offered ₹3 lakh to shoot police, 5 more held in Shahzad Bhatti terror module

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Five more persons associated with the alleged interstate terror module linked to Pakistan-based gangster Shahzad Bhatti have been arrested. The accused has been arrested for allegedly plotting attacks on police personnel and spreading propaganda for an ISI-backed outfit.

According to the Delhi police, a total of eight persons are arrested in the case till now. A month earlier, three members of the same module were apprehended during Operation Gang Bust 2.0 on May 7.

A senior police officer said the accused were tasked

with targeting police personnel in Delhi and neighbouring states, conducting reconnaissance of police stations and security establishments, and promoting an alleged terror outfit called Tehreek-e-Taliban Hindustan through graffiti and posters across Delhi-NCR.

The five arrested are Sohail, 26, from Faridabad; Sonu Meena (30), from Ghitori in Delhi; Sachin Kumar Meena (20), from Rajasthan's Dausa district; Mohammad Kaif (21), from Haryana's Nuh; and Mohammad Rihaan (20), from Meerut in Uttar Pradesh.

Police said the module was being run by Bhatti, backed by the ISI, through associates including Hassan



Gujjar, Rana Hunain, Abid Jutt, and Mohsin, all based in Pakistan.

From the five, police recovered five firearms, 10 live cartridges, posters, and digital material, including

developed intelligence through human sources and technical surveillance, leading to the arrests," the officer said.

Sohail, who has a prior criminal record, allegedly painted TTH graffiti at several locations in Delhi and Faridabad on Bhatti's direction and shared videos of the activity through encrypted messaging platforms, for which he was paid ₹5,000.

Sonu Meena was found with three pistols and ammunition. Police said he was responsible for arranging weapons and providing financial support to other members of the module, and had transferred the ₹5,000 to Sohail for the graffiti work.

Sachin Kumar Meena, an

associate of Sonu, was found with two pistols and live rounds. Kaif was allegedly in contact with Bhatti's associates Rana Hunain and Abid Jutt, who instructed him to conduct reconnaissance of police establishments, recruit youths for attacks, and plan targeted killings of police personnel. Rihaan was in direct contact with handlers Abid Jutt and Mohsin.

He allegedly pasted posters of Jutt in Meerut and was offered ₹3 lakh to open fire on police personnel, the highest individual payment disclosed so far in the case. He was also tasked with reconnaissance of security establishments and TTH propaganda through graffiti.

Police noted that TTH had

recently claimed responsibility for the killing of an assistant sub-inspector in Amritsar's Majitha, giving the network's stated intentions a documented precedent rather than a theoretical risk.

The three accused arrested earlier in the case, Soyab and Ravi Kashyap from Amroha in Uttar Pradesh, and Anmol Rai alias Annu from Madhya Pradesh, were allegedly involved in plans to attack police personnel and had recorded videos threatening officers at their handlers' direction.

Wednesday's arrests follow closely on the heels of a separate Special Cell operation against the same broader network announced just a day earlier, in which

seven operatives, including Anas, Mohit, Arif, and gangster Deepak Agrola, were arrested for smuggling arms and narcotics from Pakistan through Punjab into Delhi-NCR on the direction of Bhatti and his associate Ajmal Gujjar.

Taken together, the two operations within 48 hours point to a sprawling network in which Bhatti appears to be running parallel cells, one focused on arms and drug trafficking for revenue, the other specifically tasked with targeting police personnel and spreading propaganda, both recruiting young men across Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh through social media and encrypted apps.

LG orders women cops, Home Guards in DTC ladies' buses; panic buttons to link with 112

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Women police personnel will be deployed inside all Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) ladies' special buses operating on identified routes. The decision was taken at a meeting chaired by Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and attended by officials of Delhi Police and the transport department.

Another decision taken at the meeting was to directly integrate panic button alerts installed in buses with the 112 PCR emergency response system of the Delhi Police. It was also decided to deployment of Women Home Guard Marshals on board to assist police personnel.

Taking a highly serious view of women's security, the Lt Governor issued strict directions to the authorities, categorically stating that the safety of women should not be compromised



at any cost and directed that women police personnel will be deployed inside all Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) ladies' special buses operating on identified routes. The Commissioner of Police informed the LG that, while Delhi Police will provide the necessary female workforce, women Home Guard Marshals could additionally be deployed to assist the police personnel.

These buses, initially to run on already identified

routes, mostly around far-flung areas of Outer Delhi, will be operated entirely by women staff.

At the meeting, officials informed the Lt Governor that the preliminary exercise of identifying vulnerable routes with high female ridership had been undertaken by the DTC and the Delhi Police had been requested to deploy women police personnel on the Ladies Special Buses plying on these routes, especially during morning

and evening hours.

In a major technological upgrade aimed at eliminating response delays, a key decision was taken to directly integrate the Panic Button alerts installed in buses with the 112 PCR emergency response system of the Delhi Police.

This instantaneous linkage will enable seamless coordination between the transit network and law enforcement, ensuring a faster, more effective, and fool-proof emergency response mechanism for women passengers in distress.

"In addition to the above, the CP informed LG, that as per his directions, the plan to open only women police stations catering exclusively to complaints and crime related to women & children, was all set to be rolled out and the first such Police Station was ready to be operationalised soon," Lok Niwas secretariat said in a statement.

HC seeks Centre's reply on Telegram plea on restrictions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Centre to file its reply on Telegram's plea against its order temporarily restricting access to the messaging app ahead of the June 21 NEET-UG 2026 re-examination.

As the matter came up before a vacation bench of Justice Tejas Karia, Telegram's counsel claimed the curbs were illegal, but Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta defended the Government action, saying the platform was being misused and he would reveal "something shocking" tomorrow.

The court adjourned the hearing to Thursday and issued notice to the Centre.

During the hearing, Telegram's counsel questioned the legality of the Government order blocking the platform. He said that over 150 million users had been affected by the Centre's action on Tuesday.

SG Mehta sought an adjournment, saying that he



had not put several things on record. "If the court posts the matter tomorrow, then there is something shocking I can show...One channel starts, it is prohibited, and then another is started. And with a QR code, you can make a payment. This is continuous," he said.

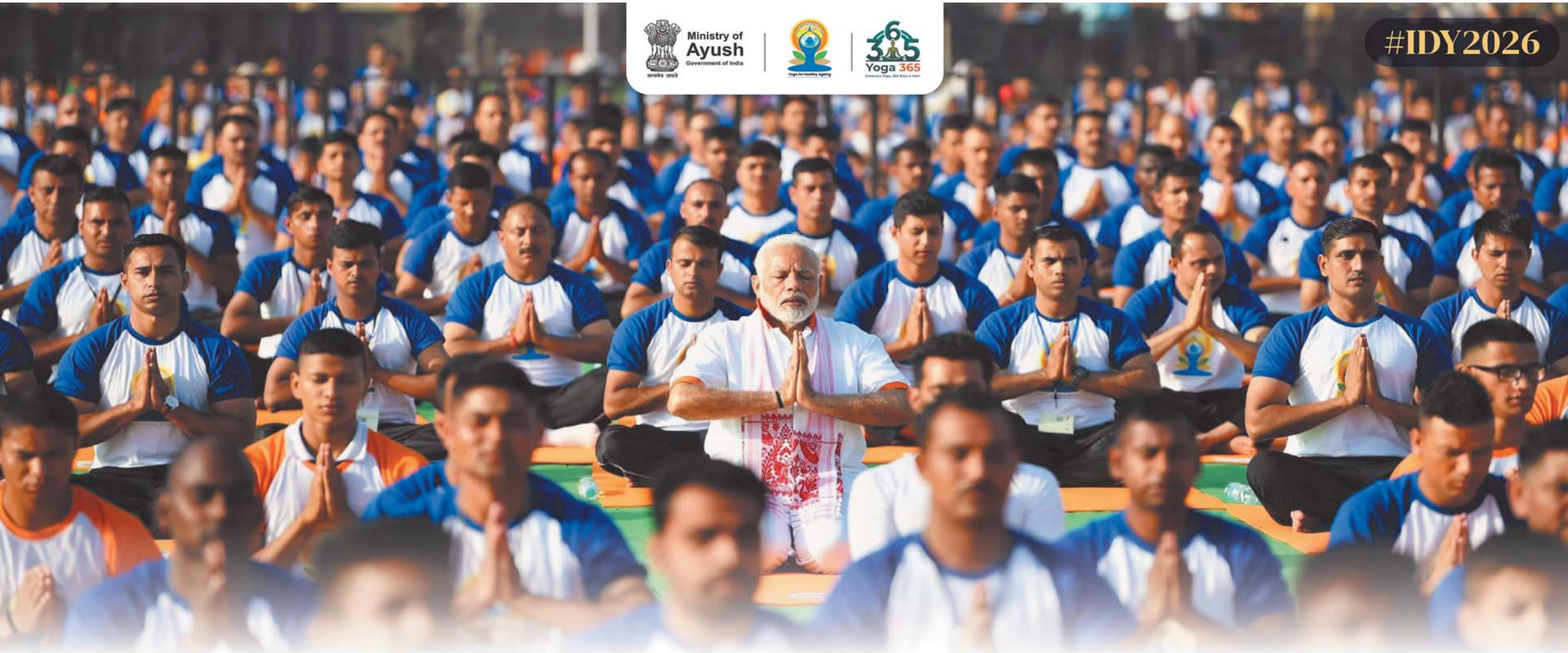
"This has not happened overnight. We have been dealing with complaints since May. I don't wish to go beyond this. This platform is being misused, and imagine the situation which may arise," Mehta added.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), acting on recommendations of the National Testing Agency (NTA), issued a direction under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, restricting access to the Telegram platform in India till June 22, covering the day of the NEET (UG) 2026 re-examination and its immediate aftermath.

A separate direction requires Telegram to disable in India the message-editing feature for already-posted messages till June 30, 2026,

addressing the specific structural feature through which the platform has been used to fabricate after-the-event "paper leak" evidence in respect of national examinations, according to an NTA statement.

"Both measures have been taken in the interest of public order, in response to the organised use of the platform by cheating rackets to defraud candidates appearing for the NEET (UG) 2026 re-examination scheduled on 21 June 2026," the NTA said on Tuesday.



12th International DAY OF YOGA

YOGA FOR HEALTHY AGEING

You are cordially invited to join the event on 21st June from 5 AM onwards in Kolkata, West Bengal

Celebrate the International Day of Yoga 2026 with Hon'ble Prime Minister **Shri Narendra Modi** from Kolkata

Join the main event live at a venue near you or participate virtually from your home and be part of this nationwide celebration of health, wellness, and well-being

Celebrating Wellness Across Generations

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IN FOCUS



People move on camels during a religious procession on the first day of the Muharram, near Bara Imambara in Lucknow on Wednesday PTI

NTA reforms sought from Education Ministry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary committee has expressed concern over continuing examination irregularities despite measures taken by the Government, and recommended that the Ministry of Education publish a time-bound roadmap for implementing reforms suggested by a high-level panel.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, headed by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, presented its 381st action taken report on the recommendations contained in the 364th report on Demands for Grants (2025-26) pertaining to the Department of Higher Education to Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Tuesday.

The committee has endorsed Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's



acknowledgement of June 16, 2024, that "a lot of improvement is needed in the NTA". It is recommended that the National Testing Agency (NTA) expedite the implementation of the Radhakrishnan Committee's recommendations.

The parliamentary committee also recommended that the department and the NTA conduct additional widespread consultations with all stakeholders to adopt a protocol for the "foolproof" administration of nationwide com-

petitive examinations, the report said.

"The Committee notes the steps taken by the ministry, including the constitution of a high-powered steering committee headed by K Radhakrishnan to monitor the implementation of the recommendations of the high-level committee of experts (HLCE).

"However, despite these measures, the paper irregularities are still happening, leading to cancellation of examinations, thereby causing a lot of anxiety among

students," the report said.

"The Committee also recommends the department of higher education to publish a time-bound implementation roadmap for the HLCE recommendations at the earliest," it added.

The HLCE was constituted by the Ministry of Education under the chairmanship of K Radhakrishnan, a former ISRO chairman, to implement critical systemic reforms in national competitive examinations conducted by the NTA.

The parliamentary panel noted that several firms involved in paper setting, administration, and correction have been blacklisted by one organisation/State Government, but this is not impeding their securing of contracts from other states or organisations.

"The Committee, therefore, recommends that the department compile a nationwide list of blacklisted firms so as to bring clarity in

this regard," the report said.

In its action taken reply, the higher education department said that the core activities of the NTA, including paper setting and correction, are not "outsourced".

"The NTA maintains records of penalised vendors, including terminations, blacklisting, and contract cessations, and does not engage vendors that have been blacklisted by the NTA.

"The procurement process adopted by the NTA incorporates mandatory self-disclosure clauses regarding blacklisting of the bidder by any Government agency," it said.

The committee also referred to the finances of the NTA and reiterated its recommendation that the agency's surplus be utilised to strengthen its capabilities.

"The Committee notes that the NTA collected an estimated ₹3,512.98 crore while it spent ₹3,064.77 crore on the conduct of examinations," netting a surplus of

₹448 crore in the last six years.

"It recommends that this corpus be used to build the agency's capabilities to conduct tests itself, or to strengthen regulatory and monitoring capabilities for its vendors," the report said.

Responding to the recommendations, the higher education department said that NTA is a self-sustained organisation, which does not receive Government funding.

"At the beginning of the year, the NTA needs funds for booking centres, paying experts, software, and security, etc. The income and expenditure trend of the NTA shows that, on average, ₹74.5 crore remains every year after incurring all expenses.

"The income remaining unspent in a financial year is utilised for preparatory activities for the next financial year. However, any surplus after budgeting for next year's activities can be appropriately utilised," it said.

BJP calls NC's Statehood protest an eyewash, Omar says party won't compromise values

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Assembly's Leader of Opposition Sunil Sharma on Wednesday labelled the ruling National Conference's proposed protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar over restoration of statehood as an "eyewash", saying that the Abdullah government was trying to divert people's attention from its "zero-governance".

"It is an eyewash," Sharma told reporters in Srinagar when asked about the National Conference protest.

The NC had announced a sit-in protest at Jantar Mantar on the first day of the monsoon session of Parliament to remind the Centre of its promise of restoring statehood to Jammu and Kashmir.

"People are demanding electricity, but I have not seen



any review meetings taking place. There is a lack of clean drinking water, but this government is not making clean and safe drinking water available to the people," he said.

"There is rampant corruption, and it is impossible to get work done without it. The situation created by these six (council of) ministers is one of corruption only, with no governance. There is zero-governance," he added.

The BJP leader said that, unlike other states, where the chief ministers meet people and conduct public outreach programmes, "the CM (Omar Abdullah) here only meets his own party legislators".

"He (Abdullah) should meet people, hold a review meeting, interact with officers, take information, and meet the

nance, zero-performance, on the ground," he added.

The BJP leader said that, unlike other states, where the chief ministers meet people and conduct public outreach programmes, "the CM (Omar Abdullah) here only meets his own party legislators".

"He (Abdullah) should meet people, hold a review meeting, interact with officers, take information, and meet the

people on the ground. To divert the attention of the people from their lack of performance and worthlessness, they have come up with this Jantar Mantar programme, with which I have a huge problem," he said.

On the other hand, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Wednesday asserted that the National Conference would never compromise its principles or "sell its morals" for power, saying the party's ideology and commitment to the people cannot be traded regardless of changing political equations.

Reacting to the question of MPs from the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and Shiv Sena (UBT) backing the NDA on certain issues, Omar said no offer or political arrangement could persuade the National Conference to abandon its core values.

Panel flags issue with CUET's MCQ format

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary committee has flagged concerns over the Common University Entrance Test (CUET), saying its multiple-choice format may not suit humanities and social sciences, while calling for a review of its design and question quality in line with the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020.

The department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, headed by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, observed that CUET was brought from the 2022-23 academic year "to reduce the burden on students, universities, and the entire education system, and to bring candidates passing out from different boards on an equal footing". However, some members of the Committee are not convinced of the merits of introducing the CUET as the universal admissions method for undergraduate studies, it said in a report submitted to Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan on Tuesday.

It was the 381st Action Taken Report on recommendations contained in the 364th Report on Demands for Grants (2025-26) pertaining to the



Department of Higher Education. The report said, "Multiple-choice question (MCQ) answers are particularly ill-suited for humanities and social sciences disciplines, which are definitionally centred on independent, subjective thinking."

"The Committee recommends review of the quality of the question paper and also design of the CUET exam to ensure that it meets the purpose envisaged in NEP, 2020," the report said.

The Committee further observed that the CUET, as the sole entrance examination, has its merits, but it does not allow for Universities like Jawaharlal Nehru University, with their specific legislative mandates, to meet their specific needs.

"The Committee resolves to deliberate further on the matter," it said.

"The JNU system of test administration was designed to ensure that the university was able to fulfil the criterion of socio-economic and regional diversity and representation mandated by the JNU Act in its admissions," the report said.

In its Action Taken Report, the Government said the observations of the Committee were "duly noted" and that the University Grants Commission and the National Testing Agency have been suitably advised.

It said CUET is being conducted for admissions to central universities and participating institutions, providing a single application window allowing students to apply once and appear in one examination for admission to multiple universities.

It added that CUET has "emerged as the second-largest examination in India within two years with 13,54,699 applicants in 2025". The report noted that the CUET (UG) structure has been rationalised after experience from the first three editions, and CUET (UG) 2025 was offered in 37 subjects, with results declared more than three weeks earlier in 2025 than in 2024.

Delhi Govt conducts study to find more durable fabric for national flags

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has commissioned a scientific study to identify more durable fabric for the national flags installed across the capital, following repeated damage caused by strong winds and adverse weather conditions.

Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Wednesday said a team of engineers has been tasked to determine a fabric that can better withstand wind and resist damage to the Tricolour.

"The team will select five types of



flag fabrics which will then be tested for wear and tear, and in rain and storm conditions, and the most durable fabric will be selected and

used (for the Tricolour) at all spots," the minister said.

After getting several complaints of damage, the PWD had earlier this month decided to bring down all the 500 national flags across the city.

According to officials, 115-foot-high flagpoles are situated at 500 locations across the capital. The flags — made out of polyester material — though quite durable, cannot withstand strong winds.

The Tricolours usually replaced around four times a year, including the occasions of Independence Day and Republic Day.

Sorry for being a burden: NEET aspirant dies by suicide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

A 23-year-old medical aspirant allegedly died by suicide in her room in the Patel Nagar area in Dehradun, leaving behind a note apologising to her parents for her "incompetence". The Patel Nagar Police received information regarding the incident on Tuesday morning.

According to Circle Officer (Sadar) Ankit Kandari, preliminary inquiries revealed that Riya Kumari lived with her parents. She routinely

studied late into the night and woke up late in the morning.

The matter came to light when her mother went to call her for breakfast around 10.30 am. When Riya did not open the door, her mother alerted her father. The family then forced the door open and discovered her hanging. The police recovered a suicide note from the scene.

"I am sorry for being a burden. It's nobody's fault but my own incompetence. The best option is to end it, I love you, I'm sorry," CO

Kandari said, quoting the note.

The family informed the police that there were no prior signs of depression.

Riya's father, a Kargil war veteran, mentioned that when she complained of discomfort due to the summer heat about 10 to 15 days ago, they promptly installed an air conditioner in her room.

CO Kandari indicated that frustration over a lack of success in her studies seems to be a contributing factor behind Riya's extreme step. Riya had scored over 96

per cent in her Class 12 examinations and had recently appeared for the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET), which was later cancelled. She was preparing for the re-examination scheduled for June 21.

Sources close to the family shared that this was Riya's third attempt at the medical entrance exam. She did not clear the exam on her first attempt because she had fallen ill. In her second attempt, she improved her performance, scoring around 400 marks.

FROM PAGE - 1

A high-stakes bargain takes shape between...

The reported provisions have sparked debate because they appear to offer Iran significant economic benefits before a final nuclear settlement is reached. Critics are expected to compare the framework with the 2015 nuclear accord, from which Trump withdrew during his first term in office. The draft framework is also said to include efforts to end hostilities involving Iran-backed groups in the region, including fighting between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon. However, several contentious issues remain unresolved and are expected to be addressed during subsequent negotiations.

The proposed talks are intended to produce a long-term arrangement that the Trump administration says will permanently prevent Iran from developing nuclear weapons. Iran, meanwhile, continues to maintain that its nuclear programme is intended for peaceful purposes.

Trump indicated that he would provide additional details about the negotiations during a scheduled press conference later in the day.

The evolving agreement comes amid heightened geopolitical tensions in the Middle East and follows months of conflict that disrupted global energy markets and intensified international concerns over regional stability.

At G7, Modi, Trump discuss security, trade...

India is participating in the 52nd G7 Summit as a partner country, with PM Modi engaging world leaders on issues concerning India and the Global South. In a significant endorsement of India's growing global stature, President Trump said New Delhi would continue to play a major role in international decision-making under PM Modi's leadership.

"India always plays a major role in international decision-making and will continue to do so

as long as Modi remains the country's leader," Trump said during the bilateral meeting.

The US President also described PM Modi as one of the toughest negotiators he has encountered. "You look at this man. He's the most beautiful-looking man. He looks so nice. He's like an angel. But actually he's tough," Trump remarked.

Responding to a question on concerns in India over some recent US policy decisions, Trump sought to reassure Indians, saying New Delhi had a "great friend in the White House".

"I can tell you everyone here loves India. They have tremendous respect for this man," Trump said, referring to PM Modi.

The meeting is being viewed as an important step in rebuilding momentum in bilateral ties following last month's visit by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio to India. Both sides have expressed interest in strengthening cooperation across strategic, economic, defence and security domains despite recent disagreements.

India's participation in the G7 Summit marks its 13th appearance at the grouping and Prime Minister Modi's seventh consecutive attendance, reflecting New Delhi's expanding influence in global affairs and its role as a leading voice of the Global South.

Claims of split in SP spark fresh political...

The BJP-led NDA is in a strong position in the State, while the SP has been strengthening its Yadav-Muslim base and reaching out to more groups through its PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alapsankhyak) strategy.

The SP has dealt with internal problems before, such as the 2016-17 family dispute involving Mulayam Singh Yadav's brother, Shivpal Yadav, which led to a temporary split. So far, there is no solid proof of the alleged letter or any list of defectors. BJP leaders have mostly stayed away from commenting on Rajbhar's specific claims.

Political observers see this as pre-election positioning. In Uttar Pradesh's changing political scene, talk of splits or defections is often used to make rivals look weak. With the 2027 elections still more than a year away, both sides are testing different messages on unity and caste. For the SP, showing unity under Akhilesh Yadav seems to be the main goal right now.

For the BJP and its allies, this episode shows how hard it is to turn dominance into complete control. As Uttar Pradesh prepares for the assembly elections in 2027, such political arguments are likely to increase. It remains unclear whether Rajbhar's claims will come to pass or turn out to be political drama. For now, the Samajwadi Party has made its position clear.

Uddhav faces new defections

All the MPs are set to join the Shiv Sena (Eknath Shinde) at an event in Mumbai on Thursday, giving final shape to the speculations of 'Operation Tiger' in Maharashtra, they added. The move by Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs comes on the heels of the breakaway and merger of 22 Trinamool Congress legislators to the BJP-led NDA fold. Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde was back in Mumbai on late Wednesday evening from New Delhi to complete the process of induction of six MPs of Uddhav.

Shinde had led a rebellion against the Thackerays and went on to split the Sena in 2022 and became the CM of Maharashtra. He pulled the Uddhav-led Congress-Shiv Sena combined Maha Vikas Aghadi Government.

Against these developments, some MPs of Shiv Sena (UBT) met Lok Sabha Speaker Birla on Wednesday after holding a press conference in the national Capital. The party further issued a three-line whip to all party MPs to attend a meeting of its parliamentary party at 11 am on Thursday. "We went to request the Speaker to

respect our caveat letter. We had sent the letter by email on Tuesday (June 16, 2026) night. But we personally went and met him to tell him that, in case any other group approaches him, he should hear us first," said Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut, accompanied by colleague MPs Anil Desai and Arvind Sawant. Raut alleged that some Maharashtra MPs were being offered "Rs 50 crore" to switch sides.

"Under the law, one cannot simply merge with a party even if they have the support of two-thirds of the MPs. Only the original party can merge if a group has the required two-thirds strength," Desai said. He added that the Lok Sabha Speaker assured them that he would look into every aspect of the law before taking any decision.

Apart from Sawant and Desai, Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Rajabhau Waje has announced that his loyalty remains to the Thackeray family. Raut has been camping in Delhi ever since there were talks of a split of the party in the fashion of Mamata Banerjee's TMC.

High-level meeting fuels buzz over BJP shake-up

The meeting took place as the party gets ready for a regular review of its organisational structure. These reviews usually involve changes to national office-bearers, better coordination among state units, and adjustments to key roles in the central leadership.

The presence of two senior RSS leaders in the meeting suggests the changes will focus on grassroots connections, to manage the cadre for the long term, rather than just short-term politics. As organisational general secretary, BL Santhosh is central to any changes in the central team.

In the past, these reviews have often led to the rotation or promotion of national secretaries, joint secretaries, and state coordinators. The main goals are to refresh the middle-level leadership and to prepare for upcoming State Assembly elec-

tions in the next 18 to 24 months.

Gubernatorial appointments are another important topic. Some states have vacancies for Governors or Governors whose terms are ending soon. The Union Government makes these appointments.

Party sources said the meeting was part of regular talks among top leaders to review pending decisions. No specific names or roles were mentioned during the discussions, according to people familiar with the meeting. The BJP has held similar organisational reviews before, often after big elections or at regular times to strengthen the party. These changes usually mean rotating or bringing in leaders at different levels to keep the organisation efficient.

Delhi LG orders POSCO audit of schools

The LG also directed that a detailed report must be provided on the exact actions that have been taken, or is planned to be taken, against the defaulters.

Further directing the law enforcement agencies, the LG instructed the Delhi Police to ensure robust and visible deployment around school premises and prominent student hubs. He stressed that police presence must be intensified particularly during school dispersal hours, to proactively deter any untoward incidents and strengthen public confidence.

Emphasising a strict zero-tolerance approach towards eve-teasing, harassment, and molestation of women and children, the LG categorically stated that women's safety is non-negotiable. Reaffirming that the safety, dignity, and well-being of every student cannot be compromised at any level, he stated that the administration remains firmly committed to building a secure, fearless, and protective environment for every child in Delhi.

Raise education spending to 6% of GDP, says Parliamentary panel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

A parliamentary committee has said that the current allocation for higher education is “underwhelmed”, and recommended that spending on education be increased to 6 per cent of GDP as envisaged under the National Education Policy-2020.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, headed by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, on Tuesday presented its 381st action taken report on the recommendations contained in the 364th report on Demands for Grants (2025-26) pertaining to the Department of Higher Education to Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan.

The Committee noted that the percentage increase in the Department of Higher Education's Budget estimates (BE) for 2025-26 vis-à-vis the BE for 2024-25 was lower than the previous year.

“The Committee feels that in view of the inflationary trends in the country, the allocation should increase at least 8 per cent to 10 per cent to accommodate inflation, to maintain the existing standards for expenditure by the Department of Higher Education, and to avoid a decline in actual allocation/expenditure for



the higher education sector.

“The current allocations are, therefore, underwhelmed – especially in the context of the need for adequate resources to implement the National Education Policy (NEP),” the report said.

The committee also noted that the gross enrolment ratio of males and females during 2018-2023 “has not registered any significant growth for the purpose of employment and optimal development of human resources”. “The Committee, therefore, recommends that the percentage of expenditure should be enhanced further in consonance with the NEP-2020's targets for the year 2035,” it said.

Taking note of NEP-2020, which “unequivocally

endorses and envisions a substantial increase in public investment in education by both the Centre and all the State Governments to reach 6 per cent of GDP”, the panel expressed concern that total expenditure on education stood at 4.12 per cent of GDP in 2021-22.

“The Committee is constrained to note that the total expenditure on education (including all Central ministries and all states/UTs) as percentage of GDP stands at 4.12 per cent for 2021-22, which is far lower than the recommendations of NEP-2020,” it said.

The Committee also noted that “SAARC countries such as Bhutan and Maldives spent 7.47 per cent and 4.67 per cent of their GDP, respectively, in 2022, as against

4.12 per cent spending on education by India”.

“The Committee, therefore, recommends that the Ministry of Education make sincere efforts to increase the spending on education to 6 per cent of the GDP, as endorsed and recommended by the NEP-2020,” the report said.

“The Ministry of Education should sincerely seek additional funds from the Ministry of Finance to make spending on education at 6 per cent of GDP feasible, thereby strengthening and augmenting the public education system from school education to higher education, truly world-class and accessible to all sections of society,” it added.

The Government, in its action taken reply, said the allocation of funds in the department is based on the requirements of the respective bureaus within the overall Budget ceiling allotted by the Ministry of Finance and that the BE for 2025-26 were ₹50,077.95 crore, which was enhanced to ₹51,381.67 crore at the revised estimates stage.

“It is stated that the actual expenditure at the end of FY 2024-25 was ₹44,055.44 crore. Funds amounting to Rs 33,938.88 crore were certified till 31.12.2024. However, actual expenditure as on 31.12.2024 was ₹33569.05 crore.

Congress slams PM as US command uses incorrect map of India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday criticised the Modi Government over the US Pacific Command reportedly using an incorrect map of India, asking why any country would need adversaries when its prime minister has thrown the nation into such “exploitative friendships”. The Opposition party claimed that Prime Minister Modi's friends have an uncanny habit of acting against India, its interests, and its friends.

Congress's media and publicity department head, Pawan Khera, shared a social media post which stated that the US Pacific Command had used an incorrect map of India without Jammu and Kashmir and showing Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) as Pakistani territory.

“Modi Ji's friends have an uncanny habit of acting against India, India's interests, and India's friends.

The latest example? The US Pacific Command used an incorrect map of India, excluding Jammu & Kashmir and depicting PoK as Pakistani territory,” Khera said. “One is compelled to ask: Why would any country need adversaries when its PM has thrown the country into such exploitative friendships?” the Congress leader said.

The US has also restored



Congress leader Pawan Khera

the name of the US Indo-Pacific Command to the US Pacific Command, reversing an eight-year-old decision.

The US Department of Defence announced the decision on Tuesday, stating that the designation honours the Command's deep historical roots, established in 1947 by then-President Harry Truman.

The US Pacific Command extends from the US West Coast to India's western border. “Originally established on January 1, 1947, by President Harry S Truman, the command operated under the US PACOM banner for over 70 years, standing as the oldest and largest of the United States' unified combatant commands,” the US Department of Defence said in a statement.

The US Pacific Command was renamed as the US Indo-Pacific Command in 2018 during US President Donald Trump's first term in office.

States Focus



ARMY CHIEF UPENDRA DWIVEDI MEETS PRESIDENT MURMU

Outgoing Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi on Wednesday called on President Droupadi Murmu at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. The president's office shared a picture of the meeting in a post on social media. “Chief of the Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi, along with his spouse Sunita Dwivedi, called on President Droupadi Murmu at Rashtrapati Bhavan,” it said. Lt General Dhiraj Seth was named on June 13 as the next Chief of the Army Staff. He will take charge on June 30, following the retirement of incumbent General Dwivedi. (PTI)



READ NEWS ABOUT YOUR GOVT, ACT: STALIN TELLS VIJAY

DMK president MK Stalin on Wednesday asked Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay to read the “news about him and his Government and take appropriate action.” Addressing a function, Stalin said the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) stands as an exemplary model of how a regional party should function. (PTI)

Neither public nor allies trust Rahul Gandhi: BJP after DMK slam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday claimed that neither the public nor his allies have confidence in Rahul Gandhi, after DMK mouthpiece ‘Murasoli’ reportedly accused the Congress leader of weakening the unity of the Opposition INDIA bloc.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the criticism by the DMK reflected a growing discontent among the opposition parties over Gandhi's leadership, and claimed that the Congress leader has become a “political liability”. An edi-



Shehzad Poonawalla

torial published in the DMK mouthpiece Murasoli on Monday accused Gandhi of undermining the alliance partners and weakening the Opposition unity.

“The DMK has launched an all-out attack on Rahul Gandhi, calling him political-

ly immature. Nobody has faith or trust in Rahul Gandhi. The Congress uses and throws away its allies,” Poonawalla said in a video statement. Referring to recent strains within the Opposition alliance, he alleged that several INDIA bloc constituents have raised concerns about Gandhi's leadership.

“Old friends have now become new and real enemies. Be it the DMK and what they did to them in the Tamil Nadu elections, be it the TMC, the Left, Uddhav Sena or the RJD, all have expressed dissatisfaction,” he claimed.

India, Thailand to boost defence ties in Indo-Pacific

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Thailand have agreed to further strengthen collaboration in manufacturing, research, innovation and capability during the 10th Thailand-India Defence Dialogue, the defence ministry said on Wednesday.

Giving details, officials said the parleys were held in Bangkok on Tuesday to review the full spectrum of bilateral defence cooperation and exchange views on regional and global security issues of mutual interest.

The dialogue was co-chaired by Thailand's Deputy Permanent Secretary for Defence, Admiral Nuttapol Diewvanich and joint



Secretary, Ministry of Defence, Satyajit Mohanty.

The two sides discussed the evolving security environ-

ment in the Indo-Pacific region and exchanged perspectives on regional developments. They reaffirmed

the importance of strengthening cooperation to promote peace, stability and prosperity in the region.

The delegations reviewed the progress made in bilateral defence cooperation since the previous dialogue. Discussions covered the ongoing military-to-military engagements, capacity-building initiatives, training exchanges, maritime cooperation and other areas of mutual interest.

The dialogue also reviewed the ongoing defence industry cooperation between the two countries. The two sides discussed opportunities to deepen collaboration in defence manufacturing, research, innovation and capability development, with

a view to promoting mutually beneficial partnerships between their respective defence ecosystems.

The delegations exchanged views on cooperation under regional and multilateral defence frameworks, including Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)-led mechanisms. They reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening practical cooperation and addressing shared security challenges through dialogue and collaboration. The meeting concluded with discussions on future engagements and the way ahead for bilateral defence cooperation. India and Thailand elevated their bilateral ties to a formal Strategic Partnership in 2025.

India's defence production hits record ₹1.78 lakh crore



Representative image

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's annual defence production touched an all-time high of ₹1.78 lakh crore in the financial year 2025-26, the defence ministry said on Wednesday. The milestone represents a 15.6 per cent growth over the previous fiscal year's output of ₹1.54 lakh crore and a staggering 110 per cent increase since 2020-21, when the figure was ₹84,643 crore, it said.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said the “remarkable rise” in India's defence production in recent years is the result of the collective efforts of the Department of Defence Production and all other stakeholders. “This upward trajectory is a clear indicator of the country's expanding defence industrial base,” he said.

“With sustained policy support, several new initiatives, increased private sector participation, and growing export capabilities, the defence production sector is poised for continued acceleration in the years ahead,” Rajnath said. The defence ministry said the rise in the defence production is “stag-

gering” and that it is a 110 per cent increase since 2020-21, when the figure was ₹84,643 crore. The indigenous defence production has increased almost four times from ₹43,746 crore in 2013-14, it said.

“The Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs) and other PSUs accounted for approximately 76 per cent of total production, while the private sector contributed 24 per cent, which is a rise from 22 per cent in 2024-25,” the ministry said.

“The share of the private sector is at its all-time high of around ₹42,000 crore in 2025-26, reflecting its expanding role in the defence ecosystem,” it added.

The ministry said the growth in defence production over the years has “tremendously” contributed to achieving the record defence exports of ₹38,424 crore in 2025-26.

“The achievement reflects the growing momentum of the Government's push for self-reliance in defence manufacturing under the Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative, spearheaded by Prime Minister Narendra Modi,” it said in a statement.

Speaker Om Birla invites Abhishek Banerjee on June 19 over TMC split

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla has invited Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee to a meeting on June 19 to present his case regarding the party split, according to parliamentary sources. However, Trinamool Congress sources said the party had not received any communication from the Speaker's Office as of 3 pm.

Parliamentary sources said 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs have demanded recognition as a separate group following their merger with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. The Speaker has decided to hear both factions before making a decision. On June 10, Abhishek Banerjee



Abhishek Banerjee

wrote to the Lok Sabha Speaker, urging him not to accord any recognition, status or facility to any group claiming to be a separate faction of the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC). Banerjee had asserted that the Constitution and the anti-defection law do not permit the formation of a separate group within an existing political party.

India restored 21.7 million hectares of degraded land: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has already brought 21.76 million hectares of land under restoration efforts against its Bonn Challenge target of restoring 26 million hectares by 2030, Environment Minister Bhopender Yadav said on Wednesday. The Bonn Challenge is a global initiative launched in 2011 to restore degraded and deforested landscapes, with a target to bring 350 million hectares under restoration by 2030.

“Restoration activities have generated around 1.22 billion person-days of employment,” Yadav said at an event to commemorate the World Day to Combat Desertification



and Drought. The minister highlighted that more than 27 million hectares have been treated under the watershed development component of the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana, and over 61.3 million geo-tagged natural resource management assets have been created. “Greening and

restoration activities have been undertaken across around 1.7 lakh hectares under the Green India Mission, while afforestation has been carried out over around 3.20 lakh hectares through CAMPA-supported activities during the past five years,” he said. The event also saw the launch of a special

issue of Indian Forester and India's Second Progress Report on the Bonn Challenge (2011-2020). The Indian Forester issue brings together scientific insights, policy perspectives, and field experiences on sustainable land management, ecosystem restoration and land degradation neutrality, with a special focus on rangelands and grasslands.

The Bonn Challenge report documents restoration efforts across states and Union territories, highlights their ecological and socio-economic benefits, and reflects India's continued efforts towards forest landscape restoration, land degradation neutrality, and ecosystem resilience.

Rahul slams Telegram ban, calls it Govt's theatrics

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday criticised the Government after it temporarily restricted access to Telegram, saying the “new trick” was akin to putting a lock on the victim's house instead of catching the thief.

Telegram has stopped working for existing users in India after the Centre temporarily restricted access to the messaging app ahead of the June 21 NEET-UG re-examination, but it continues to remain operational through the Virtual Private Network (VPN). Google



delisted the app on Tuesday, and Apple's App Store has also removed it now in compliance with the Government order to block access to the app. In a post in Hindi on social media, Gandh said, “Telegram Ban” — Modi Government's new trick to stop paper leaks. Meaning, instead of catching the thief, just put a lock on the victim's door.”

■ States Focus ■



BIHAR CM ANNOUNCES PLAN TO RENAME GREATER PATNA

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary participated in the Block Assistance-cum-Public Welfare Camp organised at Nadiyawan village in Phulwari Sharif here on Wednesday. During the event, he elaborated on the Government's plans concerning development, law and order, industrial growth, farmers' welfare, and the future of Patna. According to him, criminals would have no option but to flee to Nepal, as Uttar Pradesh has Yogi Baba, West Bengal has Shubhendru Adhikari, and Bihar has Samrat. During the programme, he revealed that the government is working on the concept of "Greater Patna," which will eventually be identified as Pataliputra. (PTI)



LATERAL ENTRY PROCESS NOT SUSPENDED: JITENDRA SINGH

Union minister Jitendra Singh on Wednesday said that the lateral entry has not been suspended and consultation was going on with all stakeholders. The lateral entry is referred to as the appointment of specialists, including those from the private sector, in the Government departments. "There is no such order suspending the process," Singh told a press conference, when asked about the status of lateral entry. The minister was addressing the presser on the "12 Years' Achievements of the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions". The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) had, in August 2024, cancelled its advertisement to fill key posts in Government departments through lateral entry, amid a political row over the lack of a reservation provision for those positions. Singh, the minister of state for personnel, said that the consultation was going on "not with the stakeholder ministries alone, in fact with everybody" (concerned). (PTI)

Amit Shah orders AI upgrade for cybercrime helpline

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday asked officials to improve the national cybercrime helpline 1930 by adding artificial intelligence and support for more languages. He also told agencies to ensure every complaint is handled and to make reporting simpler for people across India.

At a review meeting, Shah highlighted the need to improve the helpline as cyber fraud cases rise. He asked officials to use AI tools to streamline operations and add support for more languages so everyone can report issues easily. He also urged better coordination with State Governments to ensure every call or complaint is followed up on.

Shah noted that frozen bank accounts often make investigations harder for victims. Officials said he



stressed that solving complaints quickly would help restore trust in the system.

The 1930 helpline is managed by the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Ministry of Home Affairs. It is a toll-free number available 24/7 for reporting financial cyber-crimes such as UPI fraud, OTP scams, phishing, and unauthorised transactions involving cards or digital wallets.

Dhaka University students protest desecration of image of Lord Ram

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Students of Dhaka University staged a torchlight procession in the Capital to protest against the alleged desecration of an image of Lord Ram during a demonstration in Gaibandha and to demand the resumption of construction work on a proposed Lord Ram statue in northern Bangladesh.

The protest comes amid growing tensions surrounding a project to build what is expected to be Bangladesh's largest statue of Lord Ram in Palashbari upazila of Gaibandha district. Minority rights groups have expressed concern over threats directed at the project and have urged authorities to ensure the safety of those involved.

The statue, which is planned to stand 81 feet tall, is being constructed at the Sri Sri Radha Govinda Temple complex in Komorpur village. According to project organisers, approximately 80 per cent of the construction has already been completed. However, work has been temporarily suspended due to security concerns and pressure from groups opposing the initiative.

"We are building a statue of one of the principal



sources of strength in Sanatan Dharma, Lord Ram. Around 80 per cent of the work on the 81-foot statue has been completed, but some radical groups are pressuring us to halt construction. We are living in fear and have suspended work for the time being," said Haridas Chandra Das, Founder and President of the Temple Committee of the Gaibandha Palashbari Komorpur Sri Sri Radha Govinda Temple.

Das appealed to the Government, political leaders, law enforcement agencies, and civil society to

ensure that the project can be completed without further disruption.

The Bangladesh Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council has called on the Government to take immediate action against what it described as communal threats targeting the temple and the statue project.

The organisation expressed concern that such incidents could undermine communal harmony across the country. In a statement, the council urged the Government, local administration, civil society representatives, and political leaders to take swift and

appropriate measures to preserve peace and religious coexistence. It also demanded that individuals responsible for inciting communal hatred and provoking unrest be identified and brought to justice.

During the Dhaka University demonstration, student leaders condemned the reported desecration of Lord Ram's image and described it as an attack on the religious sentiments of the Hindu community.

"Lord Ram is one of the most revered deities in Hinduism. Recently, extremist groups spread rumors involving Lord Ram, while others allegedly desecrated his image. These actions have deeply hurt the religious sentiments of Hindus," said Ram Prasad Saha Topu, Social Welfare Secretary of the Jagannath Hall Students' Union.

The controversy has sparked renewed debate over minority rights and religious freedom in Bangladesh, with community leaders calling for stronger protections and measures to prevent communal tensions from escalating. This version removes clutter, improves flow and neutrality, and follows a standard newspaper-style format.



CBI arrests ex-CREST CEO Navneet Srivastava in ₹75 crore fund scam

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

In a major development in the ongoing CREST fund misappropriation probe, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Wednesday arrested senior Indian Forest Service (IFoS) officer Navneet Srivastava, who was the Chief Executive Officer of the Chandigarh Renewable Energy and Science & Technology Promotion Society (CREST) at the time of the alleged fraud. Srivastava was produced before the Special Judge, CBI, Chandigarh, and remanded to three days of police custody.

The arrest follows revelations about his role during the investigation. According to the CBI, funds parked in three CREST bank accounts maintained with IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh were fraudulently misappropriated and diverted to various shell companies. The proceeds were allegedly diverted for personal use by the beneficiaries, resulting in a loss of approximately ₹75 crore to CREST during Srivastava's tenure.

The investigation further revealed that a portion of the proceeds of crime was routed into the account of a private company in which Srivastava's wife and a close relative are directors.

CREST, the nodal agency of the Chandigarh administration for promoting renewable energy, solar power projects, and related initiatives, maintained the accounts at the IDFC First Bank branch in

Sector 32. The alleged diversion involved collusion with bank officials and the use of shell entities to siphon public funds intended for green energy projects. comes days after the CBI filed its first chargesheet in the ₹75.34 crore CREST case before the Special CBI Court.

The chargesheet named 13 accused, including five IDFC First Bank officials, two CREST public servants, former Project Director Sukhwinder Singh Abrol and accountant Sahil Kukkar, as well as private individuals and shell companies. Chandigarh Police earlier arrested Abrol and Kukkar. T

The CREST scam forms part of a larger series of alleged frauds linked to IDFC First Bank accounts involving government departments and entities such as the Chandigarh Smart City project and Municipal Corporation Chandigarh, with total alleged losses running into hundreds of crores.

Srivastava, an IFoS officer, had been removed as CREST CEO earlier and was subsequently suspended by the Central Government in April this year in connection with the probe. His arrest marks the first custodial action by the CBI against a senior serving or former official directly heading CREST.

The agency is continuing its investigation to trace the full money trail, identify all beneficiaries, and examine the role of other individuals and entities. Further arrests cannot be ruled out as the probe deepens into the alleged civil servant-bank nexus.

Jammu Police bust ring allegedly supplying 80% of district's drugs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In a major clampdown against narco-terrorism and organised drug trafficking, Jammu Police has arrested three key operatives of an interstate narcotics syndicate from Amritsar, Punjab, and recovered a large cache of arms, ammunition, heroin, cash and vehicles during a coordinated operation.

The arrested accused have been identified as Surajdeep Singh alias Suraj, a resident of Jandiala, Harpreet Singh alias Raju, and Jaspreet. The arrests were made in connection with multiple cases registered under FIR No. 51/2026 at Police Station Miran Sahib, FIR No. 58/2026 at Police Station Bishnah, FIR No. 137/2026 at Police Station Nagrota and FIR



No. 48/2026 at Police Station Gangyal.

According to a police spokesman, the three accused were major suppliers of narcotic substances to Jammu district and were allegedly responsible for supplying nearly 80 per cent of the drugs trafficked into the district. The operation was launched following sustained surveillance and meticulous intelligence-based investigations.

Police said the accused were part of the backward link network of notorious narcotics trafficker Lau Gujjar and his associates operating in Jammu and Kashmir. Investigations into previous NDPS cases and the arrest and questioning of several accused, including Lateef, Bachu, Majeeda and Mushtaq, led investigators to Suraj and Raju, who were identified as crucial links in the drug supply chain.

BJP accuses Rahul Gandhi of playing politics over NEET exam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ahead of Rahul Gandhi's interaction with students in Kota, the BJP on Wednesday accused the Congress leader of playing politics at the expense of medical aspirants who are in the final leg of preparations for the June 21 NEET-UG re-exam.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters, party national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi asked why Gandhi chose Kota in Rajasthan for his interaction with the students 72 hours before the NEET-UG retest and accused him of being



Sudhanshu Trivedi

"cunning" for political gains. Trivedi said, "Is it because of the Congress' internal politics that you want to play with the students' sentiments there?" Gandhi will interact with students in Kota in the evening as part of the Congress' campaign against paper leaks and to highlight youth issues.

The programme, to be held at an open theatre in Kota, is being positioned by the Congress as the first in a series of nationwide student conventions.

The campaign seeks to highlight the challenges faced by young people due to alleged paper leaks, rising examination costs and what the party described as the government's failure to ensure a fair and transparent recruitment and education system.

PMLA Court frames charges against Sheikh Shahjahan, 3 others

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

The Special PMLA Court in Kolkata has formally charged suspended Trinamool Congress leader Sheikh Shahjahan and three others under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002. The accused include Sheikh Shahjahan, his brother Sheikh Alomgir, Shib Prasad Hazra, and Didar Boksh. The court acknowledged the Prosecution Complaint from the Enforcement Directorate's Kolkata office, filed on May 27, 2024, and on June 3, 2024.

The charges are connected to alleged land grabbing in Sandeshkhali, North 24 Parganas district, and to money laundering from these activities. The Enforcement Directorate says



the accused and their associates took land by threatening locals, including farmers, tribals, and fish merchants, using intimidation, extortion, and organised crime. They reportedly made significant illegal profits by using these properties, especially in the shrimp and fish trade.

The investigation began after West Bengal Police filed several FIRs for crimes like extortion, threats, attempted

murder, and land grabbing. The Enforcement Directorate collected statements under Section 50 of the PMLA and conducted searches, resulting in the seizure of vehicles linked to the accused. Earlier, the agency had frozen assets worth Rs 14.28 crore belonging to Sheikh Shahjahan, Sheikh Alomgir, and their associates. With these charges, the case will now go to trial.

Mahayuti eyes dominant show in Maharashtra MLC polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The BJP-led Mahayuti alliance heads into the biennial Maharashtra Legislative Council elections from local authorities' constituencies seeking to win all 17 seats, with voting slated in 12 on Thursday and the remaining five already decided through unopposed victories.

Members of local self-government bodies such as municipal corporations, councils, and zilla parishads are eligible to cast their votes between 8 am and 4 pm. Votes will be counted on June 22.

Although elections were notified for 17 seats, actual voting will be held only in 12 constituencies as candidates of the ruling alliance have already been elected unopposed in five seats, making their formal decla-



ration a procedural formality.

The Mahayuti bloc consists of the BJP, Shiv Sena and NCP. The ruling coalition has already secured uncontested victories for BJP's Arun Lakhani from the Wardha-Chandrapur-Gadchiroli constituency, NCP nominees Vikram

Kakade from Pune and Aniket Tatkare from Raigad-Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg, and Shiv Sena candidates Ravindra Phatak from Thane and Dushyant Chaturvedi from Yavatmal.

With those seats in its pocket, the Mahayuti is focusing on the remaining 12 constituencies and is

attempting to prevent the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) from gaining ground.

Despite its numerical advantage, the ruling alliance's campaign has not been entirely free of difficulties. Internal differences surfaced in the Sataras-Sangli and Nashik local authorities' constituencies, forcing senior leaders to intervene and undertake damage-control measures.

The Sataras-Sangli constituency has emerged as one of the most keenly watched contests. The BJP has fielded Dhairyasheel Kadam, while the NCP (SP) has nominated Abhaysinh Jagtap. The seat witnessed unease within the ruling alliance after sections of the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena expressed reservations over the seat-sharing arrangement.



Stage set for election to two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

All preparations have been completed to conduct the election to two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand on Thursday, for which three candidates are in the fray, an official said.

The Opposition BJP-led NDA decided to support an Independent candidate, despite lacking the required number of MLAs in the Assembly. Three candidates – JMM's Baidyanath Ram, Congress's Pranav Jha and BJP-backed Independent nominee Parimal Nathwani – are contesting the polls for the two seats. The voting will take place between 9 am and 4 pm at a polling station set up within the Jharkhand Assembly premises.

"Once the polling is over, the report will be sent to the Election Commission of India. On the Commission's permission, the counting of votes will start, tentatively around 5 pm," Returning Officer Ranjit Kumar said on Wednesday.

Kumar, who is also the secretary of the Jharkhand



Assembly, said all preparations are in place to hold the polling peacefully. The returning officer added that adequate security arrangements have been made in the Assembly premises in view of the elections.

Political temperatures are rising in the state capital amid fear of cross-voting.

A candidate is required to secure a minimum of 28 first-preference votes to emerge victorious in the June 18 polls.

The BJP-led NDA has 24 MLAs in the Jharkhand Assembly, while the INDIA bloc has 56 members.

The JMM's Baidyanath Ram is expected to win easily, as the party has adequate numbers in the State

Assembly. All eyes are on the second seat, in which a tough fight between Congress's Jha and NDA-backed Nathwani is likely. In the Jharkhand Assembly, the INDIA bloc has 56 members, comprising 34 from the JMM, 16 from the Congress, four from the RJD and two from CPI(ML) Liberation. The NDA has 24 MLAs – 21 from the BJP and one each from the LJP (Ram Vilas), AJSU Party and the JD(U). The Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha has one MLA. Both the ruling and Opposition camps are keeping no stone unturned to keep their MLAs intact ahead of the polling.

The NDA MLAs were shifted to a hotel in Ranchi on

Tuesday, while the ruling INDIA bloc is busy holding meetings with its MLAs to thwart chances of cross-voting.

The ruling INDIA bloc MLAs, including those from the Congress, participated in a mock poll during a meeting at Chief Minister Hemant Soren's residence on Tuesday night to make the new legislators aware of the exercise.

Congress MLA Suresh Baitha said a meeting of ruling party legislators, including those from RJD and CPI(ML) Liberation, was held at a hotel on Wednesday, and they also participated in a mock poll on that occasion.

"We all 56 MLAs of the INDIA bloc are united, and we will win both the Rajya Sabha seats," he said.

BJP chief whip Naveen Jaiswal also claimed victory for their supported candidate in the election.

One of the Rajya Sabha seats in the state fell vacant following the death of JMM co-founder Shibu Soren. The other vacancy is due to the completion of BJP member Deepak Prakash's tenure on June 21.

Former West Bengal minister Udayan Guha arrested over irregularities



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Former West Bengal minister and senior TMC leader Udayan Guha was arrested on Wednesday over his alleged involvement in "financial irregularities" linked to the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, a police officer said. Guha was arrested from a flat in the Phoolbagan area of the metropolis.

"There was a complaint lodged against the former minister alleging his involvement in financial irregularities in connection with the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana. There are other cases, too, against him, and action will accordingly be taken," an officer of the Cooch Behar District Police said.

The complainant alleged that Guha has been siphoning money meant for the scheme since 2016, he said.

Guha has been booked under sections of the BNS, including cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal conspiracy, the officer said.

Allegations have also been levelled against Guha over post-poll violence in 2021.

Guha was the Trinamool Congress candidate from Dinhat in the 2026 Assembly elections.

Ex-Kerala CM's daughter Veena appears before ED in PMLA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ KOCHI

Veena T, daughter of former Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan, on Wednesday appeared before the Enforcement Directorate (ED) here for questioning in connection with a money laundering case involving her now-defunct IT firm and mining company CMRL. Veena appeared before ED close to 10.30 am following a fresh summons issued to her by the agency.

A heavy police presence was outside the ED office, where Veena got out of her vehicle and walked inside.

The agency had earlier asked her to appear before its Kochi unit on June 12, but she had expressed her inability to do so, citing health reasons. She was asked to appear before the agency along with relevant documents related to transactions involving her now-defunct IT firm, Exalogic



Solutions Private Ltd.

On Tuesday, the ED had questioned the son and wife of CMRL Founder Sasidharan Kartha in connection with the case. Prior to that, on Monday, the agency had questioned Kartha's daughter in the matter.

The probe pertains to allegations that Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL) made payments amounting to ₹2.78 crore to Exalogic without receiving any services in return.

According to the ED, another company, Empower India Capital Investments Private Limited (EICPL), operated by CMRL Managing Director Sasidharan Kartha,

had extended loans worth ₹50 lakh to Exalogic despite the company allegedly failing to make timely repayments.

The agency has alleged that Veena and the management of CMRL, led by Kartha, generated "proceeds of crime" through these transactions.

The ED registered a case under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) on the basis of a prosecution complaint filed by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) before a court in Ernakulam in April 2025. The SFIO is the investigation arm of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs.

CMRL came under the scanner of central agencies following an Income Tax Department raid in January 2019, which allegedly detected financial irregularities, including certain expenses suspected to be fictitious and amounting to around ₹130 crore.

100% distribution of enumeration forms in Sikkim: CEO Yadav

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

Sikkim has achieved 100 per cent distribution of enumeration forms (EF) to eligible voters during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Raj Singh Yadav said on Wednesday.

"We have achieved 100 per cent distribution of EFs in Sikkim, way ahead of the



deadline," he told. Yadav urged all eligible voters to make a timely submission of filled EFs for preparation of draft electoral roll in Sikkim.

Yadav, however, said that

distribution alone does not guarantee inclusion in the draft electoral roll as the electors who have received the forms must ensure that they are duly filled and submitted to their respective Booth Level Officers (BLOs) on or before June 28, the prescribed deadline for submission.

He said that electors who fail to submit their forms by the deadline would not be included in the draft electoral roll.

UCC bill will be passed in Assembly's monsoon session: MP CM Mohan Yadav

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Wednesday said a bill to implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Madhya Pradesh will be introduced in the State Assembly's upcoming monsoon session and expressed confidence that it will be passed with the blessings of Lord Mahakal.

Yadav was speaking to reporters after a ceremony held in the Assembly premises to pay tribute to former State CM Kailash Nath Katju on his birth anniversary.

The five-day monsoon session of the MP Assembly will be held from July 20.

Asked if the Government will introduce the UCC bill in the monsoon session, Yadav said the Government will bring many important and contemporary issues to the Assembly session.

"The Uniform Civil Code bill will also be introduced in this session. With the blessings of Baba Mahakal, the UCC bill will be passed this session," he added.



The five-day session is expected to feature the presentation of the first supplementary Budget for 2026-27, along with discussions on several important bills and amendments.

Yadav had said earlier this month that the Uniform Civil Code would soon be implemented in the State. The Government has formed a six-member committee headed by a retired Supreme Court judge and said it was visiting various districts to gather suggestions from people of all religions.

"After compiling their report, we would like the Uniform Civil Code to be implemented in Madhya

Pradesh as soon as possible. The State also wishes for it to be implemented," the CM said.

A website regarding the UCC was also launched, and Chief Minister Yadav appealed to the public to share their suggestions.

The Opposition Congress expressed concern over the UCC, claiming it could pose a serious threat to the identity, traditions and constitutional rights of the tribal community.

Former minister and State Congress media in-charge Mukesh Nayak alleged that the Government wants to divide people in the name of equality.

PM Modi rebuilt India as bastion of security in 12 years: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday hailed the 12 years of the Modi Government, and said the country has been rebuilt as a "bastion of security" that shields its citizens and responds firmly to threats during this period.

In a post on X, Shah said that under the Modi Government's leadership, India has set examples of its resolute commitment to national security for the world to admire. "In the 12 years of the Modi Government, our nation has been rebuilt as a bastion of security that shields the citizens and unleashes destruction upon its enemies," Shah said.

"Whether it is responding to enemies across the border with the firepower of surgical strike, air strike and Operation Sindoor, abrogating Article 370, eradicating Naxalism or fortifying internal securi-



ty with over 12 accords in the Northeast, India has set examples of its resolute commitment to national security for the world to admire," he said.

The BJP-led NDA Government under Narendra Modi recently completed 12 years in office at the Centre. Last week, Modi became India's longest continuously serving elected prime minister, completing 4,399 consecutive days in office and surpassing the record held by India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru.

Movement on right track to become political party by July: Annamalai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

His "We the Leaders" movement launched recently was on the "right track" to transition into a political party by July and the goal is to achieve 50 lakh membership, former BJP Tamil Nadu president K Annamalai said on Wednesday.

Pointing out that at present 18 lakh members have joined the organisation "without any expectations," Annamalai, in a video interaction on a social media platform, said that membership was taking place not only online but also by meeting the people directly.

Stating that the members have joined with the belief that the movement would



bring in a big change, he said "after we start this movement as a political outfit, its activities will take on a different nature from this July and people are going to see it."

Claiming that his movement "will not fail, will not lie, and will not lead the people to the wrong path",

Annamalai said "for us, we are equal to all religions and there is no second thought about that".

"Our aim in the coming months is that this membership drive will keep going", he said. "As we move forward, our objective is to transform our organisation into a people's movement to

6 killed, 20 injured as bus crashes into truck in Vadodara



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

Six persons were killed and nearly 20 others injured after a private bus rammed into a parked truck on a highway in Gujarat's Vadodara district in the early hours of Wednesday, police said.

The accident occurred near Kotambi village on the Vadodara-Halol highway at around 4 am.

The luxury bus, heading from Rajasthan to Surat in Gujarat, crashed into the rear side of the truck, Vadodara District Superintendent of Police Sushil Agrawal said.

The truck had been parked on the roadside as its driver was checking tyre pressure when the speeding bus hit it from behind, he said.

"The impact of the collision was severe, and the front portion of the bus was completely crushed. Six people died in the accident, while around 20 others sustained injuries and were shifted to hospitals for treatment," Agrawal said. A majority of the passengers travelling in the bus were from Rajasthan, the official said.

Personnel from the Jarod police station in Vadodara rural rushed to the spot after receiving information about the accident and launched rescue operations.

Considering the extent of damage to the bus, teams of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) were also called to assist in the rescue efforts, the SP said, adding that further investigation was underway.

NIA attaches land of terror case accused in J&K's Baramulla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday attached two plots of land in Baramulla district of Jammu and Kashmir under the stringent Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA), officials said.

The plots measuring 7.5 marla (2,050 square feet) and 6 marla (1,632 square feet) in Kanispora belong to Shaheen Ahmad Lone, an accused in a case registered by the NIA in 2020, the officials said.

The attachment was carried out on the basis of an order issued by a designated NIA court in Jammu under Section 33 (1) of the UAPA.

The attachment is part of



the NIA's high-profile investigation into a deep-rooted conspiracy involving the banned terror outfit Hizbul Mujahideen and Pakistani state agencies to fuel terrorism in India.

The investigation focuses on the illegal arms network, terror funding and the interception of Hizbul terrorists alongside former deputy superintendent of police Devender Singh.

BJP demands probe into petrol bomb attack on RSS office in Ranchi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday sought a thorough probe into the alleged hurling of petrol bombs at the RSS office in Ranchi, and said it reflects the law and order situation in Jharkhand under the JMM-Congress Government. The remarks came after unidentified persons allegedly threw petrol bombs at the RSS office in Ranchi early Wednesday.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla claimed the incident appears to be part of a larger conspiracy and called for a thorough investigation to identify those behind it.

"Two people have thrown petrol bombs at the RSS office in Ranchi. It shows the kind of law and order situation prevailing in Jharkhand



under the JMM-Congress Government," he said in a video statement.

Poonawalla said there should be a thorough investigation into the incident to identify the perpetrators and ascertain the motive behind the attack.

"There should be a complete probe, a deep probe, so that we can unearth who the mastermind behind such acts is and what the objective is," he said.

He alleged the attack

appears to be part of a larger conspiracy and referred to "hostile" remarks made against the RSS by certain people in recent times.

"But we have also seen that there appears to be a conspiracy, and the targeting of the RSS seems to be part of a bigger plan. We have seen the kind of vitriolic statements being made against the RSS by certain people recently, and then this attack happens," Poonawalla said.

While saying no direct link should be drawn between the remarks and the incident, he claimed that an atmosphere of hostility was being created against the RSS and warned that such rhetoric could have dangerous consequences.

"One should not directly link the two. But one should be very clear that some kind of poison and vitriol is being spread against the RSS, and that can have dangerous consequences," he added.

Questioning the "growing intolerance" towards the RSS, Poonawalla said those responsible for spreading hatred against nationalist organisations must be identified. "Why is such intolerance, hatred and hostility being peddled by certain elements against nationalist organisations like the RSS? These questions need to be answered," he said.

Puducherry cabinet expansion: Three ministers sworn in

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

P Rajavelu, V P Sivakolundhu and G N S Rajasekaran, belonging to the AINRC and BJP, were sworn in as ministers by Puducherry Lt Governor K Kailashnathan at a ceremony held at Lok Niwas here on Wednesday.

All three ministers took the oath of office and secrecy, marking the expansion of the Rangasamy-led ministry. The newly inducted ministers bring significant legislative experience to the cabinet. While Rajavelu is a former Deputy Speaker of the territorial assembly, Sivakolundhu is a former Speaker.

Rajasekaran was elected in the April 9 Assembly polls from Tirunallar in the Karaikal region.

Before the oaths were administered, Chief Secretary Sharat Chauhan



read out the Home Ministry's notification on the appointment of three members as Ministers of Puducherry.

The notification was issued by President Droupadi Murmu on June 8. The ceremony was attended among others by legislators, officials and delegates of different organisations.

The induction of these MLAs into the Rangasamy-led cabinet brings the total number of ministers to six. Traditionally, Puducherry has a six-member cabinet.



Editor's
TAKE

Indian lives matter: The world must listen

PM Modi's G7 remarks on the deaths of seafarers underscored India's commitment to its citizens' safety and well-being anywhere in the world

The lakeside resort town of Évian-les-Bains hosted this week a summit that carries the weight of a world fracturing at its seams. The 52nd G7 – convened by France amid the ruins of a US-Iran war and a grinding conflict in Ukraine – happened at a critical juncture, with a plethora of issues to be discussed. But it was a quieter, more human moment when Prime Minister Narendra Modi raised his voice for the men who sail the world's oceans and fall to the guns of geopolitics through no fault of their own. Modi's intervention at the G7 outreach session was pointed and personal. Days before the summit, three Indian nationals were killed when US forces struck the Palau-flagged oil tanker Settebello in the Gulf of Oman – a vessel crewed almost entirely by Indians. At Évian, the Prime Minister took that protest to the highest table. It was diplomacy at its most necessary – and its most uncomfortable.

The summit's formal agenda reflects an era of overlapping crises. Leaders convened around three broad pillars: geopolitical stabilisation (Iran, Ukraine and the fragile ceasefire in West Asia), economic resilience (tariffs, supply chain diversification and the spectre of stagflation), and technology governance (AI, quantum computing and digital infrastructure).

France, as host, pushed hard for a renewed commitment to multilateralism – a direct rebuke to the transactional nationalism that has defined Washington's posture for years. The Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway, handles an estimated 20 per cent of the world's oil supply, and when it becomes a theatre of war – with tankers struck, crews killed and insurance premiums spiking – every item on the G7 agenda is affected: energy prices, supply chains, inflation targets and even the geopolitical leverage of nations.

This is precisely why Modi's maritime intervention was not a digression. It was a diagnosis. The Settebello incident is not an isolated tragedy. Since West Asian tensions escalated, Indian seafarers have borne a disproportionate burden of maritime insecurity. India supplies roughly 12 per cent of the world's seafarers – over 200,000 sailors at any given time navigating waters that powerful nations treat as extensions of their military campaigns. When the US strikes a tanker in the name of strategic objectives, it is often an Indian who dies. The G7's grand statements about open trade and global stability ring hollow unless they reckon with this asymmetry: that the citizens of non-G7 nations – particularly India, the Philippines and Ukraine – pay with their lives for crises they did not create and conflicts they did not choose.

The path ahead demands action on multiple fronts. Globally, G7 nations must embed civilian maritime safety – including legal protections for merchant crews in conflict zones – into any framework for resolving the Iran and West Asia crises. Maritime law must be enforced in both letter and spirit. For India specifically, the way forward is clear: build institutional muscle, not just diplomatic rhetoric. New Delhi must push for a binding international convention on seafarer safety in conflict zones. India's seafarers are not collateral. They are Indian citizens.

Can unity overcome internal fault lines?

As the opposition alliance prepares for future electoral battles, its ability to reconcile differences, strengthen coordination and reinvent itself in tune with public aspirations will determine if it can evolve into a credible national force



KALYANI
SHANKAR

The INDIA bloc, representing a coalition of opposition parties, recently gathered in Delhi to reflect on its journey so far and to share hopes for the future. On June 8, during a meeting organised by the Congress party, 23 out of the original 27 members expressed their strong commitment to working together, highlighting their dedication to unity and collaboration in these challenging times.

Some parties, such as the Trinamool Congress and the DMK, face challenges in their respective states. This has raised concerns about the alliance's chances in national elections. However, these challenges can also be seen as opportunities for growth. Recognising setbacks can strengthen the alliance and help supporters believe in its ability to overcome local issues.

At the meeting, the alliance agreed on a five-point plan. This plan includes writing to the Chief Justice of India about electoral manipulation and calling for the Education Minister to resign. The alliance also decided to meet at least once every two months.

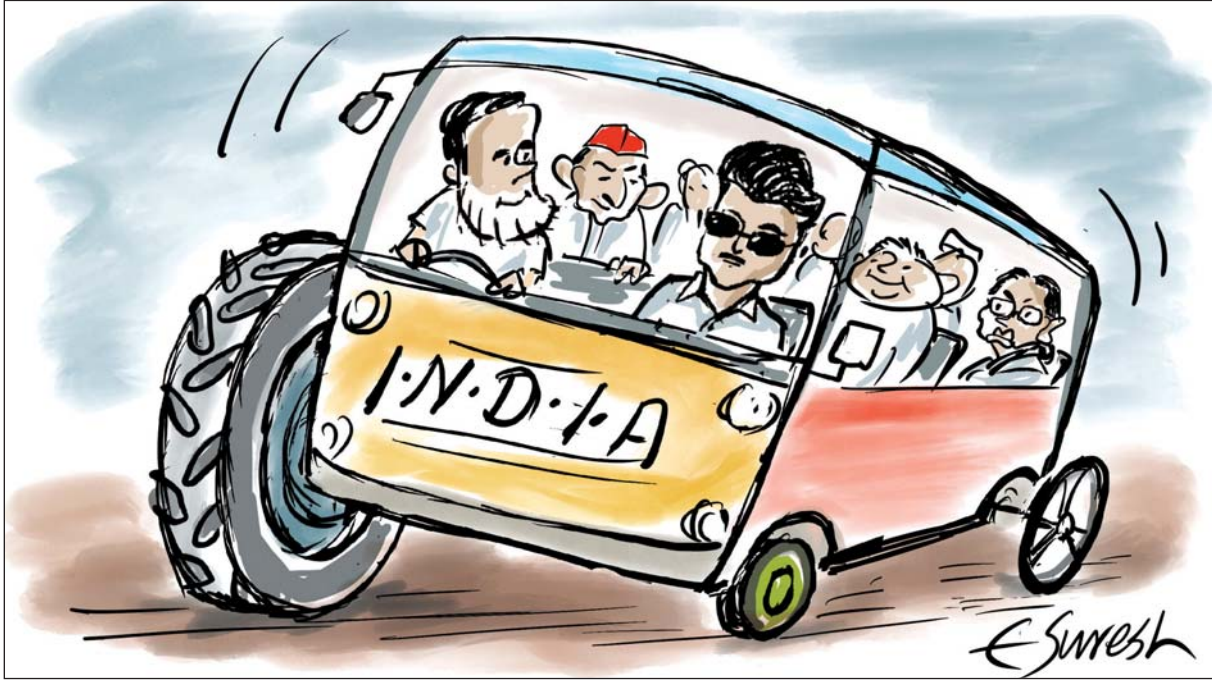
In the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the INDIA bloc achieved significant success by reducing the BJP's seat count. Now, the BJP depends on allies such as the Janata Dal (United) and the Telugu Desam Party to maintain its majority, underscoring that political power is always shifting.

The recent meeting, led by the Congress party and attended by leaders such as Mamata Banerjee, focused on reaching a renewed agreement. This plan is designed to improve communication, schedule meetings every two months and develop joint strategies to address national issues such as the economy and unemployment.

While there are some internal conflicts and the loss of key players like the DMK and AAP, the alliance still has a strong foundation. A setback occurred in June when Congress allied with Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, which might upset some members but could also lead to renewal.

The meeting revealed divisions within the alliance that became clear during the recent Assembly elections. Some parties found themselves on different sides. The DMK, an important partner from the South, did not attend the meeting due to disagreements over the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. Congress then ended its partnership with the DMK and teamed up with Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam post-poll.

In his nearly 15-minute speech, Rahul



THE ALLIANCE'S
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The writer is a
popular columnist

dailypioneer
 @kalyanishankar
 The Pioneer

Gandhi expressed disappointment with some partners for not supporting issues such as the alleged "vote chori". He also criticised parties that attack Congress. Rahul Gandhi cautioned allies against undermining one another and urged them to unite in their fight against the BJP for the sake of the country and the Constitution. "Let me tell you, it is easy to beat them if we stand together and resist," he said.

Akhilesh Yadav of the Samajwadi Party and Tejashwi Yadav of the Rashtriya Janata Dal urged Congress to recognise the importance of regional parties in the fight against the BJP-led government.

On April 17, 2026, the bloc united in the Lok Sabha to defeat the Modi government's harmful delimitation Bills. It must now strengthen this spirit to tackle the political, economic, social and foreign policy challenges arising from the government's misgovernance, said Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge. Addressing important economic issues such as rising unemployment and inflation is crucial. The central government should call an all-party meeting to discuss these issues and work together.

During the Monsoon Session, improving coordination in Parliament will be a top priority. There will be daily meetings at the office of the Leader of the Opposition, Mallikarjun Kharge. The INDIA Alliance has agreed to meet every two months, with the next meeting planned for August in Hyderabad.

The future of the INDIA bloc depends on its ability to integrate diverse political views, develop effective election strategies and

advance initiatives such as regional outreach programmes and policy reforms. Strengthening ties with voters and supporting grassroots movements is essential. How the bloc manages disagreements and collaborates will shape its effectiveness.

While the INDIA bloc faces challenges, it also has potential. Retaining around 23 parties demonstrates a strong foundation that can prevent collapse. Although losing influential regional players like the DMK and AAP presents difficulties, the alliance's commitment to unity and engagement with voters prepares it for future opportunities.

The INDIA bloc's strategies, unity and responsiveness will play a vital role in addressing the needs of communities. This moment offers a valuable opportunity to grow together, collaborate and revitalise the INDIA bloc to serve the people.

However, it is important for the Opposition to genuinely reinvent itself to connect with the current realities that people face.

As for the future, it is clear that the INDIA bloc's strategies, unity and responsiveness will play a vital role in addressing the needs of communities. This moment offers a valuable opportunity to grow together.

However, it is important for the Opposition to genuinely reinvent itself to connect with the current realities people face.

The alliance's future success depends on the partners sticking to a five-point agreement made in June 2026. This plan aims to improve collaboration, election readiness and unity, highlighting the importance of working together.

Rediscovering hope, purpose and life

A person who lives meaningfully learns to cherish relationships. He values human bonds, understands emotions and discovers beauty even in ordinary moments. He learns from suffering, delights in small joys and gradually acquires emotional balance. That is where a person's true courage, wisdom and intellect lie.

Life is a blend of joys and sorrows. Light and darkness follow one another. The dazzling light gradually fades into darkness, and even pitch darkness, in the course of time, must yield to penetrating light. Neither is permanent. This is the eternal law of nature.

Human beings gladly welcome happiness and revel in it. But when sorrow strikes, many lose their peace of mind. Unable to bear pain and disappointment, they become emotionally unstable and begin to view death as an escape.

At such critical moments, the wisdom gained through experience, the values nurtured from childhood, the strength imparted by education and even ordinary common sense seem to disappear. Man completely loses his sense of judgement.

"Man is a wonderful creation. In all of living creation, he is the most supreme, powerful and resourceful," said Shakespeare. Indeed, among all living beings, man alone is blessed with an extraordinary power of

thought. From the days of the primitive caveman to the modern technological age, humanity has undergone astonishing evolution and unimaginable transformation. Through his ever-sharpening intellect, man has achieved remarkable progress in knowledge, science, civilisation and technology.

Yet, a disturbing question remains.

When sorrows surround him, why does man fail to display the same maturity and mental strength? Why does such a brilliant mind lose its resilience in moments of distress? Does he forget that troubles are temporary? Does he fail to realise that no night lasts forever?

This beautiful life must be lived until its very end.

We must protect our families, nurture our relationships and keep our loved ones safe and flourishing. Only then can we truly taste the sweet nectar of life. We must preserve our great civilisation, artistic brilliance and precious literature, passing them on to future generations. The humane qualities within man must multiply. He must

grow into a person of wisdom, compassion and discernment.

If such a transformation takes place, could there be any heaven greater than this very earth?

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a columnist, lecturer and radio presenter. He has delivered several talks on spirituality and literature

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India deserves strong answers

Appropos the headline, "PM raises maritime security concerns before Trump talks" (June 17), President Trump neither expressed regret over the deaths of Indian mariners, for whom the entire nation grieves, nor showed any meaningful concern about the disruption to India's oil supplies and the economic losses arising from the conflict. Perhaps Washington recognises that the reported peace arrangement with Iran remains fragile. Israel, which played a central role in the conflict, appears to have been left outside the framework, leaving significant uncertainties unresolved. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was therefore right to raise India's concerns directly at the highest level.

This was particularly important given recent strains in bilateral relations. President Trump's tariff policies, his comments on Operation Sindoor, and incidents involving attacks on commercial shipping have all contributed to concerns in India regarding American policy priorities.

The G7 summit took place at a time of heightened geopolitical uncertainty. While leaders may project optimism and issue broad statements about stability and cooperation, genuine progress requires concrete commitments and measurable outcomes. Symbolic diplomacy is not enough when lives and livelihoods are at stake.

VINOD JOHRI | DELHI

G7 must deliver cooperation

This refers to the news report, "PM Modi to participate in G7 Summit in Évian". The summit comes at a time when the international community faces multiple challenges, including geopolitical tensions, trade disruptions, climate concerns and economic uncertainty. France occupies an important place in India's strategic vision. Discussions between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French leaders are expected to strengthen cooperation in diplomacy, defence, trade and technology, reflecting the growing depth of India-France relations.

The G7 remains an important political and economic forum where issues such as trade security, climate change and global development are discussed. India, along with Brazil, South Korea, Kenya and Egypt, has been invited as a partner nation to contribute to deliberations on matters of global importance. Prime Minister Modi is expected to articulate the concerns of the Global South, particularly on development, economic stability and multilateral cooperation. His participation offers an opportunity to strengthen India's role in shaping international discourse. The recent easing of tensions between the United States and Iran is also welcome. If India contributes to regional stability, it will serve both national interests and global peace.

YUGAL KISHORE SHARMA | FARIDABAD

Expanding India's strategic reach

This refers to the editorial, "PM Modi's Slovakia Visit: Opening New Frontiers" (17 June). The Bratislava summit demonstrates that India's foreign policy is most effective when it focuses on building long-term frameworks rather than short-term optics.

The elevation of India-Slovakia ties to a Comprehensive Partnership, along with agreements covering defence, semiconductors, artificial intelligence and labour mobility, reflects a strategic approach to Europe. Particularly noteworthy is the establishment of an ICCR Chair in Artificial Intelligence at the Technical University of Košice. Academic and institutional partnerships often outlast political cycles and create enduring foundations for cooperation. The broader emphasis on diversification is equally important. India's traditional concentration on a limited set of strategic relationships has often created vulnerabilities. Central and Eastern European countries possess growing industrial capabilities and increasing political influence within the European Union. Strengthening ties with these nations is therefore both timely and prudent.

Slovakia's backing of India's UNSC and NSG aspirations is a notable gain. The visit reinforces India's focus on long-term strategic partnerships.

KP MUTHUKUMAR | CHENNAI

PIC TALK



A farmer prepares his field for cultivation in Assam's Nagaon district.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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ETHANOL POLICY NEEDS PUBLIC TRUST AND TRANSPARENCY

The relationship between a government and its citizens is built on a simple principle: the people speak and the government listens. When that principle weakens, democracy risks becoming an exercise in instruction rather than participation. The ethanol-blending programme increasingly appears to illustrate this growing disconnect. When E20 petrol was introduced, citizens were told it was necessary for the nation. We were informed that it would support farmers, reduce dependence on imported oil and contribute to energy security. However, consumers were given few convincing answers about lower fuel efficiency, higher running costs and continuing concerns regarding vehicle compatibility.

Since E20 contains 20 per cent ethanol, many expected some meaningful price advantage.

Instead, consumers have watched fuel prices remain high while being repeatedly encouraged to accept the benefits of ethanol blending. The economic burden, however, continues to be borne largely by motorists. More concerning is the discussion surrounding E85 and even E100 fuels before the practical implications of E20 have been fully assessed. Such moves create the impression that decisions are being advanced without sufficient public consultation. A policy of this scale requires transparency, accountability and public confidence. Citizens deserve clear information about costs, benefits and long-term implications before further expansion takes place.

Is the government governing with the people or merely over them? Increasingly, citizens fear the latter.

NOOPUR BARUAH | TEZPUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

1857 folklore: A national heritage

The folk songs of 1857, composed by talented poets, form part of our national heritage and provide valuable insight into the aspirations of the Indian people during the 1857 struggle. This literary heritage must be documented, popularised and preserved



Madho Singh, highly agitated, vowing to cross swords with the British before they died. In 1842, the 65 year old Kunwar was particularly exercised. He had seen the Maratha heydays.

India could regain its glory. Kunwar Singh had been active in anti-British plots during the Sikh wars. The Bengal Army regiments deployed west of the Indus had a serious effect on their morale. The Muslim sipahis were demoralised for having been deployed against a Muslim state (Afghanistan). The 2nd Bengal Cavalry, during the 1st Afghan war, had refused to fight against Dost Mohammad and was therefore disbanded.

Let us try and comprehend the communal situation of that period. Shah Waliullah, a Delhi Maulvi had translated the Koran into Persian. His son Shah Abdul Aziz translated the Koran into Urdu. Aziz declared India dar-ul-harb (enemy territory) the moment Lord Lake captured Delhi from the Marathas in 1803. Shah Waliullah had spoken out against the Marathas.

Yet he had not proclaimed India as dar-ul-harb (Islam's enemy territory) when Marathas were in power. Shah Waliullah's followers, termed 'Islamic fundamentalists' by the British, did not regard Sanatan Dharmis as the 'other'. The Mughal-Maratha alliance was considered natural.

Shah Waliullah's movement, dubbed Wahabi by the British, had nothing to do with the orthodox Middle East trends. It was a quintessentially Indian movement of liberation, fought when the East India Company was seen not merely as an exploitative arm of the British Empire, but also as an alien force bent upon re-engineering Indian society.

As for dealing with the 1857 Rising per se, this was an armed mass movement and a planned political revolution of the Indian people as a whole, at one and the same time. Conscious actors and spontaneous masses played a crucial part - the peasantry was the leading force. 1857 was more 'nationalist' than the Congress led twentieth century freedom movement. People and forces from Gilgit to Tamil Nadu and from Manipur to Maharashtra fought for common aims.

The 1857 movement continued well up till 1875; in Bundelkhand, the last 'Sepoy war' bullets were being fired even in the 1880s. Refusing British offers of jagirs and an 'honorable' retirement in any place other than Lucknow and UP, Begum Hazrat Mahal died in Nepal, unvanquished and unconquered. The British never found Nana Saheb, his brothers (Baba Bhut and Bala Rao), and Azimullah Khan. They had 'vanished into thin air'. Rao Tula Ram was never 'caught'. In 1859, Tanya Tope was 'caught' and hanged — but, till the 1890s, the British remained skeptical, whether they had 'tried' the right man.

One of Nana Saheb's last letters, written in April 1859, in response to British charges of him being a murderer of women and children, is an extraordinary document. It reveals that Nana was not only willing to fight, but had preserved soldiers and had a plan, that Begum Hazrat Mahal had arranged to attack Calcutta and free Wajid Ali Shah, before marching on to Delhi, with a Poorabia-Gurkha force.

In overall strategic terms, the combination of mass movements and armed action was a major 1857 highlight. Defeat nowhere meant that revolutionaries were broken. The conventional view is that Indians lost militarily and politically.

From Chinhat to Kanpur to Arrah to Jharkhand to Orissa, Maharashtra and Gujarat, every major Indian victory was achieved in the open field, with our sipahis blending European with Asiatic tactics. The revolutionary sipahi fighting big battles had not commanded more than a platoon before 1857. This Indian performance was indeed historic — there is no such parallel in either the American War of Independence or the French Revolution.

The Afghan War in the early 1840s dealt a decisive blow to British pride. Then came the Crimean War reverses. The defeat of the army of Indus in 1842 sent signals to the Indian sipahi that their British masters were no longer invincible. The folklore of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh speak of Kunwar Singh and Beni



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

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The writer is Advisor,
Bharat Ki Soch

dailypioneer

@59raghvendra

The Pioneer

The Indian post-Independence elite was cut off from 1857 memories. The Bahadur Shah Zafar-Wajid Ali Shah-Nana Saheb ethos was permanently lost. The true figures of how many Indians lost their life in 1857 has never been researched. Preliminary enquiry is staggering, almost unbelievable. Some 30,00,000 Sanatan Dharmis perished in the Kranti. As per British records, the rough estimate is about 25,00,000 killed in Awadh alone.

The British thinking had rested on the theory that once the Hindu-Muslim alliance was broken, India and Indian-ness could simply be effaced. The India of Ram and Krishna, Muhammad, Guru Nanak, khayal, tappa, thumri, bhajan, gurubaani and qawwali would simply have vanished - there would be no Indian State power, even such as we have today. In this sense, 1857 fighters won the battle of civilisation.

After the 1857 war, European imperialism woke up to Asiatic assertion and gave up its plan of doctoring Asia culturally. Countries as diverse as Egypt, Turkey, Iraq, Iran, Russia, Afghanistan, China, Indonesia, Malaysia, Japan, Vietnam and Korea reaped the benefits of this event.

But, there is a lamentable lack of sound historical material from an Indian point of view. The conditions of terror that prevailed post 1857 were such that any writing from an Indian's point of view, his version of 1857 history, seriously risked his skin. And it is precisely for this reason that the folk songs on 1857 constitute a very valuable source material. Their supreme value lies in the fact that they constitute an authentic record of the outlook of people whom they portray. There is a rich gold mine of it waiting for it to be explored, reflective of our living love of common people for writing the history of 1857.

In the folklore, one often finds those who went against the national uprising cursed as traitors. The people of those days had the political sagacity to differentiate between the patriots and the traitors. There runs through these folk songs, a burning hatred of the firangis. The deeds most glorified are the ones of fighting the firangi. The virtues most admired are bravery, courage and sacrifice. The real shame is known to lie in passivity and submission.

The folk songs of 1857 were written by a host of most talented folk poets. This literature is part of our national heritage which forms an important source of historical material on the outlook and aspirations of the Indian people during the 1857 struggle. But most unfortunately, they are little known part of our patriotic poetic heritage. There is a strong need to document, popularise and enrich this national literature.

It is also necessary to put this to heart-warming music for stirring the nation's patriotic sentiments. It would be a fitting addition to our heritage of national music. To treasure, study and sing them is a simple way of paying the debt back to our forefathers who gave their lives during the kranti. The deeply moving and rousing incidents that find mention in the 1857 folklore can be excellent resource for inspirational creative work in our national literature and art.

Gharuan Craftsmen: Carriers of heritage



SUKHDEV SINGH

to serve the Nihangs who are the main consumers of 'Sarb Loh' utensils and other objects as a tradition of Guru Gobind Singh ji. The Nihangs, a sect among the Sikhs, take pride in carrying the tradition of the Guru truly. They wear traditional long robes of blue colour, rear, and ride horses and carry traditional weapons like swords, spears, and chakram or war quoit etc. made of 'Sarb Loh'; Like nomads they keep moving from one to the other place, although they have their settlements too.

When Guru Gobind Singh Ji founded the Khalsa in 1699, he used a 'Sarb Loh' bowl and 'Khanda' (a double-edged sword) to prepare 'Amrit' (the nectar of immortality). At that time, 'Sarb Loh' vessels were commonly used for preparing Langar (community meals) and for cooking and dining in ordinary households. Following the tradition of robes, utensils and lifestyle as a Maryada, the Nihangs have continued to maintain the need for and relevance of the 'Sarb Loh' utensils. The artisans living in Gharuan village too have continued the centuries old tradition and technique struggling to fight the market and popular trend pressures.

It is said that the seventh Guru of the Sikhs, Guru Har Rai had stayed in Gharuan on his way to Kiratpur and blessed the village for the Sarb Loh craft. According to the oral folk narratives, the Guru was presented a 'Sarb Loh' bowl by the elder of the 'Jhiunt' (a sub-caste) family of the artisans. The Gurudwara named Deg Sahib, also called Gurudwara Patshahi Satvin (seventh) in the village, is dedicated to the Seventh Guru's visit. According to the folk narratives, even the bowl used by Guru Gobind Singh Ji for preparing Amrit at the time of creating Khalsa was crafted by the artisans of Gharuan.

During those days, the Sarb Loh utensils were essential for those in rugged or mobile professions like military. Since Guru Gobind Singh ji enrolled the masses in his army who were mostly on move and in war, the 'Sarb Loh' utensils were the best choice due to their affordability, durability, easy maintenance, heat retention, and versatility. Moreover, they helped replenish the body's iron levels. These utensils, made from a metal that was cheaper, stronger, and less fragile than the other metals and easy to clean scrubbing with sand or dust, were more functional than decorative.

Valued for durability, heat retention, and versatility, iron cookware in common households had already spread globally; in Punjab and neighbouring regions, 'Sarb Loh' wok, griddle, spatula, and ladle for cooking; bucket, and pots for drawing and storing water from wells; and bowl and spoon for serving food were popular in common households. Degs (large bowls), Cauldron and other utensils of bigger size were used to cook for larger gatherings. Following the development of steel-an alloy of iron, carbon, chromium, nickel, and manganese- and its use in industrial production of cookware, the utensils made from 'Sarb Loh' and other metals like Copper, Brass, and Bronze gradually disappeared from the common households in Punjab and other parts of India beginning the second half of twentieth century.

Consequently, the demand for the work of 'Sarb Loh' artisans and their income declined. Due to the 'hard labour but low returns' in this work, the younger generation largely turned away from this craft. In such circumstances, the Nihang Singhs and the 'Gharuan' craftsmen deserve appreciation and attention for upholding the 'Sarb Loh' tradition. Recently, a trend is setting in favour of Sarb Loh utensils with a belief of their medicinal relevance. However, the history of 'Sarb Loh' vessels is not linked to medicinal reasons; rather, it is associated with human innovation and the practical application of these discoveries in everyday life. Literally, 'Sarb Loh' means "pure" or "unalloyed" iron; but, in reality, it is an alloy of iron and carbon. Since the percentage of carbon in the alloy can be as low as less than 1 per cent, it is called 'Sarb Loh' or all iron. Practically, pure iron is too soft to use it for making utensils and other tools. The carbon in iron adds the essential hardness and tensile strength to it ensuring that the cookware retains its shape when used. Thus, in metallurgy, 'Sarb Loh' is wrought iron i.e. a low-carbon alloy; due to its low alloy properties, it signifies purity and has been used metaphorically in some sacred texts as a reference to God. The evolution and history of 'Sarb Loh' utensils is a long journey-spanning from unique vessels made of rare metal "iron from the sky" to the commonplace industrial goods made of "iron from the earth": the discovery and use of iron began between 5000 and 3000 BCE, when the only source of the metal was meteorites falling from the sky. Consequently, thus produced iron was rarer and more valuable than any other metal then, and the objects made from it were used only by royal families. Iron became common only when the metal began to be extracted from terrestrial minerals and rocks. By 1200 BCE, smelting techniques had been developed which transformed the "metal from the sky" into a "metal from the earth".

But, due to the secrecy surrounding the techniques, iron objects yet remained accessible only to the elite. After 1200 BCE, when 'blacksmiths' began mass-producing iron utensils using metal-smelting and forging technologies, these items became accessible to the lower-middle classes. The increased availability of iron and the large-scale production of goods with it shifted the perception of these vessels from symbols of 'opulence and grandeur' to mere 'utilitarian objects'. Since the Sikhs and soldiers of Guru Gobind Singh Ji largely belonged to the working class and were constantly engaged in warfare, they used iron vessels not as symbols of a 'sacred or elite' status, but because they were affordable, durable, practical, and easy to clean. The Nihangs have continued the tradition as Maryada and the Gharuan craftsmen have served them well. The governments should recognise the craft skills (intangible heritage) and its objects (tangible heritage) by arranging exhibitions, showcasing the objects in emporiums, recognising the craftsmen for their skills and providing the objects GST relief etc.



The writer is a former
Professor at Guru Nanak
Dev University, Amritsar,
and former Vice-Chairman
of INTACH

dailypioneer

@dailypioneer

The Pioneer

Empowering widows to rebuild their lives with dignity and independence



RAJINDER
PAUL LOOMBA

received a good education. Her strength and resilience inspired me to lifelong determination to ensure that widows are treated with dignity and given opportunities for economic independence and social inclusion Forty three-year later, in 1997 I founded The Loomba Foundation, with the mission of supporting widows and educating their children in memory of my late mother, who was my inspiration.

In 1999, the then Prime Minister, Atal Behari Vajpayee, launched our project to educate children of poor widows in India. To date the Loomba Foundation has educated over 10,000 children of poor widows in all the 30 states of India. Each beneficiary was given a monthly scholarship of ₹500 for a period of five years. This amount included school uniform, lunches, healthcare and sustenance amount for the mother.

Over the years, the Foundation has developed pioneering programmes focused on education,

empowerment and advocacy. More than 10,000 children of poor widows have received educational scholarships, helping to break cycles of poverty and social exclusion. The Foundation has also empowered over 20,000 widows through vocational training programmes in areas including tailoring, food processing, healthcare, hospitality and computer education.

These initiatives have enabled widows to become financially independent and rebuild their lives with dignity. I believe that widowhood should never condemn a woman to poverty, isolation or humiliation. The Foundation's work has extended across India and internationally, with activities in Africa, Asia, Europe and North America. In recognition of its global impact, The Loomba Foundation was granted Special Consultative Status with the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC).

Widows are treated badly in South Asia, Africa and other parts of the world. In some cases, they have to deal with murder, rape, prostitution, forced marriage, property theft, eviction and social isolation. There are an estimated 285 million widows worldwide and of these 100 million live in poverty and 81 million have been abused physically, psychologically and even sexually.

Perhaps our most historic achievement has been the establishment of International Widows Day. The campaign began in 2005 when the Foundation formally launched International Widows Day at the House of Lords in London. The aim was simple but ambitious — to bring global attention to the plight of widows and mobilise governments,



international organisations and civil society to act. That followed a tireless five-year international campaign International events were held across several countries to raise awareness of what he described as the "invisible suffering" of widows. The campaign gathered support from influential global personalities including former UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan, Cherie Blair, Hillary Clinton, Yoko Ono and leaders from several nations.

The breakthrough came on December 22, 2010, when the United Nations General Assembly unanimously adopted 23 June as United Nations International Widows Day. The first official UN-recognised observance took place on June 23, 2011 at UN Headquarters in New York. This landmark achievement ensured that widows' rights and welfare would no longer remain invisible

on the global agenda. Today, International Widows Day is observed annually around the world, highlighting the social, economic and human rights challenges faced by widows and their dependents.

As a member of the House of Lords, I have continued to champion widows' rights at every opportunity. My advocacy has helped redefine widowhood not simply as a social issue, but as a major human rights and development concern. Through research publications, international conferences and grassroots programmes,

Over 20,000 widows in Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, India, Nepal, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, South Africa, Malawi, Guatemala and Chile have so far benefited from the Loomba Foundation empowerment programmes, breaking the cycle of deprivation and transforming their prospects. In India, the Loomba Foundation, in partnership with the US India Friendship Alliance, a charitable arm of the US India Strategic Partnership Forum, started a 'Prosperity for Widows Project' to empower 5,000 marginalised widows in the state of Uttar Pradesh on January 1, 2023.

Loomba Foundation's Varanasi project to empower 5,000 widows was launched by the Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2016. That project not only helped the widows but it also supported 50,000 of their children and family members. Each widow has received training in tailoring for two months. Once the training was completed, the Foundation gave each beneficiary a sewing machine so that they could start their own business or work in a factory to earn money,

become self-reliant and be able to educate their children and support their family members.

Modi, who represents Varanasi in the Lok Sabha had said: "I met Lord Loomba about a year ago in Delhi and he mentioned that his foundation would like to support 5,000 widows in Varanasi. I commend their work and feel happy that both of them are present at this event here today". The "World Widows Report" presented to him; was the most authoritative and comprehensive country-wise data source on the plight of widows. The Report revealed that the number of widows in the world has gone up by 9 per cent since 2010. There are over 258 million widows and their 585 million children worldwide. Later, I appealed to the Prime Minister that "since there are over 46 million widows and over 100 million children in India who need support from all of us as individuals, policy makers and corporates alike, the Government should establish a 'National Commission for Widows' to help them."

Unless the Government comes forward to help widows, India will never be able to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals, which have been signed by all the governments, including India, at the 69th General Assembly of the United Nations in New York in September 2015.

The writer is the Founder of the
Loomba Foundation and a member
of the House of Lords,
United Kingdom

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 Order Order

**CJI takes note of Registry
misplacing case file**

Taking strong note of an allegation that a case file was purportedly misplaced by the Supreme Court registry, Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Wednesday said he would look into the issue.

The issue came to light when an advocate mentioned the matter before a bench comprising the CJI and Justice V Mohana. The advocate said a petition was filed earlier this month but it has not been listed for hearing yet.

The lawyer said they wrote to the registrar about it but the case has not been listed before the court as the file appeared to have been misplaced by the registry.

Citing urgency in the matter, she urged the bench that the plea be listed for hearing.

"It is a serious matter if the registry has misplaced the file. If our registry is misplacing the files in urgent matters, then do you think that I will only direct for listing? I must do something more," the CJI said.

He told the advocate to give the details.

"I would like to look into this inefficiency and find out what is the reason behind it," the CJI observed.

"Ask your AOR (advocate-on-record) to give a compliant to me during the day itself. I am very much available," the CJI said.

In May, a CJI-led bench had lashed out at the apex court registry, terming its conduct "nasty" and saying its officials think they were acting as "super Chief Justice of India".

The bench had made the observation while hearing a bail plea filed by an accused in an alleged investment fraud.

(PTI)

**SC seeks Delhi Police’s reply
on bail pleas of IM operatives**



The Supreme Court on Wednesday sought a response from Delhi Police on the bail pleas of two alleged Indian Mujahideen operatives, who have been in jail for around 12 years in connection with terror cases.

A bench of Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pandholi issued a notice to Delhi Police on the pleas of Mohd Saquib Ansari and Waqar Azhar, challenging the denial of bail by the Delhi High Court.

The bench said the principles laid down by the court in January, in which several Delhi riot accused were granted bail and activist Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam were denied bail for one year, will govern the case.

Additional Solicitor General Anil Kaushik, appearing for Delhi Police, said the high court order denying bail was a reasoned one, and had applied the principles laid down in the Gulfisha Fatima judgement (January 5, 2026).

The bench said, "What reasoned order? The judgement referred to is pending for reference. What are you saying? The KA Najeeb case will apply with all force here, subject to the way it has been interpreted in the Gulfisha Fathima case. You will have to file a counter."

The KA Najeeb case of 2021 recognised long delay in trial as a ground for bail in cases under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, overriding the statutory restrictions on bail under Section 43D(5) of the Act.

Saquib and Azhar were arrested in 2014 pursuant to an FIR registered by the Special Cell of Delhi Police.

The case originated when Mohd Quateel Siddiqui, an alleged member of Indian Mujahideen, was apprehended on November 21, 2011, near the Anand Vihar inter-state bus terminal in Delhi.

During interrogation, he disclosed the names of other persons, believed to be members of Indian Mujahideen, a banned terrorist outfit.

(PTI)

Cyber criminals ‘parasites’: SC

Cyber criminals are "parasites" who take money from innocent investors to dupe them and we have to be very harsh with them, the Supreme Court on Wednesday said.

The observations came from a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana which was hearing a plea filed by a man seeking clubbing of some FIRs lodged against him in different states.

"You people (cyber criminals) are parasites and you take money from innocent investors and dupe them. For cyber criminals, we have to be very harsh," the CJI observed.

The CJI said victims of such crimes were always pan-India.

"You cheat someone in Tamil Nadu, then you go to Jammu and Kashmir and then to the North-East," the CJI said, adding it would be in the society's interest that cyber criminals are kept behind the bars.

The top court refused to entertain the plea for clubbing of some FIRs lodged against the petitioner in different states.

The bench said the petitioner may approach the jurisdictional high court to seek relief.

(PTI)



Justice delayed before justice begins

How technology can free judges to deliver justice



VIVEK NARAYAN SHARMA

India's judicial pendency crisis is often described through staggering numbers. More than 4.5 crore cases are pending before district courts, over 70 lakh cases await adjudication in various High Courts, and tens of thousands remain pending before the Supreme Court. These figures routinely trigger calls for more judges, more courts and greater infrastructure.

While all these demands are legitimate, they often overlook a more fundamental problem. The real crisis is not merely that cases take years to conclude. It is that in far too many cases, years pass before the court even begins the substantive task of deciding the dispute.

Justice, in India, is frequently delayed before justice even begins.

For an ordinary litigant, the journey starts with hope. A suit is filed. A petition is instituted. A complaint is lodged. The expectation is simple — the court will hear the grievance and decide it on merits.

What follows, however, is often a long procedural odyssey.

Notices are issued but remain unserved. Fresh notices are directed. Summons return unexecuted. Alternate modes of service are sought. Multiple dates are consumed merely to ensure that all parties are brought before the court. Thereafter begins another familiar cycle. Time is sought for filing replies. Additional time is sought for filing rejoinders. Documents are produced in phases. Applications are moved to place additional material on record. Procedural compliance becomes an end in itself.

Years often pass before pleadings are completed and the matter is declared ready for hearing. By then, the litigant has already suffered the very prejudice that prompted the legal action. A landlord continues to remain out of possession. A commercial dispute remains unresolved. A contractual obligation remains unenforced. A family dispute continues to fester. A claimant seeking compensation continues to wait. The irony is striking.

Judges are appointed to decide disputes, yet a substantial portion of their valuable judicial time is spent managing procedure rather than adjudicating cases. Any lawyer who regularly appears before trial courts and courts exercising original jurisdiction is familiar with this reality. A considerable part of the daily board consists of procedural matters. Fresh summons, completion of service,



filing of pleadings, compliance reports, adjournment requests and miscellaneous procedural applications consume judicial time that could otherwise be devoted to evidence, arguments and judgment writing.

Even after a matter becomes ready, progress is often slow. Evidence recording, which should ideally proceed on a day-to-day basis, frequently stretches across months and years. On many days, witnesses are unavailable. Counsel seek adjournments. Parties remain absent. Administrative requirements intervene. Similarly, final arguments are often postponed because courts are burdened with numerous procedural matters listed on the same day.

The result is a system where judges spend a significant part of their working lives managing litigation rather than deciding it.

This is not merely a shortage-of-judges problem, it's a process-design problem.

For years, judicial reform has focused on increasing judicial strength. Certainly, India requires more judges. But even if judicial vacancies were filled overnight, the procedural architecture itself would continue to generate delay.

The next generation of judicial reforms must therefore focus on something more ambitious: redesigning litigation processes through technology.

India has already taken important steps through the e-Courts Mission Mode Project. E-filing, virtual hearings, electronic records and the National Judicial Data Grid have transformed many aspects of court functioning. Yet these initiatives have largely digitised existing processes. The next stage must focus on reimagining those processes altogether.

The greatest opportunity lies in automating the pre-adjudication stages of litigation. Consider service of notice. Today, service remains one of the most significant causes of delay. A modern litigation system should automatically generate and transmit notices through multiple verified channels, including WhatsApp, email, registered electronic addresses and traditional physical service wherever required. Litigants should be required to furnish verified contact details at the filing stage itself. False addresses and inaccurate information should invite serious consequences, including exemplary costs and appropriate legal action.

Technology today allows documents to reach parties within seconds. Courts should leverage this capability fully.

Similarly, once service is complete, the system should automatically create a time-bound digital litigation calendar.

Written statements could be required within a specified period. Rejoinders could follow within a fixed timeframe. Document disclosure, admission-denial exercises and procedural compliances could operate through an automated workflow monitored digitally rather than through repeated physical appearances before the court.

Automated reminders could be generated. Deadlines could be tracked electronically. Non-compliance could trigger predefined procedural consequences, subject to judicial discretion in exceptional circumstances.

Such a system would eliminate thousands of non-effective hearings across the country taking place every day. More importantly, it would allow judges to focus on substantive adjudication rather than

procedural supervision.

Artificial Intelligence can play an even greater role.

The fear that AI may replace judges is misplaced. The real opportunity lies in enabling judges to become more effective.

Imagine an AI-powered case readiness engine. Once pleadings are complete, the system could automatically identify admitted facts, disputed issues, prepare chronologies, generate document indexes, extract relevant statutory provisions and highlight procedural deficiencies.

The system would not decide cases. It would merely prepare a concise digital brief enabling judges to understand disputes quickly and efficiently.

A judge, handling hundreds of matters every week, should not be required to spend valuable time locating documents buried within voluminous records. Technology can perform that task far more efficiently.

Case listing also requires urgent reform.

Many courts routinely list more matters than can realistically be heard. Consequently, lawyers, litigants and witnesses spend entire days waiting for their cases to be called, only to receive another date.

Artificial Intelligence and data analytics can help create intelligent cause lists by analysing complexity, hearing duration, witness requirements and historical patterns. Cases requiring effective hearing can be allocated dedicated slots, while routine compliance matters can be managed digitally.

The benefits would be substantial. Judges would hear more evidence. More final arguments would take place. More judgments would be delivered. Pendency would begin

reducing naturally.

Technology can also transform evidence management.

Digital evidence repositories can categorise documents, create searchable databases, generate timelines and detect duplicate filings. Lawyers would spend less time handling paperwork and more time focusing on advocacy. Judges would spend less time navigating files and more time evaluating evidence.

Equally important is the need to reduce future litigation.

Technology — assisted mediation platforms, online dispute resolution systems and pre-litigation settlement mechanisms can resolve a substantial category of disputes before they enter the court system. Consumer disputes, family disputes, small commercial claims and motor accident matters often possess significant settlement potential. Every dispute resolved before trial represents one less burden on the judicial system.

Of course, technology is not a magic wand.

Judicial decision-making must always remain human. Artificial intelligence should assist judges, not replace them. Strong safeguards relating to privacy, cybersecurity, transparency and accountability will be essential. Technology must strengthen access to justice rather than create new barriers. But none of these concerns diminish the transformative potential of intelligent judicial automation.

India's judicial debate has long focused on numbers. More judges. More courts. More infrastructure. All are necessary. Yet the next great reform lies elsewhere. The true challenge is to ensure that judges spend their time judging.

A justice system where highly trained judicial officers devote years to managing notices, pleadings and procedural compliance is not using its most valuable resource efficiently.

The constitutional promise is not merely access to courts. It is timely and effective justice. The future of judicial reform therefore lies in creating a smarter justice system. One where technology handles procedure, data manages workflow and judges devote their energies to resolving disputes.

Justice delayed is indeed justice denied, but justice trapped in procedure is justice that never truly begins.

(Vivek Narayan Sharma is an advocate-on-record at the Supreme Court of India, Constitutional expert, accredited Mediator and arbitrator, with over 26 years of experience in constitutional law, litigation, arbitration and public policy)

Jaipur court sends man accused of spying to 5-day police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

A court here sent a man accused of spying for Pakistani intelligence agencies to five-day police custody on Wednesday, officials said.

The accused, Mustaq Ali (26), was produced before the court of Special Judicial Magistrate, Jaipur Metropolitan-1, by the CID (Intelligence), following his arrest on Tuesday, Special Public Prosecutor Sudesh Satwan told reporters.

The court sent Ali to police custody till June 22. The CID (Intelligence) had sought his seven-day remand for interrogation, he said.

Satwan said the agency has been maintaining strict surveillance on espionage activities allegedly being operated from across the border.

He said Ali, a resident of Higoala ki Dhani in Jaisalmer district, had come on the agency's radar due to his activities.

According to police, pre-



liminary investigation revealed that Ali had been in contact with handlers of Pakistani intelligence agencies through social media for the past two years.

During questioning and an examination of his mobile phone, it was found that he was tasked with monitoring the movement of the Border Security Force (BSF) and the Indian Army in the border area.

To carry out the task, the accused had opened a tea stall on a road leading towards the border and used

it as a cover to observe and record movements of the security forces, Satwan said.

He said Ali would click photographs and record videos of BSF and Army activities and send them to his handlers in Pakistan in exchange for monetary benefits. Following his arrest, the accused was jointly interrogated by multiple security and investigation agencies in Jaipur. Further probe is underway to identify his network and other possible links, the officials said.

SC bench to hear plea challenging NEET-UG re-test in July

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

A bench headed by Justice PS Narasimha will hear in July a plea challenging the decision to conduct NEET-UG 2026 re-test, the Supreme Court said on Wednesday.

On May 12, the National Testing Agency (NTA) had cancelled the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak.

The CBI is currently investigating the matter, and a re-test is scheduled for June 21.

On Wednesday, a plea seeking quashing of the decision to re-conduct the NEET-UG 2026 came up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana.

The CJI said the plea would be heard by a bench headed by Justice Narasimha in July when the apex court resumes normal functioning after the partial court working days.

The Justice Narasimha-led bench is already seized of separate petitions related to the NEET-UG.

The fresh plea has sought a direction to the Centre and others to implement secure technology-



driven digital examination and evaluation mechanisms, including encrypted digital question deliv-

Court bins Punjab minister’ bail plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

A special PMLA court here has dismissed the bail application of Punjab Minister Sanjeev Arora, who was arrested by the Enforcement Directorate last month.

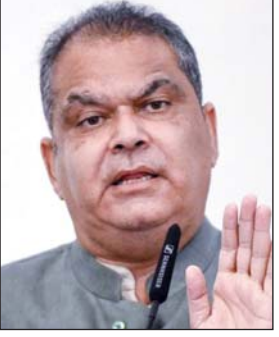
Arora was arrested by the ED in connection with a money laundering case related to an alleged ₹100 crore GST fraud involving certain entities linked to him.

The 62-year-old minister was taken into custody on May 9 following raids conducted by the ED at his official residence at Sector 2, Chandigarh.

In its order dated June 15, the court said it was of the view that the petitioner does not deserve the concession of bail at this stage as he may make efforts to tamper with the evidence.

The ED submitted before the court that bail at this stage will hamper the investigation.

"During arguments, the counsel for ED submitted that the investigation is



still pending and in case of grant of bail at this stage, the petitioner will make his best efforts to tamper with the evidence," the court order said.

Citing an incident during the investigation, the ED counsel said it was revealed that one person whose statement was recorded under Section 50 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) was taken to the office of an advocate to prepare an application to retract his statement. Two people related to the petitioner even transferred the counsel fee of ₹35,000 to him through GPay.

"However, following legal advice taken from another counsel, the said application was not moved before this court," the ED counsel said.

The court said the investigation officer has produced before it screenshots of the receipt of ₹35,000. The court also perused the case diary maintained by the investigation officer.

"After considering the evidence, this court is of the view that the petitioner does not deserve concession of bail at this stage as he may make efforts to tamper with the evidence as he is well acquainted with persons having knowledge of the company's affairs, alleged dealings and transactions. As of today, his family and other known persons are making such efforts, as clear from the facts recorded above," the court observed, dismissing Arora's bail.

Arora held the portfolios of power, industry and commerce.

After his arrest, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann had allocated Arora's portfolios to other ministers.

While hearing a batch of separate pleas related to NEET-UG 2026, the top court on May 29 stressed that the real problem relating to the medical entrance examination would not stop till "actual accountability arises".

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta had then told the apex court that the government was seriously concerned about the concerns of the youths and Prime Minister Narendra Modi was personally supervising the situation so that "there is no lacunae".

Mehta had also said that some new mechanisms have been put in place for the NEET-UG re-test scheduled for June 21.

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GAMSME, Meghalaya Rural Bank sign MoU

The Global Association of MSMEs (GAMSME) and the Meghalaya Rural Bank on Wednesday signed an MoU to help self-help groups, artisans and agricultural processors become bankable enterprises, officials said. The agreement aims to create a structured financial inclusion framework for expanding access to formal credit for unorganised micro-units and family-run businesses across Meghalaya, they said. Under the partnership, MRB's banking network will be integrated with GAMSME's grassroots outreach to facilitate easier access to institutional finance for rural entrepreneurs, reducing reliance on informal and high-interest sources of borrowing. The collaboration will also focus on livelihood formalisation through financial literacy programmes designed to help self-help groups and micro-enterprises maintain separate business finances, build verifiable credit histories and transition into registered micro and small enterprises, the officials said. As part of the initiative, GAMSME will deploy its digital measurement, reporting and verification field toolkit to assess the financial preparedness and compliance readiness of entrepreneurs before they approach the bank for loans. Speaking on the occasion, GAMSME Founder and Chairman Abhijit Sharma said the partnership seeks to unlock the potential of rural entrepreneurs, who often remain outside the formal financial system despite having viable businesses. "In rural India, ambition has never been in short supply. Access has. A weaver, a beekeeper, a small food processor are businesses waiting to happen, held back only by a system that could never quite see them," he said.

Vedanta power eyes hydro, battery storage, nuclear growth

Newly listed Vedanta Power on Wednesday said it is evaluating a foray into hydro, battery storage, and nuclear energy as part of a long-term diversification plan. The company said it recognises nuclear energy as a clean, reliable round-the-clock power source and a key enabler of the country's energy transition. Vedanta Power Ltd has listed its shares on the BSE and the National Stock Exchange (NSE). The listing ceremony on June 15 was led by Vedanta Group Chairman Anil Agarwal. The listing marks an important inflection point for Vedanta Power as a focused, independent business built on a strong operational foundation and positioned to support India's rapidly growing energy demand, the company said in a statement. The other newly demerged businesses -- aluminium, oil and gas, and iron and steel -- also commenced trading on the exchanges alongside Vedanta Power. Speaking on the day of the listing, Agarwal said, "24 years ago, Vedanta became the first Indian company to list on the London Stock Exchange and went on to become a FTSE100 company. The seed we sowed that day has grown into a vast banyan tree, and the saplings nurtured under it are now ready to become giants in key sectors and contribute significantly to India's rapid growth." Backed by a clear growth roadmap, Vedanta Power is focused on enhancing operational excellence, expanding capacity and building a long-term power platform for India. The company plans to scale its capacity to 20 GW, with the long-term ambition to be among the top-three private-sector power companies in the country. As part of this journey, Vedanta Power expects to commission the second 600 MW unit at its Sakti plant in the second half of FY27 and increase total capacity to 12 GW by FY33. A significant portion of this expansion is expected to be driven through brownfield projects, leveraging existing infrastructure and operational advantages, the company added.

Sensex, Nifty rise for 4th day on US-Iran peace deal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended higher on Wednesday, taking their winning run to the fourth straight session, buoyed by softening crude oil prices following a peace deal between the US and Iran.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 347.14 points, or 0.45 per cent, to settle at 77,155.62. During the day, it jumped 410.51 points, or 0.53 per cent, to 77,218.99.

The 50-share NSE Nifty rallied 96.55 points, or 0.40 per cent, to end at 24,085.70. Intraday, the benchmark advanced 119.05 points, or

NSE NIFTY

Intra-day on June 17, 2026

96.55
(0.44%)

Close: 24,085.70

Open: 24,044.50

High: 24,108.20

Low: 23,969.70

Previous close: 23,989.15

BSE SENSEX

Intra-day on June 17, 2026

347.14
(0.45%)

Close: 77,155.62

Open: 77,080.09

High: 77,218.99

Low: 76,768.49

Previous close: 76,808.48

0.49 per cent, to 24,108.20.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Trent jumped the most, by 7.06 per cent. Bharat

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NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | JUNE 18, 2026

RBI infuses ₹72,300 cr liquidity via VRR as surplus narrows

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday infused ₹72,300 crore transient liquidity through two Variable Rate Repo (VRR) auction into the banking system after surplus liquidity narrowed following advance tax payments.

The central bank injected Rs 50,016 crore through a two-day VRR auction at a cut-off rate of 5.26 per cent. It also infused another ₹22,284 crore via a second two-day VRR auction. Variable rate repo auctions are used by the RBI to manage liquidity mismatches in the banking system. Currently, liquidity in the banking system is estimated

to be in surplus of around ₹23,881.21 crore as on June 16, which was lower compared to a surplus of around ₹1.51 lakh crore as on June 15, according to the RBI's data.

Experts attributed the narrowing of liquidity to outflows on account of advance tax payments. Further, they

added that the central bank may conduct more VRR auctions in the coming days to support liquidity in the banking system.

"Considering the narrowing of surplus liquidity in the banking system and expectation of further outflows on account of goods and services

tax payment, the central bank may conduct more variable rate repo auctions to support liquidity and keep overnight rates under check," said V Ramachandra Reddy, head of treasury at The Karur Vysya Bank.

In the last few days, overnight rates have been trading above the RBI's repo rate due to strain on the liquidity surplus, prompting the central bank's intervention to infuse transient liquidity in the banking system. On Wednesday, weighted average call money rates were trading at 5.37 per cent, which was 0.12 per cent higher than the repo rate, and Treps was trading at 5.21 per cent.

Silver futures fall to ₹2.48 lakh/kg ahead of US Fed meet

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Silver futures declined for the second straight day on Wednesday, falling by ₹1,705 to ₹2.48 lakh per kg, tracking weak global trends as investors await the outcome of the US Federal Reserve's policy meeting.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the white metal for July delivery depreciated by ₹1,705, or nearly 1 per cent, to ₹2,48,400 per kilogram in a business turnover of 11,162 lots. Analysts said investors are largely stayed on the sidelines amid uncertainty over the Federal Reserve's policy outlook, limiting fresh buying in the white metal. In the international markets, Comex

silver futures slipped below the key \$70 per ounce mark and were trading marginally lower at \$69.87 per ounce in New York. Silver prices fell on Wednesday driven by a combination of geopolitical tensions and technical buying as investors look beyond safe-haven assets amid fluctuating oil prices, Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

Market participants are closely tracking the outcome of the Federal Reserve's meeting, where interest rates are widely expected to remain unchanged. "The US central bank is widely expected to keep rates unchanged, but its updated economic projections and policy guidance will be closely watched

for clues on the future rate path," Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst at Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

According to financial services company ING Think, the meeting will also mark a key test for bullion markets as investors assess comments from new Federal Reserve

Chair Kevin Warsh regarding the future direction of monetary policy.

Analysts noted that traders will also parse the Fed's updated economic forecasts and remarks on inflation and growth, which could influence the bullion prices, US Treasury bond yields and the dollar in the near-term.

India emerges as one of Asia Pacific region's most AI-ready healthcare markets: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has emerged as one of Asia Pacific region's most AI-ready healthcare markets, with 78 per cent of consumers using GenAI to better understand diagnoses and treatment options, according to a report by Bain & Company.

Healthcare systems in Asia-Pacific are facing growing strain as rising patient expectations collide with a stretched clinical workforce, accelerating the shift toward new care models and AI-enabled support, said the report titled '2026 Asia-Pacific Front Line of Healthcare Report'. Consumers across Asia-Pacific

are increasingly taking a proactive role in managing their health while expecting more convenience, responsiveness and coordination from the healthcare system, it said. As per the report, 84 per cent of consumers expect greater convenience from the

healthcare system, while 71 per cent expect doctors to be more responsive through channels such as phone, WhatsApp or email.

Three out of five consumers now also schedule regular checkups and screenings, compared to 47 per cent in 2023.

RBI temporarily lifts FCNR (B) deposit interest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Wednesday temporarily withdrew interest rate ceiling on fresh Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits of 3-5 years' maturity till September 30, a move aimed at attracting foreign capital.

It has also temporarily withdrawn restriction on interest rates on Non-Resident External (NRE) deposits of 3 years and above tenors, including deposits that are renewed upon maturity, till September 30, 2026.

"The interest rate ceiling applicable to fresh FCNR(B) deposits mobilised by banks, including the deposits that

are renewed upon maturity, for three years and above -- up to and including five years tenors, is temporarily withdrawn with effect from June 17, 2026, for the period until September 30, 2026," the central bank said in a circular. The relaxation came into

effect from Wednesday. An FCNR (B) deposit is a term deposit account meant for Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) to park overseas earnings in foreign currencies in India.

The notification also said interest rates on NRE/NRO deposits should not be higher

than those offered by the bank on comparable domestic rupee term deposits.

Earlier this month, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had announced a host of measures to attract foreign capital in the backdrop of rupee depreciating against the US dollar.

One of the measures was a facility of concessional forex swap for bearing the full hedging cost shall be provided till September 30, 2026 to AD banks for raising fresh 3-5-year FCNR(B) deposits. Separate notifications in this regard have also been issued for commercial banks, co-operative banks, regional rural banks, and small finance banks.

BUSINESS 11

India's oil reserves stand at just 9-10 days: CEEW report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's current strategic petroleum reserves are equivalent to just about 9-10 days of the country's net crude imports, far below other major import-dependent countries, a new report revealed on Wednesday.

The report released by Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) said other countries that rely heavily on crude imports -- such as Japan and South Korea -- maintain reserves sufficient for over 200 days. The report, 'How Secure is India's Energy Future?'

Assessing Accessibility, Reliability, and Affordability, also noted that over 85 per cent of India's crude oil imports come from just six countries, including Russia and key West Asian suppliers, limiting flexibility supply shocks. Hemant Mallaya, fellow at the CEEW, said, "Disruptions in crude oil, LNG, LPG, coal, or key shipping routes can quickly affect cooking costs, transport fuel prices, fertiliser subsidies, industrial competitiveness, and inflation."

For gas, India imports nearly half its supply as LNG but has no dedicated strategic gas storage facilities, leaving fertiliser plants and city gas networks exposed, the report said. It also highlighted that the country's coal security risks are increasingly influenced by its continued dependence on imported coking coal -- particularly from Australia -- for steelmaking, and exposure to Indonesian export policies for non-coking coal imports.

On the domestic side, declining coal quality and rising production costs signal a narrowing cost advantage for coal power over firm renewable power, said the report. It argued that clean energy can reduce India's exposure to continuously imported fossil fuels.

However, the report said that clean energy can create a different kind of strategic dependence: on critical minerals, technologies, and industrial inputs. This dependence must be managed through domestic manufacturing, supply-chain diversification, recycling, and strategic international partnerships, according to the report.

Navi Mumbai Airport to launch international operations on July 15

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Adani Group-owned Navi Mumbai airport is expected to start international operations from the greenfield facility from July 15, a top official said on Wednesday.

Along with international passenger flights, the Navi Mumbai airport will also commence international freighter operations, he said. The Adani Group-owned airport, the second airport in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, had commenced domestic flight services from December last year.

"On July 15, we are starting with freighters, and we expect the freighters to ramp

up to almost 18 weekly flights. Good news is also that there is movement on the passenger side and hopefully on July 15 international passenger flights will also start," Navi Mumbai International Airport Ltd (NMIAL) chief executive officer, BVJK Sharma, told reporters on the sidelines of BCBA Logistics Conclave

here. Sharma further noted that both "Air India Express and IndiGo are going to operate international flights from Navi Mumbai."

Member (Customs), a senior official within the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC), reviewed the readiness of the airport (for international operations) on Tuesday, and relevant notifications have been promulgated, he said. "The last one is being done today, which will then follow with Section 45 and the trials with both the codes for courier and the cargo," he said, adding that this will lead to probably a trade notice by the customs around July 5.

GIC re-appointed Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi as CMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

General Insurance Corporation of India (GIC Re) announced the appointment of Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi as its Chairman-cum-Managing Director (CMD).

He officially took over charges on June 16, according to a statement by the reinsurer. Before his full appointment, Joshi served as an Executive Director of the state-owned reinsurer and held the interim charge of CMD, effective October 1, 2025. "The Ministry of Finance, in

its letter dated June 15, 2026, approved the appointment of Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi, Executive Director (ED), GIC Re, as Chairman-cum-Managing Director (CMD), w.e.f. the date of his assumption of charge of the post till the date of his superannuation (i.e. Sept 30, 2028), or until further orders, whichever is earlier," the general insurance company said in a regulatory filing.

The post fell vacant following the completion of Narayanan Ramaswamy's two-year tenure as CMD.

Airtel provides mobile connectivity in remote Army locations in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Leading telecom operator Bharti Airtel on Wednesday said it has set up infrastructure across 30 Indian Army stations in difficult terrain in Arunachal Pradesh to make available uninterrupted connectivity.

The Indian Army had joined hands with Airtel for last-mile connectivity in border and difficult-to-reach locations of the Himalayan state, the company said in a statement. "As part of the initiative, Airtel deployed network infrastructure

across 30 Army stations located in challenging mountainous terrain," it added.

The deployment significantly enhanced voice and data connectivity in areas where access has historically remained limited due to geographical and infrastructure constraints, Airtel said.

"This achievement was made possible through strong collaboration between Airtel and the Indian Army.

Army extended extensive logistical support throughout the project, including assistance for fiber deployment and power infrastructure," it added. The company further said that in several locations where road access was not possible, the Indian Army provided the necessary assistance and logistics support to move Airtel technical teams and telecommunication equipment deep into the mountains.

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Police hunt for hospital shooter

An assailant who shot two people inside a Delaware hospital Tuesday – killing one – remained at large hours later, police said. The shooting was reported about 3:30 pm at Wilmington Hospital, Wilmington Police Chief Wilfredo Campos told a news conference Tuesday night. He declined to release information about the identities of the victims or the condition of the person who was shot and survived “out of respect for the families,” he said. Investigators were working to identify and find the shooter and trying to determine how the person left the building, Campos said. ChristianaCare, which operates the hospital, said in an emailed statement it had diverted patients from its emergency department and was “taking all appropriate steps to ensure the safety of our patients, caregivers and visitors.”

UN

Guterres visits Haiti

UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres visited Haiti , where surging gang violence has left more than 1 in 10 people homeless. New statistics released by the UN reveal that 2,300 people have been killed across Haiti so far this year, with another 100 kidnapped, while 1.5 million have been displaced. Among those abducted is James Boyard, cabinet director of the Defence Ministry, who was kidnapped last week in one of the few relatively safe areas of the Capital. Guterres' one-day visit to Port-au-Prince comes after more than 30 people were killed in Cite Soleil.

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US has restored the name of the US Indo-Pacific Command to the US Pacific Command, reversing an eight-year-old decision. The US Department of Defence announced the decision on Tuesday, saying that the designation honours the Command's deep historical roots, established in 1947 by then-President Harry Truman. Also, the “area of responsibility” map on the Pacific Command website, which depicts an inaccurate picture of India's borders, has triggered political reactions in the country. The map in question excludes Pakistan-occupied



Kashmir and Aksai Chin from India. The website section where the inaccurate map is placed contains a disclosure that the concerned web page was last updated in March. New Delhi maintains that the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of India by virtue of the “complete, legal and irrevocable accession” of

Jammu and Kashmir to India in 1947. Opposition party Congress has criticised the BJP-led government over the map issue. Congress' media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra said: “Modi Ji's friends have an uncanny habit of acting against India, India's interests, and India's friends. The latest example? The US Pacific Command used an

incorrect map of India, excluding Jammu & Kashmir and depicting PoK as Pakistani territory.” “One is compelled to ask: Why would any country need adversaries when its PM has thrown the country into such exploitative friendships?” Kherra said. The Pacific Command operated under the USPACOM banner for over 70 years, standing as the oldest and largest of the United States' unified combatant commands, the Department of Defence said in a statement. It was renamed as the US Indo-Pacific Command in 2018 during US President Donald Trump's first term in office. “The US Pacific Command ... is back,” Defence Secretary

Pete Hegseth said in a post on X. The US Pacific Command extends from the US West Coast to India's western border. Restoring the legacy USPACOM designation honours the Command's deep historical roots, fostering a sense of pride and collective spirit among all who serve in the Pacific, the Department of Defence said. From its critical role in establishing the post-World War II regional security architecture to its coordination of joint forces during the Korean War, the Vietnam War, and countless humanitarian operations, the USPACOM namesake carries decades of military heritage and enduring regional partnerships, it said. (PTI)

G7 pledge more vital help for Ukraine: Zelenskyy

HANNA ARHIROVA
■ Kyiv



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Wednesday his country has won key pledges of further support from world leaders in defending itself from Russia's full-scale invasion, now in its fifth year. Leaders attending the Group of Seven summit in France promised to strengthen Ukraine's air defences and ensure its energy supply, as well as step up international economic pressure on Moscow. “The G7 Summit in France delivered important results for Ukraine. Most importantly, we agreed on

additional strengthening of Ukraine's air defence,” Zelenskyy, who attended the gathering, said on X. “Our partners will ensure support for our defence and energy resilience,” he said, adding they will also introduce new sanctions on Russia. (AP)

Pak facilitating repatriation of 30 Iranians: Ishaq Dar

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan is facilitating the repatriation of 30 Iranian nationals, including fishermen, through the southern port city of Karachi, Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said on Wednesday. “Pakistan is pleased to facilitate the repatriation of 30 Iranian nationals,” Dar said in a post on social media X. He said that those being repatriated include 8 Iranian fishermen rescued at sea by the British vessel MMA Valour after their boat ran aground, and 22 Iranian crew members from the vessel Lenore/Davina,



recently interdicted by the US authorities. “Both groups are expected to transit through Karachi in the coming days,” said Dar. He added that Pakistan was in close coordination with the Iranian, the US and the UK authorities to ensure the safe transit and early return of “our Iranian brethren to their homeland”. (PTI)

G7 leader's backs Trump Iran war plan amid skepticism

DARLENE SUPERVILLE/ AAMER MADHANI/ SYLVIE CORRET
■ Evian-les-Bains (France)

Leaders at the Group of Seven summit on Wednesday threw their support behind US President Donald Trump's tentative agreement with Iran to open the Strait of Hormuz and further extend a shaky ceasefire – even though he's offered scant specificity about how that would be implemented. In a declaration issued overnight, the leaders called the deal a “historic opportunity to prevent Iran from acquiring any nuclear weapon and tackling the threats related to its regional and ballistic activities.” The leaders said that they

were “ready to contribute to its implementation,” although neither the White House nor Iran has released the text of the agreement. According to leaked copies of an interim agreement, Iran will immediately take steps to reopen the Strait of Hormuz once the deal is signed and will be allowed to sell its oil without restrictions. Officials say the leaked text broadly matches the document. The accord, due to be formally signed in a ceremony in Switzerland on Friday, lays out that the US would work to end all American and United Nations sanctions imposed on Tehran if a final agreement addressing Iran's nuclear program is reached. Trump, however, said the



PM Modi, Donald Trump and other leaders posing during a group photo of leaders at the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains, France

deal is still under wraps. He was speaking at a one-to-one meeting with Egyptian President Abdel-Fattah el-Sissi. “Nobody knows what it is but it's very strong,” he told

reporters. He added: “It's a memorandum of understanding and if I don't like it, we'll go back to shooting at them, dropping bombs.” The final day of summit talks

started late with Trump, the last to arrive, saying “I'm the boss” as he entered the room and sat next to host French President Emmanuel Macron. The assembled leaders laughed, and Trump grinned. The G7 leaders were closing the formal talks of the leading industrial democracies at a lakeside resort in the French Alps on Wednesday with sessions on the future of artificial intelligence and fostering economic growth. They discussed concerns that China is flooding export markets with subsidised products, unfairly out-competing their own industries and destroying jobs. Leaders of India, South Korea, Kenya and Brazil also joined the meeting. (AP)

Carney skips bilateral with Trump at G7

ROB GILLIES ■ Evian-les-Bains

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney will leave the G7 summit on Wednesday without a formal meeting with US President Donald Trump as the free trade agreement between their countries faces an uncertain future. Canadian leaders typically get a bilateral meeting with American presidents at summits of the world's



US President Donald Trump, French President Emmanuel Macron and Canadian PM Mark Carney at the G7 Summit, in Evian-les-Bains, France

leading industrialised democracies, but Carney dismissed any notion of a snub.

“I wouldn't take a big message from that,” Carney said. “I had seven or eight dis-

cussions with President Trump over the course of last 36 hours. I'll have more today, a wide range of subjects from the economy, relations, his birthday, artificial intelligence, Ukraine, obviously Iran.” It is a crucial moment in trade talks for the latest iteration of the North American free-trade pact that has intertwined the economies of Canada, the United State and Mexico since the early 1990s. (AP)

CROSS COUNTRY HOTELS LIMITED

Regd. Off.: Cross Country Heritage Hotel, Mukand Garh Fort, Mukundgarh, Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, India-333 705. CIN: L55101RJ1990PLC013744 Email id: sales@crosscountry.co.in Website: www.crosscountry.co.in

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that 32nd Annual General Meeting of Members of the company for Financial Year 2021-22 has been fixed for Monday, the 13th day of July, 2026 at 10.00 A.M. to 11.00 A.M. at Shri Ashtavinayak Dham, Dundlod road Railway Station Mukandgarh Dist. Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan to transact the business detailed in the Notice of the Meeting, which was dispatched to the members individually.

Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made there under and Clause 16 of the Listing Agreement with Stock Exchange, Notice is also given that the Register of Members and Share Transfer Register shall remain closed from Monday, 6th July, 2026 to Monday 13th July, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of the Annual General Meeting.

Place: New Delhi Date: 18.06.2026

By the order of the Board For Cross Country Hotels Limited

(Ishan Rai Juneja) (Director) DIN: 064103133

CROSS COUNTRY HOTELS LIMITED

Regd. Off.: Cross Country Heritage Hotel, Mukand Garh Fort, Mukundgarh, Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, India-333 705. CIN: L55101RJ1990PLC013744 Email id: sales@crosscountry.co.in Website: www.crosscountry.co.in

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that 34th Annual General Meeting of Members of the company for Financial Year 2023-24 has been fixed for Monday, the 13th day of July, 2026 at 12.00 P.M. to 1.00 P.M. at Shri Ashtavinayak Dham, Dundlod road Railway Station Mukandgarh Dist. Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan to transact the business detailed in the Notice of the Meeting, which was dispatched to the members individually.

Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made there under and Clause 16 of the Listing Agreement with Stock Exchange, Notice is also given that the Register of Members and Share Transfer Register shall remain closed from Monday, 6th July, 2026 to Monday 13th July, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of the Annual General Meeting.

Place: New Delhi Date: 18.06.2026

By the order of the Board For Cross Country Hotels Limited

(Ishan Rai Juneja) (Director) DIN: 064103133

AXIS BANK

Retail Assets Centre, Axis Bank Ltd. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301, Axis Bank Ltd. Retail Asset Centre at 1st Floor, Vipul Square, Shushant Lok -1, Gurgaon-122009, Axis Bank Limited, Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor and first floor, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001, Corporate Office: Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhakar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samarathwar Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

DEMAND NOTICE

Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFESI Act, 2002 calling upon the following borrowers /guarantors /mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have returned un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.

Name of the Borrower / Address / Co-borrower and Guarantor Name: 1. Late Mr. Rakesh Kwatra Thakur Its Legal Heirs 1. Mr. Ravi Kumar S/o. Mr. Kishan Lal Kwatra R/o. Tu-71, Vishakha Enclave Pitampura, Shalimar Bagh Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi- 110088 (Co-applicant) Also At: Mr. Ravi Kumar /Mis K Rakesh Kumar & Co. First Floor, B-827, Azadpur, New Sadjhi Mandi, Delhi-110033 (Co-applicant) 2. Mrs. Meenakshi Kwatra W/o Mr. Late Mr. Rakesh Kwatra W/o Mr. Rakesh Kwatra R/o. Tu-71, Vishakha Enclave Pitampura, Shalimar Bagh Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi- 110088 (Co-applicant & Legal Heir) 3. Ms. Avishi Kwatra D/o Mr. Late Mr. Rakesh Kwatra R/o Tu-71, Vishakha Enclave Pitampura, Shalimar Bagh Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi-110088 (Legal Heir) Property Assets: Entire Upper Ground Floor, Without Roof Terrace Rights of Property Bearing No. 71 Block-TU, situated in the lay out plan of Pitampura Residential Scheme, Presently Known As Vishaka Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi and bounded as under: North-As per Title Deed East-As per Title Deed, West- As per Title Deed, South - As per Title Deed

NPA Date of Demand Notice: Amount (Rs.) Loan Outstanding Amt (Rs.) as on date of Notice: 01.05.2026 30.05.2026 Rs. 2,99,00,000/- Rs. 2,95,20,086/- (Rupees Two Crore Ninety Five Lakh Twenty Thousand Eighty Six Only)

In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (where ever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets of the borrowers and the mortgagors under Section 13(4) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and the applicable rules thereunder. Kind attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFESI Act under which you can tender the entire amount of outstanding dues together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank only till the date of publication of the notice for sale of the secured asset(s) by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty. Please also note that if the entire amount of outstanding dues together with the costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank is not tendered before publication of notice for sale of the secured assets by public auction, by inviting quotations, tender from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s) Please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no Borrower shall, transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.

Place: Noida U.P., Date: 17.06.2026 -SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

NOIDA

NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida G.B. Nagar,(U.P) Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from firms/contractors registered with for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

Sr. No.	Job No. / Work Name	Amount (Rs. in Lacs)
1.	02/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, Re Grassing of L Shape Park Sector-44 and RSP Around Japani Park Sector-94, Sector-127, 128 Central Verge Near Samshan Ghat Pusta Sector-94, Noida	53.84
2.	03/D(H)/DD(H)-III/2026-27, M/o Park (Annual Maintenance of Shaheed Bhagat Singh Park in Sector-150), Noida. (Civil Work)	94.97

Which can be uploaded by dated **24.06.2026** up to **5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/ downloaded on date **25.06.2026** at **11.00 AM**.

Sr. No.	Job No. / Work Name	Amount (Rs. in Lacs)
1.	22/D(H)/DD(H)-I/2025-26, M/o RSP (Plantation work) FNG Road Parthala Gol Chhkar to village chjarshi with One year Maintenance Noida	85.70
2.	03/D(H)/DD(H)-I/2026-27, RE-Grassing Development Parks at in sector- 12, Noida.	95.38
3.	04/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, Re Grassing of Park Sector-52 B Block Park (In Front of B-132) and C-Block park (In Front of C-80) and Aravli Appartment shatabhi vihar L-Shape park Near State Bank Sector-53 & Near A-Block Community Center, Noida	90.23
4.	05/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, Re Grassing of Park Opp. Mother Dairy and Green Belt Sector-99, Noida	45.78
5.	06/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, M/o Green Belt (S/F of M.S. Grill, R/o boundary wall, Gate and Painting of Gate & Grill near Amity School green belt sector-44) Noida.	41.25
6.	07/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, M/o Green belt (Re- Construction of Boundary wall in C- Block, Sector-47) Noida.	49.14
7.	09/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, D/o Green Belt (C/o Footpath in Green Belt Sector-116 & 117) Noida.	77.92
8.	10/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, D/o Green Belt (Supply and fixing of MS railing at gol chhakkar near Tajmahal replica, in front of police chauki and triangle park near sector-44 at Mahamaya Flyover) Noida.	46.39
9.	13/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, M/o Park, Green Belt & RSP Sector-77, 116 for Two Year Maintenance	98.20
10.	15/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, M/o Park, Green Belt Sector-33 for Two Year Maintenance	73.40
11.	16/D(H)/DD(H)-II/2026-27, M/o Park, Green Belt Sector-35 & Morna Shiv mandir & School for Two Year Maintenance	69.66
12.	01/D(H)/DD(H)-III/2026-27, M/o Green Belt (Barbed Wire Fencing in Green Belt sector-151) Noida.	60.25
13.	06/D(H)/DD(H)-III/2026-27, M/o Park, Green belt & RSP Sector - 93,110, 137,141 and Health Center, Primary School Village Garhi Shahdra, Elahabad Shamshan Ghat with 02 year maintenance.	66.57

Which can be uploaded by dated **01.07.2026** up to **5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/ downloaded on date **02.07.2026** at **11.00 AM**.

Office Sector-39 Director (H) Noida

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

The accord, due to be signed in Switzerland on Friday, also envisions Iran receiving at least \$300 billion to rebuild after the war and says the US would work to end all American and United Nations sanctions imposed on Tehran – if a final agreement addressing Iran's nuclear program is reached. The US and Israel went to war in part to prevent Iran from ever getting a nuclear weapon – although US President Donald Trump's goals in the conflict have repeatedly shifted. The interim deal stops the

war before that aim is secured – instead opening a two-month period for nuclear negotiations – and appears to offer Iran several benefits up front while extracting little in return. The US agreement to immediately allow Iran to sell its oil freely and the offer to eventually lift all sanctions, for instance, represent major concessions that outstrip the terms of Iran's 2015 nuclear deal with world powers that Trump withdrew America from in his first term, declaring it the “worst deal ever.” The accord likely will draw

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Sarita to inform the public at large that Mrs. Sarita is purchasing the Front Side Upper Ground Floor without roof rights, on Property No. 54, land area measuring 60 sq. yds., out of Kharsa No. 18/6, Nihal Vihar Phase 2, Block B, Niothi Extn New Delhi 110041 from Mrs. Luxmi Kaur who became the owner through GPA, ATS & WILL dated 04.07.2025 executed by S. Surjeet Singh & S. Santokh Singh. The said property will be financed and mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd., Noida. Therefore, to comply with the requirements of the BANK/NBFC, this public notice is issued. If anyone has any type of claim, right, title, interest, or has created any mortgage over the said property, they are requested to inform in writing, along with their objections, at the address mentioned below within 15 days from today. Failing which, it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of encumbrances, liens, etc. Lucem Legal LLP B-308, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2 Noida, UP-201301 Contact: +91120-42689719

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Sachin Kumar Dubey is the Owner of Second floor with roof rights Property Bearing No. 17-A, area measuring 50*50 = 2500 Sq. Yds, i.e., 8.83 Sq. Mtrs., out of Kharsa No. 25/43, Situated in the area of Village Khureji Khas, abadi of Gali No. 6, Krishan Kunj Extension, Laxmi Nagar, Haryana through Sale deed dated 07.05.2026 as doc no 2026/51/3987 executed by Mr. Sajdev Kumar and Smt. Sumi Nagar, Haryana. Mr. Irfan Khan intends to transfer the ownership of Third floor with roof rights area measuring 50 sq. yds. of above said floor by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Junaid Qureshi and Mrs. Areeba. Subsequently Mr. Junaid Qureshi and Mrs. Areeba are the process of mortgaging the said floor with SMEG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in.

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Sachin Kumar Dubey is the Owner of Plot No-47 and area 220 Sq Yds. at Khewat No-241, Khatori No-257, Kharsa No-38, Killa No-48/9, Muski No-45 Kila 2523519-12, Kila No-2 Rakha 8 Kanil 2 Kila 7516 Share, & 233 Marie and Khewat No-121, Khatori No-130, Muski No-38, Kila No-57/13, 8/11-11, Kila No-2, Rakha 9 Kanil 4 Marie Share 7552 Share, & 233 Marie and Khewat No-232 Khatori No-248, Muski No-27, Kila No-242/4-11 Rakha 7 Marie Or 11 Marie Share of 139 Share Portion Situated at Waka Mouza Karmen Sub Tehsil Goudi Dist. Faridabad Haryana through Transfer Deed Dated 27.03.2024 as doc no. -2939 Executed by Mrs. Sandhya Dubey in favour of Mr. Sachin Kumar Dubey. The owner has misplanned the (1) Original Sale Deed dated 29.02.2016 as doc. no. 13331 executed by Mrs Balaji Ashiyans Pvt. Ltd in favour of Mrs. Sandhya Dubey in Respect of Plot No-47 area 220 Sq Yds. for which complaint is regd. vide Application No.-13225003250008, registered at Ballabgarh Faridabad, Haryana C/rme Registered at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in. Mr. Sachin Kumar Dubey are in the process of mortgaging the said property with Aavas Financiers Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Deepansh Gupta has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Sector-16, Faridabad, Haryana (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Apartment No. 0601, 6th Floor, (1304 Sq. Ft.), Tower No. C4, SRS Residency, Sector-88, Faridabad, Haryana from Mrs. Deepa Roy Chowdhury, who has represented that she is the sole & absolute owner of the said property, 1/2 share by virtue of Conveyance Deed dated 21.08.2013 (Doc-5826) and ½ share having inherited from the other co-owner, her late husband Mr. Raja Roy Chowdhary being his only class-I legal heir. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property, he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 10 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Ami Kumar, Advocate Narang & Associates D-28, Jangpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.



Relations between the two neighbours in recent years have become more pragmatic in the wake of Russia's full-scale war on Ukraine in 2022 and the coming to power of a liberal government in Poland in 2023. As the US weighs a partial drawdown of its military presence in Europe, Poland is keen to ensure that major European allies take a greater role. (AP)

Germany, Poland to sign defence deal

CLAUDIA CIOBANU
■ Warsaw

Germany and Poland are set to sign a new defence agreement on Wednesday, putting aside their complicated past to strengthen European military cooperation amid heightened tensions with Russia and growing uncertainty over US engagement in Europe.

Putin hosts leaders of Southeast Asia at Russia-ASEAN summit

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russia's President Vladimir Putin is hosting leaders of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations at a summit that opens on Wednesday, seeking to bolster business and other ties with members of the regional bloc.

The two-day Russia-ASEAN summit, which is held in Kazan, is set to consider ways to expand Russia's "strategic partnership" with ASEAN that includes Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, East Timor and Vietnam. The regional bloc has maintained relations



with Moscow as a "dialogue partner" and engaged Russian officials in annual top-level meetings.

The summit in Kazan marks the 35th anniversary of Russia-ASEAN relations.

In a message greeting participants in a business forum held on the sidelines of the summit, Putin said he was

confident that it will "create new opportunities for expanding mutually beneficial trade, investment, and industrial cooperation, while also strengthening direct dialogue between our business communities."

Kremlin foreign affairs adviser Yuri Ushakov said the summit's agenda includes

exchanging views on global and regional issues and reviewing efforts to develop Russia-ASEAN ties. He emphasised that the participants are set to underline their adherence to "forming a just and democratic multipolar world order based on the principles of international law and the United Nations Charter."

Ushakov told reporters that Putin was set to have bilateral meetings with ASEAN leaders during the summit. Some of ASEAN's diverse member countries are seen to be aligned with the United States, including the Philippines, which currently holds the association's yearly rotating presidency.

Migrants clash with police in South Africa

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Johannesburg

Police fired rubber bullets and used stun grenades against migrants protesting Wednesday near a community hall in South Africa where thousands are being processed for deportation by authorities.

The clashes came as tensions over immigration surge in Africa's richest country following a series of anti-migrant marches and reports of attacks on some foreign nationals.

The migrants who gathered near the hall in the eastern city of Durban are mainly Malawians who initially turned up there more than a week ago to be vol-



untarily repatriated to their home country on buses provided by their government, authorities said.

The premier of KwaZulu-Natal Province, where Durban is, has said nearly 10,000 Malawians have been camping in a park near the hall waiting to go home.

Former Spain PM Zapatero questioned in corruption probe



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Spain's former Prime Minister Jose Luis Rodriguez Zapatero is appearing before a judge in Madrid on Wednesday in connection to his alleged role in a Government airline bailout and links to jewelry discovered in a police raid on his office. It is Zapatero's first appearance before the National Court judge since he was placed under investigation last month for alleged influence peddling, money laundering and other possible financial wrongdoing in connection with the Spanish Government's rescue of the Plus Ultra airline.

Zapatero, 65, who was prime minister from 2004 to 2011, had been out of public office for a decade when Plus Ultra received 53 million

euros (\$61.5 million) in public money in 2021 from a COVID-19 recovery fund.

Judge Jose Luis Calama is also examining a possible case of tax fraud and dealing in contraband related to jewelry worth 1.3 million-euros discovered in a safe by police during a search of Zapatero's office in May. Zapatero has denied any wrongdoing in the airline case and has said that the jewelry was inherited or received as gifts. Zapatero remains an important figure for the Socialist party headed by current Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez, whose party has been rocked by corruption scandals over the past two years. Plus Ultra, which had investors from Venezuela, was an airline specializing in flights between Spain and South America.

UK PM calls actions of Russian warship in English Channel reckless

DANICA KIRKA/ JILL LAWLESS
■ London

UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Wednesday accused the crew of a Russian warship of acting recklessly when they fired warning shots near a British yacht in the English Channel, though he downplayed the seriousness of the incident.

The owners of the 40-foot (12-metre) sailboat Bright Future say the shots were fired early Tuesday morning when they encountered a Russian warship while crossing the English Channel to Cherbourg in France. Russia says the crew of the frigate Admiral Grigorovich fired



shots into the air after the sailboat failed to respond to warnings to change course.

No one was injured, but the incident underscored heightened tensions between the UK and Russia.

Speaking at the G7 summit in France, Starmer said the incident was "deeply concerning," even though British defence officials have concluded the shots weren't "anything more sinister" than an effort to avoid a collision. "That doesn't take away from the fact that clearly Russia is aggressive across Europe," Starmer said.

The incident occurred two days after Britain seized a tanker from Russia's so-

called shadow fleet, which Western powers say is used to skirt sanctions on Russian oil exports imposed after the invasion of Ukraine. Britain has also accused Russia of mounting a campaign of sabotage to destabilise European nations that support Ukraine.

The British couple aboard the Bright Future, Jane Kelvey, 68, and her husband Alan, 70, reported that the shots were fired about 20 nautical miles south of the Isle of Wight, outside UK territorial waters.

"It was a bit scary," Jane Kelvey told the i Paper. "I crouched down. I didn't think our safety was in

danger. But it was certainly unusual. As we sailed away, we said to each other, what the hell just happened?"

Russia's Defence Ministry said the crew of the frigate tried to contact the yacht when it was seen sailing on a "dangerous course in close proximity to the warship." It said the ship's crew launched flares and issued sound signals when the yacht did not respond.

"After the distance had closed to 150 metres, the frigate's commander decided to fire warning shots across the vessel's bow using small arms," the ministry said. It said the yacht then changed course and sailed away. (AP)

Phishing most damaging form of cybercrime, says INTERPOL

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Cyber-scams such as phishing have emerged as the most widespread and financially damaging, with 33 per cent of countries reporting over 10,000 cases, according to an INTERPOL report released on Wednesday.

Releasing its Asia and South Pacific Cyberthreat Assessment Report on Wednesday, INTERPOL revealed a dramatic increase in cybercrime across the region driven by rapid digitalisation, new technologies and increasingly organised criminal networks. The report draws on information provided by 18 INTERPOL member countries across the Asia and South Pacific region, as well as contributions from private sector partners, operational case studies and analysis of emerging cyber threats, INTERPOL said. The report, covering the period from January 2024 to March 2025, found that



more than half of the countries surveyed reported cybercrime now accounted for 30 per cent of all crimes recorded nationally.

Neal Jetton, INTERPOL Cybercrime Director, said: "The findings in this report highlight a rapidly evolving cyber threat landscape across Asia and the South Pacific, where cybercriminals are leveraging artificial intelligence, ransomware-as-a-service models and sophisticated social engineering techniques on an industrial scale. (PTI)

Taiwan accuses Kenya of rights abuses, blames Chinese pressure on scholars

EVELYNE MUSAMBI ■ Nairobi

Taiwan accused Kenya on Wednesday of human rights abuses against its nationals attending a global oceans conference in Mombasa and blamed China for exerting pressure on the East African country.

Taiwan's foreign ministry said the scholars' passports and mobile phones were confiscated and they were detained for more than 20 hours before being deported. In a statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Taipei said it "strongly protests and condemns China's pressure on the Kenyan Government to



refuse Taiwanese scholars' attendance at the international ocean academic exchange conference, as well as the barbaric acts of confiscating passports, mobile phones, and restricting personal and communication freedoms — actions that violate human rights and international norms."

Kenya defended its deci-

sion to deport the Taiwanese nationals. Foreign Ministry Principal Secretary Korir Sing'oei said his country's foreign policy "recognises only one China." "Any person purporting to hold a Taiwanese passport would ordinarily not be allowed through our borders for lacking proper documentation and would not in any event be part of a formal state meeting convened by Kenya Government," Sing'oei added.

Kenya is hosting the annual oceans conference, which focuses on addressing critical ocean issues, including climate change, biodiversity and pollution. (AP)

Pakistan extends airspace ban on Indian aircrafts by a month



M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Pakistan on Wednesday extended its airspace restrictions on Indian-registered aircraft for yet another month till July 24. The restrictions were first imposed in April 2025, a day after terrorists killed 26 people in Jammu and Kashmir's Pahalgam, leading to a stand-off between the two nuclear-powered countries, which culminated in a four-day military conflict. India has also slapped similar restrictions on Pakistani aircraft for using its airspace. "The ban on Indian aircraft — both civil and

military — will remain in effect from 5:50 pm June 16 until 4:59 am July 24," the Pakistan Airports Authority said in a notice issued on Wednesday. While military tensions have eased between the two, diplomatic relations remain strained with both sides continuing with retaliatory measures introduced during the crisis. The prolonged airspace closure is expected to increase operational costs for Indian airline companies, many of which have been forced to take longer routes to destinations in Central Asia, Europe, West Asia and North America. (PTI)

UK restaurant calls for India's intervention against eviction

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Veeraswamy, one of the world's oldest Indian restaurants, has appealed the Indian Government to intervene against its forced removal from its iconic London location, which once welcomed Mahatma Gandhi.

The Michelin-starred diner, which recently celebrated 100 years since it first opened its doors at Victory House on Regent Street in March 1926, is set for a legal battle over its lease at the end of the month.

Building landlord, the Crown Estate, has maintained that "comprehensive refurbishment" requirements mean it is unable to renew the historic restaurant's lease.

"Even at this late stage, we would urge the Government of India to consider interven-



ing on behalf of Indian cuisine — the country's soft power in the UK," said Ranjit Mathrani of MW Eat, the group that owns Veeraswamy.

He pointed out that given the strength of the India-UK bilateral relationship and the Free Trade Agreement (FTA) approaching implementation, it would be disappointing to see a slice of Indian

history disappearing from the very heart of London.

"Veeraswamy is, after all, a shining example of culinary expertise exported out of India," said Mathrani.

The latest appeal this week follows an over 20,000-strong online petition urging King Charles III to "Save Veeraswamy" taken to Buckingham Palace by the staff and management of the restaurant in February.

While Victory House is part of the British monarch's property portfolio, the Crown Estate is charged with its management and generating profits for the UK Treasury.

"Our guests have included her late majesty the Queen (Elizabeth II), the Princess Royale (Princess Anne), and other overseas royals... heritage cannot be relocated, nor

can history be replaced," said Mathrani, who co-owns the restaurant with wife Namita and her sister, Camilla Panjabi. MW Eat claims to have submitted several workable alternatives to the Crown Estate (TCE) to keep the restaurant on site, including acting as project managers for the building's necessary refurbishment works and matching the rent expected from converting the building into office units. The company also challenges the financial arguments made by TCE, as the dispute is costing the British taxpayer millions of pounds in lost rent and legal fees.

A five-day hearing of MW Eat's case over its tenancy rights is scheduled at Central London County Court from June 29. (PTI)

Duterte ally removed as Philippine Senate begins impeachment

JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

A leadership standoff in the Philippine Senate ended Wednesday with the removal of an ally of former President Rodrigo Duterte as leader of the chamber, which will soon start the impeachment trial of his daughter, incumbent Vice President Sara Duterte.

With 13 of 24 senators backing him, Sherwin Gatchalian, an ally of President Ferdinand Marcos Jr, was elected Senate president. His rival, Alan Peter Cayetano, a key supporter of Duterte, conceded defeat. Both had claimed leadership of the Senate in the last two weeks based on contrasting legal interpretations of the quorum that led to their elections.

An allied senator of Cayetano, however, defected Wednesday and gave his rivals' bloc a clear majority. "It's a relief," Jean Franco, a political professor at the state-



run University of the Philippines said, but added that the country's democracy, "with its weak and fragile institutions," faces more headwinds.

The Senate infighting has been perceived as being swayed by the long-running political disputes between Marcos and Vice President Duterte. The country's top two leaders were once allies but had a bitter falling out in a high-profile dispute that reflects the divisions and turbulent politics long plaguing the Asian democracy. (AP)

Nepal Govt wants stronger ties with India, China: Nepalese Foreign Minister Khanal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

The Nepal Government wants to have "stronger ties" with India and China, Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal said as he wrapped up his four-day visit to Beijing on Wednesday.

During the visit, Khanal held comprehensive and in-depth talks with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi and senior political leaders, Wang Huning, the chairman of the National Committee of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC), and Liu Haixing, Minister of the International Department of the ruling Communist Party of China. Khanal's visit to Beijing fol-



Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal

lowed closely on his trip to India during which he said his Government would accord "highest priority" to relations with New Delhi.

Asked whether the visits to New Delhi and Beijing were aimed at striking a balance

between Nepal's two big neighbours, Khanal said both India and China are vital partners to the Himalayan country. The Balendra Shah-led Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) replaced the prolonged rule of pro-China Communist

Parties after a landslide victory in the general election in March. "My visit was to indicate the importance that we give to both countries and we want to build on our existing relationship and also make it stronger and better and deeper than what has been in the past," he told state-run the Global Times.

The fall of the Communist Party of Nepal (UML) government headed by pro-Beijing leader K P Sharma Oli following the massive Gen Z movement and massive victory of the little known RSP has caused apprehension here about the future course of ties between Nepal and China. After talks with Wang, Khanal said he held a "com-

prehensive discussion" with his Chinese counterpart "on the entire gamut of bilateral relations, including in the areas of connectivity, border management, trade, technology transfer and multilateral cooperation".

He also assured Wang that Nepal remains firmly committed to the one-China policy, supports China's efforts to achieve complete reunification, and will never allow any forces to use Nepal's territory to undermine China's interests.

Reports in the Nepalese media said during the talks with Khanal, Chinese officials had raised concerns over Western influence in Nepal, mostly about the USD

500 million American Millennium Challenge Corporation and State Partnership Programme, MCC-Compact.

When asked for its reaction to the report, the Chinese Foreign Ministry told PTI that international development cooperation should adhere to the principles of mutual respect and equality.

"It should not interfere in the internal affairs of other countries, impose any political conditions, engage in 'coercive diplomacy', or undermine the sovereignty and interests of other countries for one's own selfish gain," it said. Khanal told Global Times that Nepal is grateful for assistance from

the Chinese government and hopes to build a strong relationship with China, identifying connectivity and infrastructure as top priorities for bilateral cooperation with China. He also discussed the Trans-Himalayan Multi-Dimensional Connectivity Network between Nepal and China which includes the cross-border transmission line and cross-border rail as core projects.

A feasibility study for the railway project has been completed by the Chinese side, and Nepal expects to receive it by the end of this month. Issues like border facilities, freight corridors and capacity building will be based on this report, he told the daily.



Growing older, living better: Role of yoga in healthy ageing

Living a better life is not merely our wish — it is our right. While ageing naturally brings changes to the body and mind, Yoga and Swasthavritta can help us maintain our well-being, preserve our independence, and lead active, healthy, and dignified lives.



PROF (DR) KASHINATH SAMAGANDI

Ageing is an inevitable process, but how we age is shaped by the choices we make throughout our lives. With the increasing life expectancy across the world, the focus has now shifted from merely extending lifespan to enduring the idea of healthy living. Leading up to the same, the theme of the International Day of Yoga 2026 — “Yoga for Healthy Ageing” — highlights the role of Yoga in promoting physical resilience, mental well-being, and graceful ageing.

Yoga has been an integral part of India's cultural heritage for centuries. Following India's proposal at the United Nations, the world began celebrating the International Day of Yoga in 2015. Since then, millions across the globe have embraced Yoga as a holistic approach to enhancing physical, mental, and emotional well-being.

As life expectancy increases, ensuring that older adults remain independent, active, and socially engaged has become a health imperative.

With India being home to one of the world's largest young populations, it is important to adopt healthy lifestyle practices early in life to delay the onset of age-related illness. The World Health Organization defines healthy ageing as the process of developing and maintaining the functional ability that enables well-being in older age.

Classical Ayurveda texts acknowledge ageing as a natural process that cannot be prevented. As stated in the Sharangadhara Samhita-

Ayurveda describes ageing (Jara) as a Swabhav Vikara- a natural phenomenon of life. It distinguishes between Kalaja Jara, the timely and physiological ageing process, and the Akalaja Jara, premature ageing resulting from improper diet, sedentary lifestyle, chronic stress, and other lifestyle factors.

While ageing is inevitable, premature ageing is modifiable through healthy lifestyle prac-



tices, with Yoga serving as one of the most accessible tools for promoting longevity.

Advancing age is often accompanied by several health challenges like insomnia, constipation, indigestion, arthritis, and hypertension, and gradually these diseases tend to worsen with age. To effectively deal with these issues, one needs to integrate Yogic practices into their lifestyle.

Neuroimaging studies indicate that Chanting “Om ” influences brain regions involved in emotional processing. It stimulates the

attention-regulating networks in the prefrontal cortex. Also, its calming effect deactivates the anterior cingulate cortex while the anterior cerebral cortex shows activation patterns.

Advancing age is often accompanied by sarcopenia, characterised by a progressive decline in muscle mass and strength, alongside degenerative conditions such as osteoarthritis. Regular Yoga can improve flexibility, preserve muscle function, strengthen supporting structures around joints, and enhance balance, thereby

reducing the risk of falls and functional dependence.

Chronic stress contributes significantly to hypertension through sustained activation of stress pathways. Practices such as Bhramari and Anulom-Vilom Pranayama may promote relaxation and autonomic balance, supporting healthy blood pressure regulation as part of a comprehensive lifestyle approach.

Constipation and digestive health discomfort are common concerns in older adults.

Certain Yoga postures, such as Vajrasana, Padahasthasana, Paschimottanasana and Ardha Matsyendrasana, involve gentle compression and the release of the abdominal region, which may promote digestive comfort, support bowel regularity, and contribute to gastrointestinal well-being. Reduced stress and improved autonomic regulation associated with Yoga may further support healthy gut function.

Sleep disturbances frequently accompany ageing and can adversely affect cognition, mood, and overall quality of life. Meditation and Pranayama practices may help reduce stress and

improve sleep quality. Emerging evidence also suggests that Yoga may support attention, emotional regulation, and memory functions.

Women undergoing menopausal transition may experience hot flashes, sleep disturbances, mood changes, and reduced quality of life. Evidence suggests that Yoga-based interventions may help alleviate some menopausal symptoms and improve psychological well-being during this phase.

Yoga may also serve as an important adjunct in the management of non-communicable diseases such as diabetes and hypertension, conditions that become increasingly prevalent with age.

Although genetic disposition influences disease risk, lifestyle practices, including Yoga have been shown to positively affect pathways associated with stress regulation and inflammation, highlighting the potential of behavioural interventions in promoting healthy ageing.

Healthy ageing extends beyond isolated exercise sessions.

Ayurveda advocates Swasthavritta, a preventive

lifestyle approach encompassing Dinacharya (Daily routine), Ritucharya (seasonal adaptation), balanced nutrition, adequate sleep, physical activity, and mental hygiene.

Rising during Brahma Muhurta, engaging in gentle Yoga and Pranayama, consuming freshly prepared meals at regular intervals, maintaining social connections, and cultivating gratitude contribute towards vitality in later years.

Healthy ageing is not merely the absence of disease; it is the ability to remain physically active, mentally alert, emotionally balanced, and socially engaged throughout the later years of life. While ageing is a natural process, premature decline can be avoided.

By embracing Yoga alongside Swasthavritta from an early age, individuals can aspire not only to live longer but to live better with dignity, independence, and a sense of well-being.

(Prof (Dr) Kashinath Samagandi holds a BAMS degree, an MD and a PhD in Swasthavritta and Yoga, along with a Diploma in Nutrition and Health Education and a Diploma in Yoga and Naturopathy)

Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu to lead Yoga Day event at Baansera Park on June 21

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu will lead Yoga Day celebrations on June 21 from Baansera Park near ITO. The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) is organising celebrations of the 12th International Day of Yoga at 29 locations across the city, including other parks and green spaces under it, according to a statement.

“The programmes will comprise Yoga asanas, pranayama, breathing exercises, meditation and wellness activities under the guidance of trained instructors,” a statement said. This year, the theme for celebrations is “Yoga for Healthy Ageing”, highlighting the role of Yoga in enhancing physical, mental and emotional well-being across all age groups.

“Through its extensive network of sports complexes, public parks and green spaces, DDA will facilitate large-scale



public participation in the observance, reinforcing the message of healthy living, physical fitness and holistic well-being,” it added.

Sandhu will lead the Yoga celebrations at Baansera. He will be joined by DDA Vice Chairman N Saravana Kumar along with other senior DDA officers and distinguished participants.

The programmes will comprise Yoga asanas, pranayama, breathing exercises, meditation and wellness activities under the able guidance of trained Yoga instructors

deputed by the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India. “Thousands of people from all walks of life, including students, sports enthusiasts and members of local communities, are expected to participate in large numbers,” officials said.

DDA will organise Yoga sessions in various sports facilities, namely Yamuna Sports Complex, Yamuna Sports Complex (Badminton Court), Siri Fort Sports Complex, Saket Sports Complex (Netaji Sports Complex (Jasola), Vasant Kunj

Sports Complex, Hari Nagar Sports Complex, Paschim Vihar Sports Complex, Dwarka Sports Complex (Sector-11), Major Dhyan Chand Sports Complex (Ashok Vihar), Rohini Sports Complex, Rashtriya Swabhimani Khel Parisar (Pitampura), Poorv Delhi Khel Parisar (Dilshad Garden), Chilla Sports Complex, Squash & Badminton Stadium (Siri Fort), Commonwealth Games Village Sports Complex, Dwarka Sports Complex (Sector-17), Roshanara Club and Bhalswa Golf Course.

Yoga sessions will also be organised at many DDA parks and green spaces including Baansera, Swarn Jayanti Park (Rohini), Coronation Park (Burari), Hauz Khas Park, Satya Park (Naraina Phase-II), District Park (G-17, Paschim Vihar), Ashoka Garden (Ashok Vihar, Ph. IV), DDA Park (GK-I), Vijay Mandal Park (Malviya Nagar) and Sanjay Lake Park (Trilokpuri).

Assam CM Himanta inaugurates PNG, CNG infrastructure projects in Mangaldai, Tezpur

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday virtually inaugurated a series of natural gas infrastructure projects aimed at expanding clean energy access across the state.

The projects include Domestic Piped Natural Gas (PNG) supply in Mangaldai, a CNG Mother Station at Uhani Pathar, a CNG Daughter Booster Station at Goraimari, and Industrial PNG supply to Patanjali Ayurved Limited in Tezpur.

The inauguration ceremony was held at Lok Sewa Bhawan in Dispur in the presence of ministers, senior government officials, and representatives of the gas distribution sector.

The newly launched projects are expected to provide reliable, environmentally friendly natural gas connectivity to households, com-



mercial establishments, and industries, while supporting sustainable development and economic growth in the region.

According to official sources, more than 100 households in Mangaldai have already received PNG connections, with around 30 families currently receiving regular gas supply. In Tezpur, where the PNG distribution network became operational in March this year, over 1,400 households have already been brought under its coverage.

The industrial PNG supply to Patanjali Ayurved Limited in Tezpur was also formally inaugurated. The company is currently consuming around 5,000 Standard Cubic Metres (SCM) of natural gas per day supplied by North East Gas Distribution Company Limited. Demand is expected to increase to 6,000 SCM per day in the near future. Officials said this level of gas consumption is equivalent to the LPG usage of nearly 9,000 households.

The newly commissioned CNG Mother Station at Uhani

Pathar and the CNG Daughter Booster Station at Goraimari are expected to improve the availability of compressed natural gas across Sonitpur and adjoining districts, making cleaner and more affordable fuel accessible to vehicle owners.

Addressing the gathering, Chief Minister Sarma described the projects as transformative initiatives that would strengthen Assam's energy infrastructure and contribute to the state's economic development.

Referring to global energy challenges arising from ongoing conflicts in the Middle East, Sarma noted that India had historically depended heavily on imported LPG. He said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had encouraged Indian refineries to increase domestic LPG production while simultaneously promoting PNG as an alternative fuel.

DAILY SUDOKU

		9		1				
		3				9		7
			9	2	7			
	5		3					
	6	7		5		3	8	
					2		7	
			1	6	8			
2		6				4		
			3		5			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

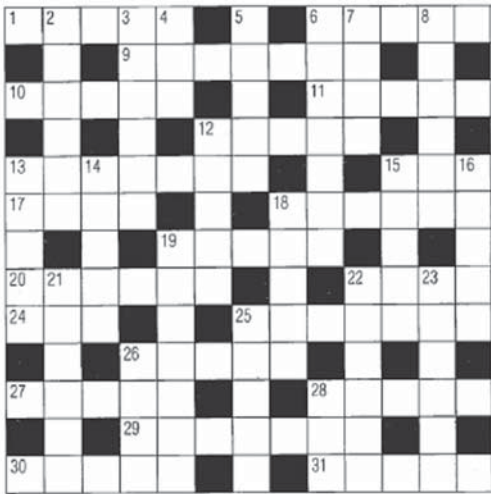
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (17.6.26)

7	3	4	8	6	1	5	9	2
5	6	8	3	9	2	4	1	7
1	9	2	4	7	5	8	6	3
9	1	5	6	3	7	2	4	8
4	2	3	9	1	8	6	7	5
6	8	7	2	5	4	9	3	1
2	4	1	7	8	6	3	5	9
8	5	9	1	4	3	7	2	6
3	7	6	5	2	9	1	8	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | JUNE 18, 2026



ACROSS

- You never see one wearing a hood (5)
- Remnants of wrecked bus on the street (5)
- Say something wrong (7)
- Do well, making money in the expansion of business (5)
- A drink before my game (5)
- Pass the ball? (5)
- Busy getting united! (7)
- Shoemaking tool? (3)
- Stravinsky's operatic prince? (4)
- Engagement with a playful little man (6)
- Song of the South (5)

DOWN

- Not being busy, I'd fish (6)
- One thus has to exclude this line (6)
- Wood used in model making (3)
- Like every single person (5)
- You may get it with a smile in the Army and Navy (7)
- Loyal, I agree (4)
- A growing degree of bamboozlement! (6)
- Make a start in radio at home (3,2)
- Fat lady engaged in rowing (5)
- Go a bit closer to a bird (5)
- The rent-a-staff man (5)
- Always, outside a theatre, you have to

- Adjoining Charlton, it's not far from Heathrow (6)
- Where the low soldiery can feel at home? (4)
- It's back for an early start to the match (3)
- Faulty loaf? (7)
- Female horse out of line (5)
- Cry when shut out for nothing (5)
- Let it change name (5)
- Naval hero? A beast, really (3,4)
- A piece of land in Wales (5)
- Looks and sounds like Samuel (5)

go in (5)

- Paisley's passage (5)
- Gave an article between two boys (7)
- It comprises scores in the freight yard (6)
- Like cattle, or big-headed sheep? (6)
- Get a better price for? (4,2)
- Dixie, like him, is apt to become heated (5)
- Think a fabulous female (4)
- Like the winning dog? (3)

SOLUTION (17.6.26)

ACROSS	DOWN
9. Leaves out	28. Ou-s-t
10. Ame-ly-th-st	29. Stupi-D
12. Pair	31. Dresser
13. Blocks	34. Followed
14. M-art-ini	4. Stock-Y
15. Right away	5. Pas-sage-s
17. Getting at	6. Hermit crab
18. Port-end	7. Char-lie
20. Desert	8. As-king
21. Str	11. Bitter-n
24. Re-veale-d	35. O-liver
26. Sub-tract	36. Launch
	37. O-rig-i-n
	20. Did (rev)

PROSPECT



Kaushik Rai, Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs, Govt of Assam, chaired an important review meeting of Mission Flood Free Guwahati with officials from Guwahati Municipal Corporation, Guwahati Metropolitan Development Authority, National Highway Authority of India, Railways and other stakeholders at Poura Sewa Bhawan, Guwahati

PIONEER PHOTO



Pabitra Margherita, Union MoS for External Affairs and Textiles accompanied by local MLA Bhuban Gam visited the exhibition at Garmur Banshigopal Natya Mandir, Majuli, Assam showcasing the transformative journey of 12 years of the Modi Government

PIONEER PHOTO

Subhash Chandra sells three acre bungalow for ₹1,260 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Essel group Chairman Subhash Chandra has sold a prime Lutyens' Delhi bungalow to an unnamed businessman for ₹1,260 crore in what is being touted as one of the costliest property deals in recent times, sources said.

The nearly 3-acre bungalow on Bhagwan Das Road in close vicinity to Connaught Place and India



Gate has been bought by a “Delhi-based business family”, the sources said, refusing to divulge the identity of the buyer.

Smile Foundation delivers 2 million healthcare treatments in a year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

From the high-altitude villages of Ladakh to the desert communities of Jaisalmer, from the river islands of the Brahmaputra to dense urban settlements, Smile Foundation has reached the milestone of delivering 2 million (20 lakh) healthcare treatments in the financial year 2025–26 through its integrated community healthcare initiatives.

Since its community healthcare programme began in 2006, Smile Foundation has provided care to more than 7 million people cumulatively. In a country where last-mile healthcare is shaped by geographic complexity, socio-economic barriers and an uneven distribution of medical services, Smile Foundation has developed one of India's most adaptive and community-focused primary healthcare delivery models.



PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE
File No.CE/R&B/ACCTS-10/26/152,
dt.11.06.2026

Name of the work: Annual maintenance & Development of garden in and around Port Township (Smruti Udyan, Nursery, JC Colony, GC and GD colony, Administrative building, Pump house premises (JC & Madhubani), and Balihara Water Works for the year 2026-27. Estimated cost: Rs.1,39,30,262.76. Last date & time of submission of bid: 01.07.2026 upto 18.00 Hrs. Refer our website for details <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.
Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Roads & building Division
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/16/2026-2027 dtd. 16.06.2026

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, देवास (म.प्र.)
क्रमांक /63/स्य.भा.मि. / 2026 देवास, दिनांक 15/04/2026
// निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना //

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्रीयकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत टेकेंदारों से ऑनलाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण <https://mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेन्डर क्रमांक जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की समयावधि एवं लागत	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं EMD	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
1.	2026_UAD_515996_1 15/06/2026	विभागीय कार्यों के संपादन हेतु फिल्टर सुपरवाइजर, इलेक्ट्रिशियन, मैकेनिक, वाहन चालक, हेलपर एवं श्रमिक टेके पर मेन पॉवर लेने हेतु ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा प्रपत्र।	12 माह 9,00,00,000/-	27,00,000/- 20,000/-	06/07/2026 6:00PM

नोट :-निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाईन <https://mptenders.gov.in> की वेबसाइट पर ही किया जावेगा, पृथक से राबीचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जावेगा।

आयुक्त
नगर पालिक निगम देवास

BRIEFLY

Neymar returns to action for limited training with Brazil



Neymar was back on the training field, returning to action for the first time since he joined Brazil's World Cup squad while nursing an injured right leg. Neymar still wasn't at full speed, though, and did mostly physical conditioning at the team's training camp outside New York. He had undergone tests on his right calf on Monday to determine the progress of the injury that he sustained while playing with Brazilian club Santos on May 17. The 34-year-old Neymar, playing at his fourth World Cup, has yet to join the rest of the squad in full training sessions during the team's preparations.

He is not expected to play in Brazil's match against Haiti on Friday in Philadelphia. The five-time World Cup champions began their tournament with a 1-1 draw against Morocco on Saturday in Group C. There was widespread debate in Brazil over whether Neymar, whose first World Cup was on home soil in 2014, should have been called up for the tournament by coach Carlo Ancelotti.

Christian Pulisic practices on his own during calf injury rehab



Christian Pulisic worked out on his own again during the US team's World Cup practice session while he rehabilitates his calf injury. A team spokesman described Pulisic as "day to day" after his second straight day doing individual workouts while his teammates practiced at the US training base in Orange County. The Americans' next game is against Australia in Seattle on Friday.

Pulisic was limited to one half of action in the Americans' World Cup-opening 4-1 victory over Paraguay last Friday at SoFi Stadium in Inglewood, California. The AC Milan forward was stellar in the first match of his second World Cup. He recorded an assist on Folarin Balogun's first goal, and he caused an own-goal by Paraguay with his playmaking from relentless runs down the left side of the US attack.

Despite setbacks, Aymen Hussein scores for Iraq in his World Cup debut

KYLE HIGHTOWER
■ Foxborough (USA)

Iraq striker Aymen Hussein was delayed on the way to his first World Cup.

He still made the best of his tournament debut.

Earlier this month, it wasn't clear whether Hussein would be able to compete in the tournament after he and another member of the team's traveling party were detained for several hours coming through U.S. customs in Chicago.

Two weeks later, Hussein scored the second World Cup goal in his country's history during Iraq's 4-1 loss to Norway on Tuesday.

Hussein also had a late own-goal, but Iraq coach Graham Arnold took only positives out of his star's effort.

"I'd rather remember his performance and the way he's played," Arnold said. "He's had quite a few



injuries during the season. For him to get through 90 minutes. ... He's the type of player that's very difficult to control in the box. I'm very proud of him."

Alzarri and Shamar back in West Indies squad

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ St Johns (Antigua)

Fast bowlers Alzarri Joseph and Shamar Joseph have returned from injury and were named in a 15-man test squad Tuesday for a two-match series against Sri Lanka.

Both missed tours of India and New Zealand, Alzarri Joseph with a lower back injury and Shamar Joseph with a shoulder ailment. The two are not related and are from different parts of the Caribbean — Alzarri from Antigua and Barbuda and



Shamar from Guyana.

Shamar Joseph is coming off a player-of-the-series performance in West Indies' 2-1 victory over Sri Lanka in the T20 portion of the tour.

The pair last featured together in a West Indies test squad during the home series against Australia in 2025.

Roston Chase will lead the squad, which includes the return of wicketkeeper-batter Joshua Da Silva, who tallied 996 runs across the last two seasons of the West Indies Championship.

"Every test series is an opportunity for us to grow as a team and strengthen our identity," coach Darren Sammy said.

Lionel Messi becomes 2nd player to score in five World Cups

DAVE SKRETTA
■ Kansas City (US)

Lionel Messi became the second player to score in five World Cups, giving defending champion Argentina an early 1-0 lead over Algeria on Tuesday night.

Making his record sixth appearance in the tournament, the eight-time Ballon d'Or winner found a crease in the Algerian defence and easily beat goalkeeper Luca Zidane for his 14th World Cup goal, sending a blue-and-white-clad crowd packed inside Arrowhead Stadium into delirium.

Moments earlier, Messi had a goal disallowed for offside.

Messi joins Cristiano Ronaldo of Portugal as the only players with goals in five World Cups.

MESSI HAS HIS FIRST WORLD CUP HAT TRICK

Kansas City: Lionel Messi registered his first World Cup hat trick while moving into a tie for first on the tournament's career scoring list, sending defending champion Argentina to a dominant 3-0 victory over Algeria in its group-stage opener. Messi scored his first goal in the opening minutes on Tuesday night on a nice feed from Inter Miami teammate Rodrigo De Paul, the second on a rebound early in the second

half. Shortly after he got his third on a strike from the top of the penalty box, he subbed out to a standing ovation from a heavily pro-Argentina crowd.

The trio of goals gave him 16 for his career, putting him in a tie with Germany's Miroslav Klose for the career record. They also allowed him to join Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo as the only players to have scored in five World Cups.

(AP)

Tuesday — and Gerd Muller of West Germany. The goal came 20 years to the day that Messi made his World Cup debut for Argentina in a match against Serbia and Montenegro.

Messi, who turns 39 next week, had been dealing with a minor hamstring injury with Inter Miami had slowed him in the lead-up to the World Cup. But he had no problems in a tuneup last week with Iceland, scoring on a penalty kick while playing 20 minutes. Messi's appearance against Algeria was the 200th of his international career, which began in 2005 at the age of 18. The only players with more are Portugal's Ronaldo and and Bader al-Mutawa.

(AP)



Ronaldo to make history by scoring in 6th WC

STEVE REED
■ New York

Cristiano Ronaldo, your turn.

The 41-year-old is set to enter the World Cup on Wednesday when Portugal meets Congo after impressive performances by the tournament's other top stars.

France's Kylian Mbappe and Erling Haaland of Norway each had two goals as they opened their World Cup campaigns on Tuesday, while Lionel Messi scored a hat trick for Argentina. That gave Messi 16 career goals in the World Cup, tying him with Germany's Miroslav Klose for the all-time record.

Ronaldo is also looking to make history by becoming the first player to score in six World Cups. Messi, too, is playing in his sixth World Cup but failed to find the net in 2010.

"Well, I wish him the best — I hope that he scores but not against us," Congo coach Sebastien Desabre said of the Portugal forward.

Ronaldo's focus has been on his team's success. "We go match by match, but not with the expectations of winning it all," Ronaldo told reporters in Portugal last week before the team's departure. "It has to be step by step. A good start is the most important thing." Some Portugal supporters question whether the aging star will be a help or a detriment to the team.

(AP)



Paying homage to Tim Cahill a World Cup tradition for Australia

BEN KULE
■ Vancouver

Twenty years ago, when Tim Cahill scored a late equaliser for Australia in its opening match against Japan at the 2006 World Cup, he ran directly to the corner of the field for a shadow boxing match with the corner flag.

Cahill's celebration in the 3-1 victory has since become something of a tradition for the Australians at the World Cup. Months after Cahill's retirement from soccer in 2019, Sam Kerr replicated the celebration in France at the Women's World Cup during a match against Italy.

Kerr, then a budding star, would go on to reach the



semifinals with the Matildas at the 2023 World Cup, co-hosted by Australia and New Zealand. In 2022, Kerr surpassed Cahill as Australia's all-time leading scorer.

Now, another young Australian is adding his own chapter to that lineage.

When 20-year-old Nestory

Irankunda became the youngest World Cup scorer in the nation's history, with a goal in the Socceroos' 2-0 upset victory over Turkey on Saturday night, he paid tribute to the man who inspired so many Socceroos and Australian fans before him.

(AP)

US official says Iran knew team would have to leave country shortly after match

JIM VERTUNO/
SEUNG MIN KIM
■ Washington

The US is pushing back on complaints from Iran's national team that it was forced to leave the country immediately after its first World Cup match instead of having a day to recover in a hotel, saying that was the plan for the team all along.

"We were clear this was the process," Andrew Giuliani, the executive direc-



tor of the White House FIFA Task Force, told The Associated Press on Tuesday.

Iran coach Amir Ghalenoei said after Monday's night's 2-2 draw with New Zealand that the team had been ordered to leave the US and return to its training base in Mexico only a few hours later. Ghalenoei said the team had expected to spend the night in California to maximise the normal recovery process after its opening game.

(AP)

Kylian Mbappe scores twice



STEPHEN WHYNO
■ East Rutherford (USA)

Kylian Mbappe passed Pele on the World Cup goal-scoring list and moved into first in the record books for France's national team.

Mbappe scored his 13th and 14th World Cup goals on Tuesday in France's 3-1 tournament-opening victory against Senegal. Those were his 57th and 58th playing internationally, tying and passing Oliver Giroud for the most in the country's rich history. "I play to make history with my country and help my team win the World Cup," Mbappe said in French, adding that he was thinking of his family, friends and loved ones when he scored.

Mbappe first scored in the 66th minute after having several quality scoring chances denied by goalkeeper Edouard Mendy, including earlier in the second half. He scored again from long range in the sixth minute of stoppage time, mere seconds after Senegal got its first goal.

"It was crazy," France defender William Saliba said. "We just conceded the first goal for Senegal, and just one minute after, we score a banger. I was so happy. Yeah, a crazy goal."

Mbappe's second goal broke a tie with Pele and countryman Just Fontaine and temporarily put him past Lionel Messi, who scored his 14th for Argentina hours later. Mbappe his goal celebrated by mimicking playing a flute, after comedian James Corden suggested that on his Fox show.

After scoring his second of the afternoon, the 27-year-old playing in his third World Cup is now tied with Germany's Gerd Muller, one behind Brazil's Ronaldo and two away from matching the record of 16 held by Germany's Miroslav Klose. "Of course I think he has everything to beat the World Cup (record)," Saliba said. "I hope he is going to do it in this tournament because for sure he has everything, and I'm sure that he will do it."

(AP)

Erling Haaland scores twice as Norway tops Iraq 4-1 in Group I World Cup match

KYLE HIGHTOWER
■ Foxborough (US)

Erling Haaland scored his first two World Cup goals, including one off a defensive blunder, and added an assist in his tournament debut Tuesday to propel Norway to a 4-1 victory over Iraq in Group I.

It was the 56th and 57th international goals for the Manchester City striker and came in Norway's first appearance in the tournament since reaching the round of 16 at the 1998 World Cup in France — two years before Haaland was born.

Leo Ostigard added the third goal in the 76th minute off a corner kick from Martin Odegaard. Kristian Thorstvedt scored the final goal just before the final whistle off



Haaland's assist.

Iraq briefly equalised just nine minutes after Haaland's first strike on a goal by Aymen Hussein.

But Haaland put the Norwegians in front for good just before halftime when he snuck in front of a poor back pass to Iraq goalkeeper Jalal Hassan. Haaland beat him to the ball, preempting his attempted clearance, and then used his shin to put the ball in the back of the net.

Haaland's first goal, which came in the 29th minute, came off a cross into the box from David Moller Wolfe. Haaland slid and used his right heel to finish it off. It ignited waves of cheers from the Norway supporters, who dominated the stands clad in red as they broke out in synchronized Viking row chants.

(AP)

Gill, Kishan star as India outclass Afghanistan

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Lucknow

Captain Shubman Gill battled intense heat and cramps to produce a masterful 154, while the increasingly confident Ishan Kishan scored a statement century as India recorded a dominant 170-run win over Afghanistan in the second ODI here on Wednesday to seal the series.

India have taken a 2-0 unassailable lead in the three-match series.

Afghanistan's decision to bowl first under the scorching afternoon sun backfired as Gill and Kishan, who scored his second ODI hundred in his comeback series, helped India put up a formidable 402.

Gill and Kishan put the visiting bowlers to the sword with a blistering 224-run stand for the third wicket off just 141 deliveries, completely taking the game away from the opposition.

Chasing more than 400 was always going to be a daunting task for Afghanistan, who were not only fighting to stay alive in the series but were also seeking their first-ever win over India in any format.

However, they were bowled out for 232 in 44.3 overs despite Rahmat Shah's fighting 79.

None of the Afghan batters showed the urgency required for such a chase. While several top and middle-

order batters got starts, they failed to convert them into substantial scores.

Openers Rahmanullah Gurbaz (41) and Ibrahim Zadran (21) were unable to provide the flying start Afghanistan needed.

Last match's centurion Gurbaz briefly enjoyed a slice of luck when he miscued a pull shot straight to mid-on, where Arshdeep Singh completed a simple catch.

However, debutant Prince Yadav had overstepped and the wicket was overturned, denying him his maiden international scalp.

The reprieve did not last long as Gurnoor Brar had Gurbaz caught 11 deliveries later.

Darwish Rasooli, who had been stretched off during India's innings, came out to bat but soon retired hurt because of the hamstring injury.

Prince (2/56) eventually claimed his maiden ODI wicket when he rattled Nangeyalia Kharote's stumps before ending the game with Rahamat's scalp

Arshdeep (3/45) picked up three wickets. Brar (3/60) also continued to impress while Kuldeep Yadav went wicketless.

Earlier, continuing with their experimentation ahead of next year's World Cup, India brought in Yashasvi Jaiswal (4) to open alongside Rohit Sharma (48), with Gill dropping

down to No. 3.

However, the young left-hander failed to make the most of the opportunity and departed in the second over.

Rohit, meanwhile, looked in fine touch and produced glimpses of his vintage best. The former captain was timing the ball sweetly and appeared set for a big score before being undone by a Rashid Khan googly that produced an inside-edge that clattered into his stumps.

Gill rarely put a foot wrong. The elegant right-hander mixed precision with purity of stroke-play, making batting appear effortless despite the challenging conditions.

He batted tactfully, and was severe when the Afghan bowlers tried to innovate. He drove fluently cruising to his ninth ODI century.

Kishan meanwhile provided the perfect support act before dramatically shifting gears after reaching his fifty. The wicketkeeper-batter, whose confidence has steadily grown in recent months, registered only his second ODI century and his first since the memorable double hundred against Bangladesh in December 2022.



SHUBMAN GILL
154
ISHAN KISHAN
125

Shafali, Mandhana script India's 95-run win over the Netherlands

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Leeds

Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma sizzled with the bat as India coasted to an emphatic 95-run win over the Netherlands in their Women's T20 World Cup match here on Wednesday.

The Indian opening duo of Mandhana (74 off 47 balls) and Shafali (55 off 38 balls) slayed a hapless Netherlands attack to fire India to 209/5, their highest total in the tournament history. The pair shared a 115-run stand off 70 balls after Netherlands put the opposition in to bat.

The Netherlands were never in the run chase despite promising knocks from skipper Babette de Leede (28 off 27 balls) and Sterre Kallis (18 off 13 balls) before being bundled out for 114 in 17.3 overs.

From India's point of view, the biggest scare came when off-spinner Shreyanka Patil was stretched off the field after twisting her ankle while fielding off her very first ball of the evening.

India next face a much

tougher opponent in South Africa in Manchester on June 21.

On her World Cup debut, pacer Nandani Sharma had a productive outing. She had opener Heather Siegers caught at cover for a memorable first wicket in her first ICC game.

Deepti Sharma, star with the ball against Pakistan, stuck



in her first over having Phebe Molkenboer caught at mid-off.

Netherlands' de Leede and Kallis played a few crisp strokes before departing in quick succession.

It was a procession thereafter as India completed the formalities. The wily Shree Charani was too good for the opposition's middle and lower-order and was also on a hat-trick in the 17th over. She was all over Netherlands after trapping Robine Rijke in her third over.

Kallis played down the wrong line to be castled by Shafali Verma while de Leede was stumped after missing a short ball from Nandani on the charge.

Earlier, it was a second successive fifty-plus score for Mandhana while Shafali completed her maiden tournament half-century.

Shafali was more aggressive than Mandhana in the powerplay during which India collected 59 runs.

The Netherlands bowlers were wayward and Shafali made them pay. Her aerial drive over extra cover off pacer Isabel Woning stood out in the first six overs.

All-round India A crush Afghanistan A by 101 runs, make tri-series final



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dambulla

A compelling all-round performance helped India A thrash Afghanistan A by 101 runs and qualify for the One-day tri-series final here Wednesday.

After amassing 319 for nine riding on fifties by skipper Tilak Varma, Priyansh Arya and Kumar Kushagra, India A bowlers produced a unified show to bundle out Afghanistan A for mere 218 in 36.5 overs.

India A thus snapped their two-match winless run in the tournament, while also sealing their spot in Sunday's final. The victory took India A to the top of the points table with four points and the best Net Run Rate of 0.597 among all three teams.

Sri Lanka A, who also have four points, are second with 0.494 while

Afghanistan A are languishing at the bottom with only two points and a NRR of -1.602. Afghanistan A, who will take on Sri Lanka A here on Friday in the final round match, will thus need a massive win to move past the hosts. Nishant Sindhu was the pick of the bowlers as he returned 4/31 from his 6.5 overs, while pacer Yash Thakur claimed 2/48 from his seven overs.

Anshul Kamboj, Vipraj Nigam, Suryansh Shedge, and Anukul Roy claimed one wicket apiece.

For Afghanistan, Bahir Shah (57 off 52 balls; 4 fours, 1 six) and Faisal Shinozoda (46) provided some resistance but most of their batters failed to convert their starts.

India A snapped their two-match winless run in the tournament, while also sealing their spot in Sunday's final

Sooryavanshi's outburst underlines need of situation management training

G UNNIKRI SHAN
■ Bengaluru

As Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's aura grows, sledging would be a routinely used tactic to unsettle him and the young Indian batting star will need "situation management" training to avoid losing composure like he did during a recent India A game in Sri Lanka, according to experts.

The 15-year-old is currently the most talked about teenager in interna-



tional cricket and as his footprint on the game becomes bigger, opposition teams will try to touch

some raw nerves to distract him. A prominent psychologist said the power-hitter needs to be prepared to

tackle the situation. "I have had the opportunity of working with Vaibhav 2-3 years back, along with a group of under-16 boys and he is a calm boy. So, the BCCI and the NCA (now Centre of Excellence), headed by VVS Laxman, already understand the importance of it and that is why players are profiled in sports psychology services whenever there are camps," Dr Swaroop Savanur, a prominent sports psychologist in India said.

Sri Lanka stuns New Zealand in Women's T20

FOSTER NIUMATA
■ Southampton

Sri Lanka crippled New Zealand's title defense at the Women's Twenty20 World Cup with a final-over comeback victory in Southampton.

Sri Lanka beat New Zealand for the first time in a World Cup after Nilakshika Silva and Kaushini Nuthan-gana combined for an unbeaten 48 runs off 28 balls to reach the 151

target with two balls and five wickets remaining at the Rose Bowl.

New Zealand has lost its first two group matches. Only one team in tournament history has advanced to the semifinals with two defeats - South Africa at home in 2023.

In the second match of the doubleheader, England earned two wins from two games after comfortably handling a spirited Ireland by four wickets.

Ireland struggled to 118-9 and England calmly over-



hauled that in 17.3 overs at 119-6. No catches win no matches New Zealand was tainted again by dropped

catches; six in the opening loss to the West Indies and three more against Sri Lanka.

Arjun, Veer to lead Indian juniors at Pickleball WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Arjun Singh and Veer Shah were on Wednesday picked as Indian captains for the U-18 and U-14 categories respectively for the Pickleball World Cup later this year.

The squads were announced after official selection trials held in Ahmedabad from June 12 to 14. The World Cup is scheduled to be held in Da Nang, Vietnam, from August 30 to



September 6.

"The Indian squad looks extremely strong and we are confident that we will be able to better our result from the last time," Arjun said. "Da Nang will be a true proving ground, and we have full confidence that this team will play with immense passion, carry the tricolour with pride, and inspire countless young kids back home to pick up a paddle," Suryaveer Singh Bhullar, IPA president said.

India look to continue winning run against Uruguay

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Auckland

A semifinal spot already sealed, a relaxed Indian women's hockey team would look to end the pool engagements undefeated to bolster its confidence against a lower-ranked Uruguay in the FIH Nations Cup here on Thursday.

Unbeaten India are atop Pool A with six points from two games and have already qualified for the last four, having defeated USA 3-



2 and Japan 2-1 in their first two matches.

India are determined to win the FIH Nations Cup to

get their place back in next season's elite FIH Pro League, from which they got relegated last year.

The Indian women's team was relegated from the elite FIH Pro League to the second-tier FIH Hockey Nations Cup, following its last-place finish in the 2024-25 season, after managing only 10 points from 16 matches.

The winner of the eight-nation FIH Nations Cup will progress to next year's FIH Pro League. Going into their final pool game against a relatively easy opponent, India would take heart from their fighting wins in the opening two games.

Ahead of Wimbledon return, Serena loses doubles match with Muchova

CIARAN FAHEYAP ■ Berlin

Serena Williams' comeback hit a bump with a loss in her opening-round doubles match at the Berlin Open.

Giuliana Olmos and Erin Routliffe defeated Williams and her partner Karolina Muchova 6-4, 6-4 to end Williams' involvement in the WTA 500 grass-court tournament at the first stage.

It didn't dim the love Williams was shown from the appreciative fans on what was her second appearance after a win at Queen's Club last week in London. That had been



Williams' first professional match since the 2022 U.S. Open. But her participation at Queen's Club was cut short when partner Victoria Mboko injured her knee in a singles match. The 44-year-old Williams

was welcomed by a huge roar and applause to center court at the Steffi Graf Stadium, which quickly filled up as fans snacking and drinking outside realised the main attraction was about to start.

Tunisia's Herve Renard embraces challenge against Japan

MAYA KOLUDER-RAMIREZ/
ETHAN WILCOX
■ Monterrey (Mexico)

New Tunisia head coach Herve Renard held his first practice with the squad, shortly after replacing Sabri Lamouchi, who was fired after the team's 5-1 thumping to Sweden.

The 57-year-old Frenchman had four days to get the team prepared for its second Group F game against Japan on Saturday. "At the moment we need to be focused on ourselves," Renard told reporters at the team's training ground just



hours after flying into Monterrey on Tuesday.

"We still have a few days to be ready," Renard led Saudi Arabia at the 2022 World Cup in Qatar, where the Green Falcons earned a shocking 2-1 victory over favourite and eventual champion Argentina. (AP)

Indian Jr women's hockey team to tour UK next month

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's junior women's hockey team will tour the United Kingdom from July 5 to 14 to play seven matches, including a couple of games against Scotland's senior side.

The Indians will also play against England U-21, USA U-21, and Belgium U-21 sides.

The tour will be India's first major international assignment under newly appointed coach Tim White of Australia and is an important part of its preparation for future international competitions.



The Indian team will begin the tour in Edinburgh, with two matches against the Scotland senior women's team at the Peffermill

Playing Fields, University of Edinburgh, on July 5 and 6.

They will then travel to Lilleshall, England where to play five matches at the Lilleshall National Sports Centre.